



"I could not put it down."

**—Marcy Dermansky,
author of *Hot Air***

**Kirsten
King**

A Novel

A Good Person

A GOOD PERSON

A NOVEL

Kirsten King

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For the girls who have turned breadcrumbs into cake

*Who has not asked himself at some time or other: am I a
monster or is this what it means to be a person?*

—Clarice Lispector

PROLOGUE

WHEN I WAS TEN YEARS old, I nearly pushed a girl into a gorilla pen at the Franklin Park Zoo in Boston, Massachusetts. Her name was Melanie Frank. She was the kind of kid who raised her hand to be team captain during recess and who always had a clan of smooth-brained followers around her. She wasn't particularly cute or well-dressed, but she maintained her place at the top of the elementary school hierarchy by making sure kids like me felt like gum stuck to the bottom of a shoe.

On the bus ride to the zoo for a field trip, Melanie had sat next to her friend Mackenzie: a duo who referred to themselves as "M&M," incessantly whispering and periodically giggling. I'd been sitting alone in the seat behind them when Melanie began to sniff the air like a bloodhound.

"Do you smell that?" Melanie asked Mackenzie.

I sniffed. I didn't notice anything outside of the plastic scent of the seat in front of me.

"No, what?" Mackenzie asked.

"I think Lillian farted," Melanie chuckled, glancing back at me.

A wave of giggles erupted on the bus, and various eyes flickered over to me. Passing gas was a cardinal sin in elementary school—a time when it was generally frowned upon for girls to have buttholes. I shifted in my seat, wondering if I should defend myself against M&M's false claims or stay quiet. I opted for silence and looked out the window as my face burned. After a moment, a sharp, egg-like scent wafted over to me. I realized that Melanie had used me as a decoy for her own foul actions.

I spent the rest of the field trip walking a few paces behind Melanie, burning an imaginary hole into the back of her blond head. When we got to the gorilla exhibit, Melanie leaned over the railing, blocking everyone else's view. Of course she thought she deserved to be the center of attention, even

when there was a gorilla from the Congo competing for the title. I craned my neck, trying to get a better look, but all I could see was Melanie's pink capri pants—her Hello Kitty underwear peeking out as her small butt swayed in front of my face. I glared at the sign that clearly stated: "DO NOT LEAN ON THE RAILING."

Did Melanie think she was above zoo laws?

I didn't think deeply about the consequences of pushing her before I did it. It was an impulse I couldn't fight; like Spider-Man casting a web, except I wasn't trying to save Mary Jane, but watch her fall. Mostly, I'd meant it as a joke, though when Melanie lost her grip and nearly plummeted into the gorilla enclosure, I realized others might not see it that way.

Our teacher, Miss Myers, caught Melanie's arm at the last moment, swinging her rag doll body back to safety. Miss Myers had mentioned to our class before that she did CrossFit, and I could see now that it was working. I felt a small pulse between my legs watching my teacher's strong arms ripple as she set a terrified Melanie down. Once Melanie was back on solid ground, my classmates stared at me like they were seeing me for the first time, except they weren't pleased with the results. I learned later that around the same time some kid had died in a London lion enclosure. I guess it was a sensitive subject, like a Zoo 9/11. I don't think they would have been so bothered if it weren't for that.

My mother picked me up from the field trip early, frazzled and apologetic. She kept pulling her hair in and out of a ponytail, a nervous tic I usually saw her perform when we were at the bank. My mother apologized profusely to Miss Myers on my behalf and then to Melanie's mom, who had shown up at the scene and was holding Melanie like her child had just returned home from military service. Melanie was loving every moment of the attention. After about thirty more apologies from my mother, Miss Myers said it would be best if she took me home for the day.

As we sat in my mother's car, the rest of my classmates stood in the parking lot, waiting for the bus to arrive. Apparently, the trip was over for everyone.

“Why did you do that, Lil?” my mother said, looking at me in the rearview mirror. “You could have killed her.”

“I didn’t mean to,” I said, my voice sullen. “And she’s a horrible person.”

This was true—Melanie was probably the worst person in my whole school—but I didn’t actually want to hurt her. I wanted to teach her a lesson about leaning on railings and falsely accusing people of passing gas, but ending her life, even accidentally, would only further alienate me from my peers. My niche humor and moth-eaten clothing had already established me as a weird kid. I didn’t need to further cement myself as an outcast by killing the most popular girl in my class.

“You can’t do things like that,” my mom said, itching at her neck like she might break out into hives.

“I know.” I swallowed. “I don’t feel well.”

My mother reached into the back seat and put her hand on my forehead. “Hmm. You might be a little warm.”

I loved being sick as a child, or pretending to be; I did the latter so often that they had grown to feel like the same thing. I loved getting wrapped up in blankets and being allowed to watch TV until my eyeballs felt like dry glass. Whenever my mother and I drove by billboards for Boston Children’s Hospital, I would think of how lucky those kids must have been—how much attention they got. Sometimes I wondered if it might be nice to actually get sick and die young; I would be remembered forever without having to do anything worth being remembered for. But in this particular instance, I just wanted to skip school the next day.

I watched as my classmates climbed onto the yellow bus while Melanie skipped hand in hand with Mackenzie to her mother’s car, apparently recovered from the event she had been so traumatized by only moments before. My mother idled in the parking lot, waiting for everyone to leave, as if driving on the same road behind Melanie would be another line crossed. I felt a deep pang of anxiety in my stomach. I wanted to be on that bus more than anything in the world, more than I wanted Nick Jonas to squeeze me until I popped. I wondered if I had ruined the rest of my life with one

simple mistake. I saw all of my futures turning black. I would never have a best friend with whom I became so intertwined that we combined our names into an acronym. I would never be the leader of the pack, or even a coveted follower. I would never be the kid you saved a seat for on the bus.

I would always be outside, looking in.

CHAPTER ONE

MY NAME WAS MISSPELLED ON the cake. That was the first thing I noticed. Instead of “Happy birthday, Lillian!” it said “Happy birthday, Lilian.” It felt like a bad omen for the year to come—like that missing *l* might derail everything. I stared at the pastel store-bought cake while my colleagues sang an off-key rendition of “Happy Birthday.” The loudest voice in the room by a landslide was my coworker Jessica, who had the vigor of a theater kid who’d been begrudgingly cast in the chorus and was fighting for her life to change her fate. Jessica was the company’s latest hire, and she was constantly asking people to go to coffee so she could “pick their brain,” as if that were a normal turn of phrase and not a deranged way of asking to harvest intel. She was fresh out of college, with more collagen and optimism than I had ever had in my life. I hated her.

I didn’t really have friends at work. Sometimes I traded GIFs with people on Slack, but I found it difficult to connect with the other women in the office. They all did reformer Pilates, drank matcha, and were invited to weddings every other weekend. How they knew so many people, I wasn’t sure. They were also all excellent at pretending to be passionate about our company, which was a small marketing firm called Fizzle that advertised themselves as progressive, as if having a white woman as our CEO meant we weren’t participating in capitalism the same way everyone else was.

My boss, Candice, who was second-in-command to our CEO, stood next to Jessica. Candice was dressed head to toe in red, with cherry Crocs to match. She seemingly had Crocs for every season, even ones that had been insulated for Boston’s harsh winters. The other girls at work often complimented her style, but I personally thought she looked like an emotionally stunted clown.

“Happy birthday to youuuuuu!” Candice sang.

Candice was mostly an okay boss. She had the kind of millennial guilt that meant she was generous with time off, and she once let a colleague stay home because she was “emotionally hungover” from watching *Squid Game*. I assumed her bright outfits and kindness would dull over time, but in my three years at the company, she had maintained her cheer. I wanted to like her, but she made me feel like a dark cloud waiting to rain on a corporate culture that was built on the back of a kombucha scoby.

“Blow out the candles!” Candice said, pushing the cake toward my face.

I smiled to the best of my ability and blew out the candles. I decided against making a real wish on a defective cake. I didn’t want to risk any cosmic wires getting crossed and making whatever I (Lillian with two *l*’s) wanted come true for Lilian with one *l* instead.

Normally, I liked attention, but today’s birthday was an exception. Against my will, I was turning twenty-nine. By now, I was supposed to have a skincare routine that didn’t make me break out. I was supposed to have a job where I made six figures and people didn’t talk over me in meetings. I was supposed to have enough underwear to make it through a month without dipping into garments I had owned since college. I was supposed to *throw out* my underwear from college. I was supposed to have a committed partner who loved me.

That part, at least, I could say I was working on.

“Who wants a slice?” Candice said, chipper, beginning to cut the cake.

The women in my office broke out into overlapping chatter of “Maybe just a tiny piece” and “A little sliver for me” and “I had a big lunch.”

“First piece goes to the birthday girl!” Candice exclaimed, handing me a slice that was so big it felt like sabotage.

“Thanks,” I replied flatly.

My coworkers wished me happy birthday and walked back to their respective desks with their paper-thin slices of cake in hand. I wondered if any of them would suggest post-work drinks in celebration, but the invitations didn’t come.

My performative birthday ritual was over.

I checked my phone to see if Henry—the guy I had been dating for the last four months—had texted me, but all I had were six texts from my mother:

Happy birthday!! Call me later.
Did you hear about the E. coli outbreak?
Don't buy celery.
Killed one person already. 😞
Some mail came for you.
Looks like junk.

Engaging with my mother was like opening a door during a snowstorm—any comfort you had could be quickly disrupted by the cold gust of air she carried with her. She was an extremely dramatic person who treated life like a telenovela, shrieking if a car cut her off in traffic or if she forgot her coffee inside the house. Every time she picked up the phone to talk to a friend, she let out a sharp gasp that left me waiting to hear if my grandma, a friend, or David Schwimmer was dead (my mom really liked David Schwimmer). Usually, these reactions only meant that someone had gotten a bad haircut or won four dollars on a scratcher. I didn't have the energy to engage with her antics today.

When I got back to my desk, I opened up an incognito tab and navigated to Henry's LinkedIn profile. In his headshot, his brown hair was gelled back, and he wore horn-rimmed glasses that looked like the kind you might buy at a drugstore in an effort to get a new personality. Henry worked at State Street Bank as a risk analyst, a job he had explained to me at least twelve times but one I couldn't fully absorb. When he spoke about work, I raised my eyebrows and reacted appropriately at the right moments, but, in truth, I had no clue what his position entailed. LinkedIn was the only social media Henry used and my only virtual connection to him. I had found his private Instagram account a while ago, but when I asked him about it, he said that it was old and deactivated. He insisted platforms like Instagram

and Facebook created a dangerous political chasm between mostly like-minded people. He claimed he could not—in good conscience—participate in social media because of it. In theory, I agreed with him, but not enough to exert any restraint over my own habits. Plus, I liked watching people I went to high school with get progressively uglier online.

Henry and I first met while I was out for drinks with my colleagues at a pub near Fenway Park. At work functions, you were supposed to drink a maximum of two drinks and be the most normal version of yourself possible. However, my coworkers were insufferable, so I was three drinks deep when I spotted him. He was at the bar sipping a whiskey soda and working on his laptop. He was handsome, but not so attractive that he felt out of my league. He looked a little bit like Bill Hader, whom I had always wanted to fuck. I approached him as I ordered my fourth glass of wine.

“Who brings a laptop to a bar?” I teased, resting my elbow on the counter and quickly recovering when it slid off the bar.

Henry seemed taken aback but smiled when he registered that I was joking.

“I’m just finishing some work,” he explained.

The bartender placed my glass of wine in front of me.

“Do you want to buy this for me?” I nodded to the glass.

Henry looked surprised but recovered. “Uh, yeah. Sure.”

I scooped up my wine and clinked my glass against his, nearly knocking it over. Henry grabbed his own cup, steadying it before it could spill onto his electronics.

“Cheers,” I said.

I returned to my colleagues, who were talking about the latest prestigious television show that everyone had decided was Really Saying Something. I glanced over at Henry, who was still hunched over his MacBook Pro. As the night progressed, my coworkers trickled out of the bar one by one while Henry remained. When they all were gone, I tipsily strutted back to where he sat, plopping down next to him. His cell phone was resting on the counter. I grabbed it, and his arm shot up to block me, like a strictly programmed robot.

“Relax.” I smirked. “I’m just putting my number in.”

Henry’s mouth fell open, but he didn’t protest.

“Unless you don’t want me to,” I said, raising an eyebrow to challenge him.

He didn’t answer. So I entered my number.

“Are you usually this forward?” Henry asked.

“No,” I lied.

Men liked to think that you were breaking your normally chaste rules to pursue them. They wanted to feel like you were virginal to the rest of the world and a whore with them. It was why I always made sure to say “I never do this on a first date” whenever I slept with someone on a first date. Men wanted to feel like you were a new car that only had a few miles on it. I understood all the ways in which this was a retrograde way of thinking, but it was the reality, so I embraced it.

“There. You’re welcome.” I smiled, handing him his phone back.

“Oh. Okay. Thanks,” Henry replied.

I walked out of the bar in the straightest line I could manage, imagining myself as a Julia Roberts character in a ’90s movie: hot, spontaneous, and with great undamaged hair that swayed in the wind behind me. I pictured Henry watching me walk away, shaking his head in disbelief at his luck. The next day, I realized I’d forgotten to close my tab and canceled my credit card out of laziness. A few days later, Henry texted:

You’re forward. I’m equal parts scared and impressed.

Since that fateful meeting, we had been consistently hooking up, though our emotional progress was slower than I would have liked. Even though we had sex weekly, he worked so much that he didn’t have time for dinners or much more. On weekends, he was usually busy working or volunteering. But after four months of seeing each other, I was ready to finally feel safe with Henry. I wanted to spend weeknights with him smoking weed,

watching bad Netflix shows, and pretending to listen when we told each other about our days. I wanted to relax.

My reverie was interrupted as Candice approached my desk, her Crocs squeaking against the linoleum floors. I quickly navigated away from Henry's page to my work email and squinted at my computer, like I was lost in thought.

"Hey, girly," Candice said, hovering behind my desk. "Any fun birthday plans for tonight?" she asked. "You know we have puppy yoga this evening if you're free!"

Candice often arranged team-bonding activities that were thinly veiled Instagram photo opportunities. At these gatherings, she carefully placed the few women of color in the front row of every photo. In the pictures she shared online, we looked like an ad for a diverse college campus that had no fat people. Since I was white and not hot in an otherworldly way, I was usually put in the back, so I avoided any team-bonding events that didn't at least provide free alcohol. I especially wouldn't be attending one on my birthday.

"I have plans with friends," I lied.

Candice smiled. "Aw, of course you do. We'll miss you!"

"Same," I said, fixing my face in a way that I hoped looked genuine.

"I did actually want to chat with you about something else if you have a minute." She squatted down so she was at eye level with my desk.

Was I in trouble? I had looked at porn on my company laptop so many times that I got a bug that IT needed to fix last week, though I'd assumed they weren't able to source where the virus had come from. Was she going to scold me for that? On my birthday, of all days? If she did, I would say she was sex-shaming me; using buzzwords to claim wrongdoing usually worked on people like Candice.

"You know how the Wellness Witch is coming in next week?" Candice asked.

I relaxed, relieved that she just wanted to talk about work. The Wellness Witch was a client our company had been trying to court for months. She was an unvaccinated woman who'd built her brand convincing people that

they could improve their lives through amateur witchcraft. On TikTok, she taught spells and potions, and talked about manifestation. She'd even sold supplements, juices, and placenta for a while until the FDA intervened. She had millions of followers, and every ad agency in Boston was trying to represent her for sponsorship deals. I personally found her nauseating, but she had dollar signs all over her, so it didn't matter what I thought.

I strained to smile. "Yeah. I'm excited for us to pitch her."

"I was actually thinking you could put together the presentation and co-lead the meeting with me. You've been here for a while now, and I would love to make sure I'm fostering your growth." Candice beamed.

"Co-lead?" I asked.

"I mean I don't mind doing most of the talking—I won't put that on you. But maybe you could put everything together?" she asked.

Candice was presenting me with a "learning opportunity," that thing bosses did when they needed to pawn off additional work onto their reports but couldn't afford to promote or pay them for it. I wouldn't receive a commission if we landed the contract, nor would I get credit, but if I didn't do it well enough—or if I wasn't grateful enough—it would be used against me.

"That sounds great," I said, silently seething.

Candice clapped her hands. "I knew you'd be down, birthday girl! I'll send you what I have so far in a brief later today, and you can start putting together the deck."

"Cool," I said, my mouth in a tight line.

Candice moved on to Jessica's desk next. "Hey, girly pop! I'm seeing you at puppy yoga later, I hope?"

Jessica spun around in her chair. "Hell yes! I'm, like, obsessed with dogs."

My phone pinged, interrupting any dark thoughts I had about Candice before they could fully form. It was Henry.

What ya up to tonight?

I hadn't told Henry it was my birthday. I didn't want him to know I didn't have plans on a day when I was supposed to be surrounded with gifts and a large group of friends whose entire goal was to make me happy. Plus, I did have some options: My mother had asked if I wanted to come home for dinner, and my college friend Jamie had asked me to drinks. I hadn't answered or acknowledged either of these invitations in the hopes that this exact moment would come to fruition: Henry would want to see me. I smiled. Fuck my defective cake. I didn't need a birthday wish to get what I wanted.

It was inevitable.

CHAPTER TWO

HENRY WAS DUE TO ARRIVE in ten minutes, though he was known to run anywhere from five to forty-five minutes late to our meetups. I stood in my kitchen, drinking a large glass of wine to bid farewell to the lackluster year that twenty-eight had been: the boring work, the mediocre friends, the unfortunate blunt bangs I had spent the better part of the year growing out.

At eight thirty, Henry finally knocked on my door still dressed in his work clothes, which consisted of a white button-up and khaki pants that gave him what appeared to be a camel toe. Oddly, it only made me want to sleep with him more.

“How was work?” he asked, taking a sip of the wine I handed him as he walked in.

“It was good,” I said, leading him over to the couch. “My boss is putting me on a big project.”

Henry unbuttoned the cuffs of his shirt, rolling up his sleeves and getting comfortable. “Hey, congrats. Come here.” He put his glass down and leaned over to kiss me.

Henry wasn’t the type to talk too much or spend a lot of time working up to sex. He liked to get right to the point, a trait I assumed helped him succeed in his high-pressure finance job. I didn’t mind. I didn’t need buildup with Henry anyway; I never stopped thinking about him.

Within fifteen minutes of his arrival, we were in my bed.

I didn’t have large boobs, but Henry did the best he could with what he had to work with. Usually, this meant spending a generous amount of time sucking on my nipples until I was certain milk or blood would come out. His head bobbed over my body while I lay on my back pretending to enjoy it. Sex with men was mostly a performance for me. As soon as my pants came off, I was a different person. Instead of a neurotic twenty-nine-year-

old with a mediocre job, I was a cool girl who was Down For Anything. I was the kind of woman who went skydiving and did polar plunges and flashed my tits in photo booths, yelling “Free the nipple.” I was the kind of woman who had a group of girlfriends that she called her “coven,” and who got hoisted onto hot men’s shoulders at festivals. I was the sexiest person in the world when I was fucking. I liked to be spanked and choked, and I once made a guy come using only my elbow. You can’t buy that kind of power.

Henry loved how sexually liberated I was. He’d taken one women’s studies class in college and mentioned it to me often, claiming it informed the kind of person he was. I didn’t really notice Henry’s feminism in practice, but I could tell he thought that being unshackled from the chains of society sometimes meant letting a man come in your eyeball.

The plan was for Henry to love me, but it was a careful journey to get there. My early twenties had taught me that men were fickle, easily scared creatures. Asking them to make plans a week in advance or suggesting that you wanted to meet their friends was like throwing a rock at a rabbit in the grass—it would be long gone before the stone fell. I had spent the last four months crafting a specific version of myself, a version that didn’t care that we never met up before eight and who liked listening to Henry summarize all of the *Dune* books. I was easing Henry into a full-blown relationship inch by inch, breaking him down week after week with good sex and carefully curated common interests. In the past, I had dated people in two-month stints, the situation usually coming to an end when I started acting like a person with feelings and not someone they’d met at Coachella. But I wasn’t going to make the same mistakes with Henry. I wasn’t going to let yet another relationship slip through my fingertips. And my approach had worked so far; as time passed, Henry had begun to mention friends and family who he wanted me to meet, as well as places we might someday go: our hypothetical future crystallizing before both of our eyes.

As I lay on my back, Henry gnawed at my nipples, which were growing sore from his suckling. I flipped him over and climbed on top of him. It wasn’t typically difficult to overpower Henry. We were nearly the same weight, as I tended to go for men who looked sickly—like they had just

emerged from sixteenth-century England. I straddled him, looking down at his pale chest and the one patch of dark brown hair that ran between his nipples. I yanked at the hair. I could do almost anything during sex, and he would assume it was me being kinky rather than demented. I loved that he gave me that benefit of the doubt.

“You’re so hot, Lillian,” he said.

“I know,” I said.

I didn’t always feel like a hot person in my regular life. I had a big nose and an angular bone structure that made my resting face look mean, and my hair was box-dyed dark reddish brown, so I looked like a Costco-brand Chappell Roan. I was also cursed with a boyish chest, but my green eyes and decent ass helped balance the scales. Sometimes I fantasized about having generational wealth so I could fix my flaws with plastic surgery, false eyelashes, and a constant stream of well-positioned injections. But I didn’t have those means, so I had to be savvier with my peacocking. I drew people in with my false confidence. I moved through the world in a way that said, *She knows how to fuck*. And I did. It was the thing I had spent most of my life trying to be good at. I might not have been the first person someone approached at a bar, but once they got a whiff of me, I was the one they brought home.

Henry grabbed one of my almost-tits, and I pretended not to notice when his boner slightly softened as a result. I moved his hand to my ass and felt the blood return. I slid him inside of me and thus initiated the dance we always engaged in when we had sex:

“Should we—” he said.

“Get a condom?” I asked. “Yeah.”

“God, you feel so goo—”

“I know,” I said.

“I’m going to c—”

I watched as Henry’s mouth turned into a little O, his eyes widening like a cat that had just seen a bird outside, before he came inside of me. He exhaled blissfully. I moaned in response, as if the sensation did anything to turn me on. Henry usually came in anywhere from thirty seconds to two

minutes. But I didn't care how long he lasted; it was flattering that he couldn't hold out any longer.

"Was that good for you?" he asked.

"Incredible," I promised.

I knew he wouldn't offer to get me off; that wasn't the kind of sex we had. I didn't mind. Orgasming during heterosexual sex was something reserved for long-term relationships with the kind of unconditional love that held space to tell a man that he wasn't remotely close to your clit. Henry and I were still building up to that. I could train him after he committed to me.

I rolled off of Henry and shuffled to my attached bathroom, my hand cupped under my vagina so the cum didn't spill out onto the floor. I closed the bathroom door behind me and sat on the toilet, letting out a small queef as I peed. I willed gravity to protect me from an unwanted pregnancy. I was admittedly irresponsible when it came to sex. I asked my partners if they had STDs and took their assurance at face value if they said no. I barely used condoms, and I firmly believed that the pullout method worked. This had led to one bout of chlamydia but luckily nothing more serious. I did have some standards; I only let men come inside of me after the second date, and I took the morning-after pill if they came when I wasn't on top. I had a strong suspicion that these precautions didn't matter and that I was sterile anyway. I had no diagnosis to confirm this theory, but my periods seemed to happen for show; the blood in my pads even looked fake—like prop capsules used in movies. I didn't want children, so this wasn't a devastating thought, though other people acted like it was. In college, I had once drunkenly told my roommate, Francesca, that I suspected I was barren.

"Don't say things like that. You'll want kids eventually," Francesca had warned.

"I don't think so." I grabbed another Domino's slice, dipped it in garlic sauce, and shoved it down my gullet like I was a competitive eater.

Francesca and I were not close roommates. We went out separately and only bonded when we both happened to be inebriated in our dorm room. I got the sense that she was weirdly religious, and she had so many

photographs of her brother on her desk, I assumed they had kissed. I didn't need her judgment on whether I should—or could—be a mother. Not everyone needed to bring children into the world. The only way I would want a child was if I became fabulously wealthy and could afford round-the-clock care. In my perfect world, I would see my hypothetical offspring for an hour each week, and during that time, they would profusely thank me for mothering them. Why should I act like it was a loss if I couldn't have kids? On the off chance I did get pregnant, the decision to abort it would happen quicker than Ken Jennings could hit his *Jeopardy!* buzzer.

“Relax,” I said. “It's not the end of the world if I don't have kids.”

“Putting that kind of energy out into the universe is dangerous,” Francesca said gravely.

Now I flushed the toilet, wondering if my own past infertility suspicions could make me sterile. I had read about magical thinking before, usually in relation to making good things happen. But what if I had the ability to make darker things come true?

When I got back to the bedroom, Henry was reading something on his phone.

“I'm going to jump in the shower,” I said.

Henry grunted in response, distracted by an article on his screen. I tried not to be jealous of the stranger who had authored whatever he was reading.

When I got into the shower, I quickly masturbated, internally replaying the scene from *My Best Friend's Wedding* where Dermot Mulroney sucks a ring off Julia Roberts's finger. It took about twenty seconds to get off picturing their sustained eye contact. After, I dried off and went back to the kitchen to grab us more wine. I returned to the bedroom with the bottle to find Henry sitting on the edge of the bed, fully dressed. He had only stayed over once before, after we split a fifth of tequila on a Thursday night. I had enough dignity to refrain from trying to lure him into another sleepover without a bottle of booze being the one to suggest it. But I wasn't ready for him to go just yet.

“Are you leaving?” I asked, trying to keep my voice sunny.

“I still have a ton of work to get through,” Henry said.

“Did you bring your laptop? You could work here, if you want.” I was aware how pitiful the suggestion sounded.

“I’m afraid you’re far too good of a distraction.” Henry winked, pulling on his socks.

I smiled emptily, resting my body on the doorway in his path. My arms felt heavy. I realized that I had downed four glasses of wine on an empty stomach and I was a little drunk. Thanks to the alcohol and sex hormones flooding my brain, the sight of Henry putting his clothes on began to feel like it was the end of my life.

“It’s my birthday,” I blurted without thinking.

Henry stopped moving. “What?” he said, shock registering across his face. “Really?”

I had made a mistake. He was going to think I was pathetic, that I was the kind of person who waited for the guy she was seeing to text her on her birthday, the kind of person who sat at home alone willing something to happen—who maybe nothing good ever happened to.

“I did a whole early-dinner thing with friends,” I backtracked. “Honestly, I’m sort of anti-birthday. I hate the whole, like, birthday-industrial complex. It’s a total cash grab.”

“Why didn’t you tell me? I would have, I mean, I would have thought you would have had plans with people. But I could have gotten you a card or something.” Henry itched his arm nervously.

“I wouldn’t have wanted you to!” I said, sounding like I actually meant it. “I don’t like people spending money on stuff like that.”

This wasn’t entirely untrue. I had gotten used to receiving shitty birthday gifts. As a child, I lived in a rented one-story home in Arlington, Massachusetts, with my mother. We had exactly what we needed but nothing more. We could barely afford to keep the heat on, never mind buy me the latest pair of UGG boots or any other gift I might have wanted. On my birthday, my mom usually made me something homemade, like a vomit-colored scarf or “coupons” for extra TV time. A birthday was just another day—a marker of time passing and nothing else.

“Really, it’s fine,” I promised. “I already celebrated.”

Henry exhaled, looking at his half-fixed sock. He pulled the other one on.

I wondered if I had ruined the night.

“Okay, hold on,” Henry said. “I’ll be right back.”

Henry stood up and walked out of my bedroom, closing the door behind him. I momentarily worried that he might flee before I heard him rustling in my living room for something. I was thankful my roommate, Elise, wasn’t home to witness my sort-of-boyfriend rifling through our common area. She often judged me for my brief relationships, probably out of jealousy because of her own involuntary celibacy. After a moment, Henry walked back into the room with something behind his back.

“Close your eyes,” he said.

“Why?” I asked.

“Just do it,” Henry said. “Trust me.”

I closed my eyes, my heart pounding with anticipation.

“Now open them,” Henry instructed.

In front of me, Henry stood with a lit Yankee Candle in his hand. The smell of artificial gingerbread cookies filled the room. I smiled.

“Happy birthday, Lillian.”

My heart swelled with affection.

“Now make a wish.” He moved the candle closer.

I leaned forward and closed my eyes. I thought about all the future birthdays we would have together. I thought of Henry throwing me a surprise party and taking me on trips. I thought of him sending flowers to my work and my coworkers admiring them. I thought of passing an older couple on the street and Henry pointing to them: “That’s going to be us someday,” he would say. I decided to make a real wish this time.

I would make Henry Davis love me, no matter what.

CHAPTER THREE

I SAT AT WORK MINDLESSLY dragging images of the Wellness Witch into a PowerPoint while I waited for my phone to vibrate. It had been six days since my birthday and Henry had yet to reach out. I hadn't texted him, either. I was impressed by my own self-control; I imagined it felt like receiving your first AA chip, except my only accomplishment was not being a loser.

I recalled our first date together. Henry had suggested we get drinks at a speakeasy in the financial district by his office. He'd said he would be working late and pitched meeting at nine thirty. The timing had given me a brief pause; I wasn't positive that he wasn't a dangerous person, and going out with a man after eight felt like a roll of the dice. He had also asked to see me on a Wednesday, which everyone knew was one of the worst slots of the week. After some debate, I'd decided to go anyway. I was more drawn to the possibility of meeting someone dangerous than making a frozen meal alone in my apartment.

I spent an hour on my makeup before the date, carefully painting my face until I didn't look like myself anymore. I put on a bra with a little padding, but not so much that Henry would feel titty-catfished if we hooked up later. The train ride took about thirty minutes, so I used the time to drink a small airplane shooter of vodka to loosen myself up. While sipping, I made eye contact with a twitchy, unkempt man who looked like he wanted to ask me for a swig. I chugged the rest and popped some gum into my mouth so Henry wouldn't think I was an alcoholic. I studied the other people on the train, noticing a young couple with a child. The woman had a big diamond ring on her finger and was wearing a cashmere coat, while the man looked like he shopped exclusively at Ralph Lauren. Their child was in an expensive stroller and was probably named Theodore or Brooks. I leaned

over to get a better look at the kid's face and was relieved to see that he was very ugly. It brought me extreme peace when rich people spawned ugly children. It felt like karmic leveling, like they could buy everything except a good face. The ugly baby smiled at me, and I gave a half-hearted smile back.

The mother looked up at me and beamed. "He likes you."

I didn't say that the feeling was mutual.

When I got to the restaurant, Henry gave me a quick side hug and said it was good to see me again before ushering me inside. The bar was so dimly lit that I had to find my way to my seat using my hands, as if I were navigating the inside of a haunted house. I looked around at the other patrons, most of whom were older men and what must have been their mistresses. Henry wiped his palms on his pants. I wondered if he was nervous to see me, too.

"This place is great," he said, looking everywhere except my eyes.

The menu was full of overpriced artisanal cocktails, each with a skull next to the name to indicate how fucked up it would get you. I ordered a drink that was four out of five skulls, wanting to get as wasted as possible without coming across like a five-skull girl.

While we waited for our drinks, we made small talk about which train I had taken to get there and the weather outside. Henry asked what I did for work and, in turn, explained a little about his own job. I didn't really listen, instead watching him spin his watch on his wrist and imagining what it would be like to be married to him. Henry was consumed with work in a way that felt stabilizing. He wasn't like the guys I had fucked in the past, who brought me home to air mattresses on the floor and their roommate's bong on the living room table. He was the kind of person I could actually build a future with.

"Do you have siblings?" Henry asked.

I considered lying. I knew that being an only child usually indicated that you might be weird and selfish. The image of Henry as my husband played in my mind.

“Only child,” I said, deciding it would be best to start honest. I didn’t want to have to hire a fake sister for our future wedding.

Henry raised his eyebrows. “So, you were spoiled.”

I wondered if I should tell Henry that I grew up somewhat poor. It was always hit or miss on how that kind of sob story landed with people. Sometimes it made them like you more; other times it made them not want to be around you, as if a lack of generational wealth could rub off on them. My mother had gotten pregnant with me at twenty-one after a one-night stand. Despite my grandmother advising her to get an abortion, she decided to keep me. My mom told this story often, like it was her hero’s journey. She said that keeping me was the smartest decision she’d ever made because she gained a best friend the day I was born. She didn’t tell me much about my father other than his name was Kevin and he bought her dinner at Dairy Queen the night of my conception. A few years ago, she admitted that she had looked him up on Facebook and learned that he had died in a drunk driving accident. She didn’t seem affected by this news, so I surmised that I wasn’t a baby made from love. This made sense. I felt different from most people; I assumed this was because I was made practically—like a genetically engineered tomato. I decided against sharing this backstory with Henry and instead agreed that I had been spoiled.

Henry and I talked a little more about our respective neighborhoods in Boston and where we had gone to college. Henry told me he’d attended Brown, and after saying it, he looked visibly relieved, like a weight had been lifted now that he could brag about it. I told him about my time at Simmons University, and he did his best to pretend that this education was at all comparable to his own. He ordered a second drink, ordering me a second one, too. The fruity liquid sloshed around my otherwise empty stomach. When he wasn’t looking, I pulled out a Pepto Bismol and swallowed it dry. I didn’t want to be gassy in case we had sex later.

After drinks, we went back to my apartment. Henry said his roommate was home and didn’t like Henry having last-minute guests over. That was fine; I didn’t mind pissing my roommate off.

When we arrived at my place, I tidied up quickly, throwing a half stick of deodorant under a cushion while Henry was in the bathroom. After he was finished, he plopped onto the couch and suggested we watch a movie, pitching David Lynch's *Mulholland Drive*. Henry claimed he was a big film buff and Lynch was one of his favorite directors. Apparently, before getting into risk analysis, he'd actually wanted to be a director. He added that his parents weren't outright unsupportive of this dream, but they also weren't dying for their son to be a "starving artist." I knew this was the part where I was supposed to share my own informed opinions on films, but the last movie I had seen was *Trolls World Tour*. I thought it was pretty good, but probably not worth mentioning.

"I've been meaning to watch *Mulholland Drive* for a while," I said.

Henry's eyes lit up and he excitedly grabbed the remote. Men loved introducing you to new things. They liked thinking of women as uninformed newborns whose connection with culture could only be achieved through a connection with a man. For most women, this wasn't true. For me, it was. The only time I read books, or listened to jazz, or watched old movies was if a guy I was fucking did those things.

We were about ten minutes into the movie when Henry moved closer to me. I took his proximity as permission to lean over and kiss him. He kissed me back immediately, but it was hard to find a rhythm. Our teeth clacked against each other and he used too much tongue. I put my hands on both sides of his head like I was holding a video game controller, and I started to stabilize him. As we kept kissing, it got better.

We moved to my bed, where I gave Henry my usual "I never do this" line and he kissed me passionately, like this was the most wonderful thing anyone had ever said to him. After about forty seconds of thrusting, Henry finished. By all accounts, it was a successful first date.

But now, almost four months later, I was still struggling to tie him down.

I tried to focus on my pitch deck, adding in another video of the Wellness Witch. In the video, she was teaching her followers how to communicate with their deceased pets. She claimed that by burning a piece

of pet hair and chanting an incantation, you could reconnect with your lost Pomeranian. In the slide show, I noted that these kinds of posts would be a good opportunity to partner with pet-goods companies like Petco, Purina, and Chewy. I wanted to die as I wrote the words.

“Keep it up!” Candice said, glancing at my computer as she buzzed by my desk on her way to a conference room. She was wearing a zebra-print jumpsuit with black Crocs, the kind of outfit I would only wear if I lost a bet.

I turned my phone over to make sure I hadn’t missed a text. There was nothing. I exhaled, reminding myself that these kinds of communication standoffs were normal with men, especially the ones whom I tended to like. A guidance counselor I went to in college said that I was attracted to emotionally distant men because I grew up without a present father. Going to the guidance counselor wasn’t my idea, but a requirement from my university after I was falsely accused of stalking a guy I had been seeing. It was honestly a funny misunderstanding: I had the code to his dorm, and he had hinted on several occasions that he liked surprises. I snuck into his room with a mini turtle I had bought at a pet store and took off all my clothes, waiting for him to return. I wanted to balance sweet (showing up with a gift) with sexy (showing up ready to fuck). He ended up coming back to his dorm with his parents, who were shocked to see me (and the turtle). I guess it was Parents’ Weekend, though my mother and I had missed the memo. His mom and dad were mortified, of course, and he was too embarrassed to admit he loved the whole scene, so he claimed I was stalking him. Afterward, the disciplinary committee told me I had to stay away from him and see the school counselor.

I went to my required session and learned quickly that therapy wasn’t for me. Everyone in my generation is obsessed with unearthing their past trauma and finding their “triggers.” My coworkers often referred to their therapists by their first names and spoke candidly about their sessions, like it was Monday Night Football. I missed shame. I didn’t want to do the work. I didn’t want to think about my mom forgetting to pick me up from school if a guy showed up for a date late. I didn’t want to think about my

dead dad while I put my finger in a man's asshole. None of it had anything to do with my ability to find love anyway.

I was well on my way to finding that with Henry.

I navigated from the Wellness Witch presentation back to Henry's LinkedIn, where he had recently reposted an article on ethical venture capital. From the little I knew about venture capitalism, there was no version of it that was ethical—but still, I appreciated this altruistic public endorsement. I made a mental note to bring up this topic in casual conversation later.

The worst part about liking Henry was that I couldn't trap him on social media in the same ways I trapped other people. When I was seeing other men, I carefully placed land mines online for them to walk into. I would add them to my Instagram story and then block every single other person who followed me, posting specifically curated content that catered to the object of my affection's interests. If they liked bowling, I would post a picture at a bowling alley. If they listened to Fleetwood Mac, I would photoshop my Spotify Wrapped to display it as my top artist of the year. I had enough dignity to block other people from this behavior; I didn't need anyone calling me out for the wide range of hobbies I was constantly cycling through. But Henry was off social media, which meant the only way to corner him was in real life.

It was incredibly inconvenient.

My phone vibrated, and I grabbed it with the speed of a precision chess player. I rolled my eyes when I realized it was just my friend Jamie.

Want to grab a drink later?

I considered this. I messaged back:

Can I pick the place?

Three dots appeared.

Totally!

She was such a sucker.

CHAPTER FOUR

I SAT IN A BAR in Cambridge waiting for Jamie. Cambridge was a random place for both of us to meet; Jamie lived in Allston and I lived in Mission Hill. There were a hundred bars between us that made more sense, which Jamie had pointed out when I suggested we meet at the Plough and Stars. But the Plough was adjacent to Henry's apartment. It was far enough away that I didn't feel like a stalker, but close enough that if he wanted to see me, I would be able to get to him before he changed his mind.

I spotted Jamie from my table as she walked into the bar, looking for me in a sea of drunk college students. She pulled her scarf off; her face was flushed from the cold, though she was still sweating from the commute. Jamie was the kind of girl who wore athletic gear like it was a conscious fashion choice and not her just being lazy. She didn't know how to do her makeup, but her features were nice enough that she got away with just mascara and sunscreen. She was an extremely symmetrical person, and she typically tied her hair in a tight ponytail that highlighted how well spaced her facial features were. She looked like someone who would be hot in her forties, but was boring as a twenty-nine-year-old. She was my best friend, though I would never tell her that. It was embarrassing to have such a boring best friend. We used to have a few other friends from college in our group, but they left the city in our mid-twenties, settling into long-term relationships and texting us less and less as a result. Jamie and I were both still single and thus bonded to each other. We were like used condoms in the ocean, floating around without a clear destination.

Jamie spotted me and motioned to the bar. I lifted my glass of wine to indicate I was ready for another, and she nodded. Jamie was a thoughtful friend who didn't mind that I dropped off the map if I was dating someone or deep into a rewatch of *The Real Housewives of New York City*. She texted

me often and didn't care when I didn't answer for days. I told Jamie that this was because I had ADHD, which I didn't have—though I did have a lot going on, so it wasn't too far from the truth. She would come over at the drop of a hat and could be easily convinced to trek across town and see an obscure band that I was only seeing because someone I wanted to fuck liked them. She let me talk about whoever I was dating as much as I wanted, and didn't seem annoyed when I never returned the favor by asking about her life. She once told me that her mother said she was a pushover, which I agreed with, but I steered Jamie against any confirmation that this was true; I liked her the way she was.

I had met Jamie in a psychology class. She let me copy her notes when I overslept, and she was probably the only reason I passed the course. Simmons used to be an all-girls school, and as a result, it had a reputation for attracting a lot of lesbians. I had a feeling that Jamie was probably gay and probably in love with me, though she hadn't admitted either yet. Her family was deeply religious, so I assumed there was a level of Catholic shame that prevented her from admitting she wanted to eat pussy. I was attracted to women, too—but not to Jamie. She was too kind and sturdy for me, like the eldest sister in an Austen novel. I occasionally fantasized about marrying her, usually when I was bored or fresh off a breakup. I imagined her cooking for me every night and letting me be a stay-at-home person. I imagined her working tirelessly to ensure my every happiness and orgasm. I knew she would be the ideal wife, but also that it would never work between us. The kind of women I liked were standoffish and obscenely hot—neither of which described Jamie.

“How are you?” Jamie asked as she settled into the booth, sliding my second glass of white wine over to me.

This opening was all I needed. I told Jamie about my difficulty getting Henry to sleep over again. I cushioned this by mentioning that we had made progress in other ways: He'd celebrated my birthday with me (the candle) and told me he wanted me to meet his friends (future planning). He was also constantly giving me forehead kisses, which everyone knew was a relationship kiss.

“Did you guys DTR yet?” Jamie asked.

I hated when Jamie abbreviated things. It made her sound like a desperate fifty-year-old trying to hold a job at a tech company. I usually called her out for it, but decided to let it go so we wouldn’t get derailed from the matter at hand.

“We haven’t had an explicit conversation, but I doubt he’s seeing anyone else,” I said.

I assumed I was the only person Henry was dating because of his lack of initiative with me. When we met, I was the one who’d made the first, second, and third move. I was the one who coaxed him out of his shyness. I couldn’t even picture him confidently leaning in for a kiss with another woman. If he was seeing someone, they probably watched movies together while she gave him bad hand jobs under a blanket. They probably talked about work and whatever thing piece was pissing everyone off that week, unable to form their own thoughts beyond the internet’s opinions. This hypothetical woman was probably such a forgettable human that she had to reintroduce herself to new people an average of four times just to get her name to stick. If he was seeing someone, it was nothing compared to what we had, and she was nothing compared to me.

“You only see each other once or twice a week, though, right?” Jamie asked.

“Sometimes more than that. There was a week he texted me, like, four days in a row and we had sex every day.”

“Gotcha.” Jamie sipped her drink.

“What?” I asked, my skin prickling with annoyance.

“I don’t know. It just sounds like he might not be ready for a relationship,” she reasoned.

“Because he doesn’t sleep over?” I said, growing irritated.

“Well, yeah. He could be seeing other people.” Jamie shifted in her seat.

“Well, so am I,” I lied.

I wasn’t sure how this made my situation any better, but now that I’d said it, I had to commit.

“Who?” Jamie raised her eyebrows, surprised.

Why was she being such a cunt? I reminded myself to be gentle with her. She was in love with me, after all. She was probably trying to sabotage my relationship with Henry for her own personal gain. But I was in control of where Henry and I were heading. I was a solid Boston eight and he was a soft Boston seven. Sure, we both wouldn’t even register on the Los Angeles or New York scales, but here, we were well matched.

“Just someone from Tinder. Only a couple times,” I said.

In reality, I hadn’t checked Tinder since Henry and I had started talking. I was never good at building a roster; I preferred to pour all of my energy into one person.

I downed the rest of my wine. I didn’t want to be around Jamie anymore, but I couldn’t bear the thought of drinking alone and waiting for Henry to text me. I had to make the best of the situation, and making the best of it meant getting a little bit drunk.

“Let’s get another.” I stood up. “On me,” I offered.

I had the patience of a saint sometimes.

AFTER FOUR GLASSES of wine, I was properly drunk. Jamie had only had two beers and was barely tipsy. I’d successfully turned the night around and was now having a great time, telling stories that entertained Jamie and, more importantly, me. This was my problem with dating and my friendships—a few beers down, I could have such a wonderful time with myself that by the end of the night, I struggled to discern how much I actually liked the person sitting across from me.

We were reminiscing about our old Simmons days, talking about the teachers we found attractive and the time our friend had soaked her tampon in vodka and gotten a yeast infection. I missed college, not because I missed socializing or bettering myself through education, but because my life felt wide open at that age. At twenty-nine, the directions where my life could go were quickly disappearing. I felt like Sylvia Plath lying under the fig tree, except the branches were dying in front of my eyes. It was too late for so

many things. I followed a few older social media influencers who insisted that wasn't the case; they said that the life you wanted could start whenever you wanted it to, but I didn't believe them. I couldn't be a sculptor, or an actress, or a novelist, or any of the things that I'd told myself I was going to be when I was younger. The path to becoming special was now muddy, overrun with competition. Instead of being important to the world, I would have to settle for being singularly special to one person. Preferably Henry.

I was about to suggest another glass of wine when my phone finally vibrated. I had placed it face down as a courtesy to Jamie. I wanted to convey that I was a good friend who was capable of being present. But the phone shaking on the table was like a siren call. I had to check it. I quickly flipped it over and saw Henry's name glimmering across the screen. A shock wave pulsed through me. Jamie smiled, trying to be supportive.

"Look who it is," she said emptily.

I slid open my lock screen and scanned his text:

What u up to

No punctuation. He was most likely drunk.

I opened up the timer app and set it to ten minutes.

"What are you doing?" Jamie asked.

"Well, I can't answer him right away," I said.

Jamie laughed and rolled her eyes. We made small talk for ten minutes while the timer counted down, but we both knew our evening was coming to an end. The energy had shifted from two friends in a bar to the kind of conversation you have with your dentist's receptionist on your way out of the building. When the timer neared thirty seconds, Jamie started gathering her belongings, like a bomb was about to go off.

"Oh, we don't have to go—" I said, feigning surprise.

"That's okay," she said. "It's getting late."

It was only nine. I knew that Jamie, who was a physical therapist, didn't have work the next day. She would go home to her studio apartment, feed

her fish (whom she had named after Lady Gaga), and watch hours of *Love Island* (UK), texting me stills from the television as she binged. Her life was almost as small as Gaga, her betta fish's. It made me feel bad, but not bad enough to stay.

"Aw, okay," I said, afraid to push back and risk her changing her mind.

She gave me a small smile. "I'll settle up at the bar and you can Venmo me?" she asked.

I nodded, though we both knew I would forget to send her money and she would never remind me. I watched her pay the bartender with a polite smile planted on my face. I gave her a small wave, and the moment she was out the door, it was like she had evaporated from my life. I looked at my phone, my body bursting with anticipation.

I texted Henry:

At a bar in Cambridge with a friend.

He started typing immediately. See? I had a choke hold on this man. Jamie had no clue what she was talking about. It didn't mean anything that we hadn't defined our relationship on some false timeline. We knew what we meant to each other. Henry texted:

Wanna come thru? Roommate isn't home

This was the first time Henry had asked me over to his apartment since we'd started seeing each other. The invitation was a clear step in the right direction, a sign that we were going somewhere. We were a few more dates away from him asking me to meet his friends and maybe a month out from meeting the parents. Soon we'd take our first photo together as a couple. Jamie didn't understand the intricacies of dating. Henry was basically my boyfriend.

So yes, I did wanna come thru.

CHAPTER FIVE

I RESTED MY HEAD ON Henry's lap while he played Radiohead on his record player. We didn't normally do stuff like this (not have sex immediately), but when I'd arrived at his apartment, it was clear that he was In A State. He told me he'd had a terrible day at work; he was passed over for a promotion that he thought he had in the bag. Instead, the title and pay bump were given to his coworker, a young Sri Lankan woman. Henry was tipsy enough to admit that he felt this decision had something to do with the woman's race.

"She's talented, sure, but I just feel like there were other factors at play," he said, burping.

This was one of those moments I was supposed to prove myself to be a Good White Person. I was supposed to challenge Henry's thinking and show that—even behind closed doors—I was thoughtful; I didn't post that black square on Instagram for nothing. I was supposed to show that I read more than one chapter in *White Fragility* and I was an Ally with a capital *A*. I was supposed to fight the good fight when no one was around to see me fighting it.

"Have you been at State Street longer than her?" I asked.

"Well, no. But I think I've accomplished more in a shorter amount of time," Henry said.

"Right," I said.

"She's decent at the job, but I put in way more hours."

I decided to drop it. I didn't want to ruin the mood by making either of us think too deeply about our own internalized racism. Plus, there was a chance his coworker didn't deserve the promotion, after all. Maybe Henry was right: Maybe he had accomplished more in a shorter amount of time than she had.

I scanned the apartment from my lopsided view in Henry's lap. His space was far nicer than I'd expected it to be, thanks to his job and probably some family money. Most of the furniture looked like it was from Floyd or West Elm, and the flat was surprisingly tidy, though sparsely decorated. I bet Henry's mother had helped him design the space. I'm sure she was the kind of mom who called this his "starter apartment," though it was far nicer than anything I had ever lived in.

Being here with him felt like a taste of what our future would hold. We would lounge in our shared apartment filled with well-made furniture and dish towels that we bought locally, not on Amazon. We would hang up art, blending our tastes carefully—like a coffee with the perfect ratio of cream and sugar. I made a mental note to deep clean my apartment when I got home and rip off any lingering IKEA stickers from my furniture. I would steal some nice soap from a restaurant bathroom soon, too.

Henry stood up and flipped the record to the other side. After a brief skip, it started playing "Everything in Its Right Place." I fought the urge to cry at how at home I felt. Henry went over to his bar cart and fixed himself a heavy pour of whiskey.

"What can I make you?" He motioned to the booze.

"Whatever you're having," I said, eager to keep my buzz.

Henry poured me whiskey on ice and handed the glass to me, glancing quickly at his phone before rolling his eyes and tossing it onto the table with a thud. I felt a brief pang of panic, wondering if I wasn't his first text tonight. I pushed this thought out of my mind. He was probably just commiserating with other coworkers. It didn't matter anyway. I was the one who was here now, the one he had turned to in his time of need, even if his time of need entailed venting about another woman's upward mobility.

Henry plopped down onto the couch next to me and closed his eyes, swaying slightly to the melancholic music. When he wasn't looking at me, I felt like I had permission to stare at him. I studied Henry's features and imagined him as a little kid. He likely played baseball in the front yard with his dad and had to ask his mom how many cookies he was allowed to have after dinner. I bet they were the kind of all-American New England family

that had an annual Fourth of July barbecue. I imagined they had a house on the Cape and owned a Boston Whaler. They sent their kids to Ivy League schools and wore expensive but unassuming clothes. They made their kids get jobs, not out of necessity but to develop a sense of responsibility. Maybe these people would be my in-laws someday. Maybe all the things that made them different from me would rub off on me until we existed on a plane of sameness that was put proudly on display in the annual family Christmas card, where we all wore white on the beach and smiled like we belonged in the back of a new frame. Henry opened his eyes and caught me staring at him.

“What’s up?” he asked.

I flushed, embarrassed. It was too intimate to look at Henry while he had his guard down. I sat up and climbed over his body, straddling his frame to distract from any overt intimacy he had caught me in. I leaned in to kiss him, noticing him stiffen a bit as he kissed me back.

“I’m kind of in a shit mood, Lillian,” Henry said, slightly pulling away.

I stopped. Had he asked me over just to spend time with him? Would we hang out and not have sex? Would he cry in my arms and tell me about work? Would we watch an old movie together and spoon? Would we talk about the things we had been avoiding, like whether or not he wanted children or if he believed in God? Was him not wanting to have sex with me a good thing, or was it a death sentence?

“How can I make you feel better?” I asked.

I flinched. The question had come out sounding more porny than I would have liked. In my head, I’d meant: “Should we watch old episodes of *The Office* together?” I’d meant: “Should we look up each other’s natal charts and determine our compatibility?” I’d meant: “Should we show each other photos of us as children and take turns talking about times we wet the bed?” But instead, “How can I make you feel better?” must have come out like “Let me suck your dick” because Henry started unbuttoning his pants. I guess he had changed his mind.

That was fine. I wanted to have sex with him, after all. My clit had been bulging out of my pants since I’d gotten on the Red Line. I was, by all

accounts, still down to clown. I put my hand on Henry's nearly erect penis and started kissing him. Henry wrapped his hands around my waist, lifting me up and carrying me to the bedroom. I was surprised. I had no idea that Henry was capable of lifting 138 pounds from a sitting position. He threw me onto the bed more clumsily than he had lifted me, but I appreciated the display nonetheless. Henry then pounced on me like an eager sixteen-year-old boy about to fuck Mrs. Robinson. He tugged at my still-buttoned jeans with frustration, and I realized he was drunker than I had thought. I kissed him slowly, trying to get him to focus on one thing at a time as I unbuttoned my own pants. I was glad I had put on good underwear, though Henry didn't seem to register it.

Henry flipped me over onto my stomach. I didn't feel ready to have sex from behind, but I moved my hand to my clit anyway and tried to get myself wet. When Henry started to shove his way between my ass cheeks, I realized he wasn't going for the door I had anticipated.

"Oh, I'm not sure—" I started, but he was already adamantly pressing against my buttocks.

My stomach turned. Henry didn't seem to be clocking my hesitation.

"Wait, slow down." I laughed, trying to sound sexy and light.

He kept pushing against me.

"Henry—"

I had been assaulted a few times before, usually minorly and not with a capital *R*. But you could always feel the air shift when it was about to happen. The person you were with suddenly wasn't aware that you were a person inside a body anymore. An animal-like hunger took over people in these moments, as if they were possessed. All the conversations you had had about liking bike riding, or making your grandma's Bolognese, or aspiring to run a marathon disappeared in an instant. Any context they had of your humanity had to go away to make room for their insatiable need; it was easier for them that way.

"I should shower first," I pressed.

He kept pushing against my body. "You're good. I don't mind."

"Henry, wait a sec," I said.

I didn't like doing anal. It didn't do anything for me other than make me feel like I was going to defecate on the other person, and not in a relieving way. I never felt clean enough for it, and even poppers didn't put me in the mood. I had done it once or twice before just to maintain my reputation as an Adventurous Person, but the truth was: I despised it. But I had asked Henry what I could do to make him feel better...I guess this was it.

"Hey, let's slow down," I said. He still didn't seem to hear me.

I racked my brain for an alternative I could offer him, a consolation prize instead of the thing he wanted to do. I wondered if I could wriggle out from under his sweaty body and make a joke about how I preferred to be in control. Maybe I could bring his coworker up again, hopefully softening his dick as a result. I thought about saying "no" loudly, and all the things you're supposed to do when you don't want to do something.

I opened my mouth, but no words came out.

Henry kept pushing.

So, I loosened my asshole to the best of my ability and I let him fuck me.

CHAPTER SIX

THE NEXT MORNING, I WOKE up beside Henry. He had insisted I stay over. My stomach was sour from the whiskey, and a dull headache was already forming, taking root in the space between my eyebrows. I remembered what had transpired the night before and hoped that there was no evidence of it in my underwear. I checked to make sure Henry was sleeping and then looked in between my legs. There was nothing out of the norm—no blood or other bodily fluids that could prove anything untoward had occurred. And nothing really had happened anyway. Henry had just gotten a little caught up. And could I blame him? I was the one who had initiated sex in the first place. However it went down didn't really matter. I was waking up next to my boyfriend in his apartment like we were a real couple; that thrilled me.

I glanced at my phone. It was 5:37 a.m. I pulled Henry's sheets up, covering my body. I was impressed by the quality of the linens and made a mental note to order new bedding before he came over again, hoping that my lack of adult blankets hadn't already been noted as a red flag. I turned onto my side and studied Henry's sleeping face. Maybe he would wake up and make me coffee from the pour-over I had noticed in the kitchen. Or prepare me an avocado toast after which we would shower together, laughing as we watched the suds run down each other's bodies. I shifted in the bed, trying to wake him. After some thrashing, Henry finally opened his eyes. He looked confused for a second; then a flash of recognition moved across his face, then something that looked like regret. I hoped that we wouldn't rehash the night before. He didn't need to explain himself. I waited for Henry to speak first.

"Wild night, huh?" he asked.

"Yeah," I agreed, trying to gauge his tone.

I wondered if you could get hemorrhoids from anal.

“Did you have fun?” He moved closer to me.

“It was a good time,” I said.

“Come here,” Henry murmured, pulling me into him. “I have fun with you, Lillian.”

I relaxed in his arms. “Me, too,” I exhaled.

Henry ran his hand along my cheek affectionally. We didn’t normally cuddle; Henry said his love language wasn’t physical touch, but rather words of affirmation—though he didn’t seem to excel at those, either. I scooted closer to him, enjoying the smell of his body odor. This was what I wanted: mornings together, the rising sun acting as a witness to our relationship. He kissed me briefly and then pulled back. I allowed myself some forbidden eye contact and smiled at him. In this moment, I felt like I might love him. Maybe we *would* have a romantic morning together. Maybe he would urge me to call out of work, and we both would call our bosses from bed, smirking to each other as we made our voices sound as nasal as possible. After a few minutes of making out, Henry put his hand on the top of my head and gently started to guide me down the length of his body.

“I could get used to waking up with you,” he said, smiling dopily.

This was what I wanted to hear: That he liked having me here. That he didn’t regret waking up next to me. That he was picturing the same life I saw unfolding in front of us. I moved down his body, hoping it might lead to something more romantic, and started to give him head. I wondered if he had rinsed himself after last night’s events, but didn’t want to ask and risk ruining our romantic morning. Within twenty seconds, Henry finished. He cuddled me a little bit more before springing out of bed and going to the bathroom to shower. I followed him into the bathroom and took the liberty of using his toothbrush without asking permission; mixing our dental DNA only further solidified our connection.

After a good brush, I went back into the bedroom and pulled on my clothes from the night before, grateful that I had chosen a sweater and jeans and not some sexy Lady of the Night attire. I glanced at the clock on my phone; I would need to head out soon if I was going to make it home to change before work. I wandered out into Henry’s living room, scanning the

books on his shelves, taking in the things I hadn't paid enough attention to the night before. Henry had an interesting mix of fiction and nonfiction. Half of the books seemed to be finance how-tos with titles like *Risks and Rewards*, while the other half of the shelf consisted of a mix of sci-fi and *New York Times* bestsellers. I pulled out a book and scanned the back cover. It was about a sex robot who develops the autonomy to fight back against her owner. It sounded interesting.

"What are you doing?" Henry asked as he emerged from the bathroom wearing a robe that seemed entirely too nice for a man to buy himself, probably thanks to his mother. Maybe she would get me a matching one for Christmas next year. I wanted to ask him if I could feel the fabric.

"You have quite the collection," I said. "Can I borrow this?" I held up the book that was in my hand.

Henry studied the cover. "I'm not sure you'll like it. It's sort of fucked up."

"I promise I'll return it, if that's what you're worried about." I smiled reassuringly. "I'm a quick reader."

This wasn't true. I usually read ten pages of a book, then forgot about it, only returning to it when I needed a good prop to bring to a coffee shop. I couldn't tell Henry that, though. I didn't want him to think I was stupid and undisciplined.

"Don't you need to go to work soon?" Henry asked. "You start at eight, right?"

I put the book back on the shelf.

"Yeah, I probably should," I said, though in truth, I still had a little time to kill. "Unless you wanted to do a quick breakfast?"

"I wish. I have some stuff I need to do before work." Henry frowned. "Sorry."

"Okay. Well, I had fun last night." I turned toward him, wrapping my arms around his neck. I leaned in to kiss him.

"I actually think we should talk," Henry said, clearing his throat.

"Okay." My stomach churned with anticipation. "About what?"

There was so much I wanted to talk to Henry about. We had barely scratched the surface of so many things. Maybe I would pitch going to the Boston Common together when the weather warmed up a bit. Maybe we would start watching a show together, like *The Sopranos* or *Suits*—something with enough episodes that there was an unspoken agreement that we were going to commit to each other for at least six seasons of television.

“I’ve had a lot of fun hanging out with you,” Henry began.

Was he going to ask me to be his girlfriend? I had assumed that he would do this somewhere more romantic, like a restaurant—but this was okay, too. I understood that he was busy at work and we had to enjoy moments like this when they happened organically. He liked me in my morning afterglow, smudged mascara and all. He liked my hair when it wasn’t brushed and my armpits when they were a little smelly. He liked my outfit on his second day of seeing it. He liked waking up next to me. He said he could get used to it.

“...But I don’t think we should keep doing it,” Henry said, interrupting my thoughts of our future house on Martha’s Vineyard.

It took me a moment to process what he was saying.

“What do you mean?” I asked, blinking too much. Was there something in my eye?

“I think you might be looking for something that I’m not able to offer right now,” Henry admitted, his eyes not meeting mine.

What the fuck was happening?

“Like...looking for what?” I asked.

“Like a relationship.”

I couldn’t tell if he was kidding.

“And you’re not?” I asked.

“I don’t think I’m in the right headspace for it,” Henry reasoned.

This was a tactic I had seen men use before. They pretended there was some deep, poetic reason they were unable to accept love. They took “accountability” for their unavailability—apologized for it, even—and then went on to date someone younger and thinner weeks later.

“You never mentioned that before,” I said, challenging this new narrative.

“It didn’t really come up.”

It dawned on me that he was breaking up with me.

After I had just sucked his dick.

“I just sucked your dick,” I said.

Henry swallowed. “Well, I didn’t want to say no to you.”

“You literally guided my head to your penis,” I said, my voice thick with venom. “It’s not like I was begging you for a morning bowl of cum.” I was growing angrier by the second.

“There’s no need to get mad. I think you’re a great person, Lillian.” Henry stood up and glanced at the door like a security team might swoop in and remove me from his apartment before I could make a bigger scene.

“What the fuck happened between five minutes ago and now?” I asked.

“I’ve been thinking about this for a while,” Henry said.

“Are you seeing someone else?” I demanded, remembering Jamie’s insinuation.

“Lillian, you’re being ridiculous,” Henry said.

I let the pleasant mask I usually had on around Henry fall completely.

“You’re at best, like, a fucking six,” I spat.

“Okay,” he said, slightly hurt. “There’s no need to be cruel.”

“And you come in, like...thirty seconds,” I said.

“Jesus, Lillian.” Henry took a step back.

“You probably don’t even know where the clit is...You’ve certainly never found mine,” I confessed icily.

Henry wasn’t supposed to end it with me. And he had no reason to. I had been the most accommodating, best possible version of myself. What more could I do? My heart was beating fast. My fingers were tingling. I felt overcome with some sort of divine anger that consumed my entire body. There was no going back now. I was going to snap whatever rope still held us together. I was going to burn him to the ground. Was this what it felt like when crazed Puritans burned witches at the stake?

“Your hair is kind of thinning, too,” I added.

Henry instinctively ran his hands through his hair, checking to see if it was still there.

“Now you’re just being a bitch,” Henry said.

“You can’t call a woman that,” I shot back. “That’s abusive.”

Henry scoffed. “Abusive? You’re actually insane.”

My phone alarm sounded, indicating that I needed to leave soon. I knew that the moment I walked out of that door, the dead bolt would lock and my number would likely be blocked. Henry looked at me like I was a woman on the edge. His body was tense, as if he thought I might pull out a weapon. I realized he was scared of me. It made my heart sink a little; the person who I had thought was on his way to loving me was now looking at me like we were in a live rendition of *Fatal Attraction*. Maybe that was fine. Maybe he should be scared.

“I was going to end things with you anyway,” I said, straightening my shoulders.

Henry rolled his eyes, unable to help himself. “Right. Of course you were.”

“I was!” I nearly yelled.

“Okay,” Henry said, putting his hands in the air in submission.

“Also, I’m not on the pill...and if I get pregnant, I’m going to keep it,” I threatened.

Blood drained from Henry’s face. Finally. This had struck a chord. I had no real intention of keeping Henry’s unborn child on the off chance his sperm was able to seek refuge in my cervical wasteland, but I knew it would scare the fuck out of him. I grabbed my purse and stood up, feeling like I had accomplished what I needed to.

“Lillian, you can’t be serious,” Henry said, desperation in his voice now.

On my way to the door, I turned back and looked at Henry like Jennifer Lopez looks at her abusive husband in *Enough* after she’s finally learned to fight back.

“I am,” I said. “Also, your coworker probably deserved that promotion. You’re kind of racist.”

I slammed the door shut, enjoying the final image of Henry's mouth hanging agape like a dead fish. I decided he was, at best, a four.

CHAPTER SEVEN

I CALLED OUT OF WORK after the breakup, citing a stomach bug and giving Candice more detail than she needed in an effort to really sell it. She recommended electrolytes, sleep, and the same brand of bone broth that Gwyneth Paltrow drank. There was less than a week until our Wellness Witch pitch. I knew I shouldn't use my limited sick days, but the idea of overhearing my colleagues talk about their loving partners—or seeing proof of their connections on a phone background—made me want to put rat poison in the communal oat milk. It would be better for everyone if I took some time to myself.

I spent the day in a bubble of questionable coping mechanisms, drinking my body weight in alcohol and only reacting to my mother's texts with thumbs-up, while I ignored Jamie's altogether. I was impressed with how undeterred Jamie was by my lack of response. Her last eight texts read:

Jamie—Friday 9:42 AM

omfg [LINK: Kevin Spacey says his persecution feels "very similar to what happened to Jesus Christ"]

Jamie—Friday 10:15 AM

How was hanging w Henry btw?

Jamie—Friday 12:23 PM

Or is it still going? X

Jamie—Saturday 8:15 AM

Breakfast of champions.

[PHOTO ATTACHMENT: A bird carrying a Twizzler.]

Jamie—Saturday 10:20 AM

Are you aliveeeeeeee?

Jamie—Saturday 10:21 AM

Okay checked your location so I know you are. Phew. LOL.

Lillian stopped sharing her location.

Jamie—Saturday 10:25 AM

Omg okay point taken! TTYL.

Jamie—Saturday 9:12 PM

Did u watch Real Housewives of Salt Lake City yet?

I hadn't decided how I wanted to spin what happened between Henry and me to my mother or Jamie yet. I had promised my mom on several occasions that she would meet him soon, so the thought of deflating her dream of a future son-in-law filled me with dread. I knew she would attempt to comfort me by recounting her own breakup stories, which would—in turn—make me feel worse, like I was biologically predisposed to being alone. Jamie, on the other hand, would take the pity route. Her eyes would bulge out of her head as she said, "*He ended it with you?*" Then we would launch into a list of all the mediocre men who had landed otherworldly women, like Lana Del Rey and that alligator guy. I knew they would both show up for me in their own flawed ways, but saying that it was over solidified that it actually was. I wasn't ready for that yet.

To make myself feel better, I made a list of everything I disliked about Henry:

Icks

has a flat ass
makes a dumb face when he's orgasming
thinning hair
clipped his toenails in the bathroom before sex (pro: they're short)
gets things stuck in his teeth easily
prob didn't vote
got defensive of J. K. Rowling twice
has a cross for a tattoo
adjusts his balls a lot
sat cross-legged on my bed once
saw skid mark on his underwear
has never taken me to dinner

I looked at the list, willing the empirical evidence to decrease my feelings toward Henry, but my desire to be with him still lingered. I felt like a failure, like I had taken a wrong turn, except I couldn't pinpoint where it had happened.

When Monday rolled around, I called out of work again. I told Candice that I was getting tested for giardia, to which she responded:

OMG. My dog had that once! Feel better.

I consumed three homemade martinis and decided the only thing that could ease my heartache was to stop by Henry's apartment. He wasn't home, of course. It was a Monday, just shy of two in the afternoon. He wouldn't be off work until six or later. I scanned the downstairs neighbors' apartment for any signs of life, but they didn't appear to be home, either. I walked around to the back staircase of the duplex, searching for a doorbell camera that I might have missed the other night, but I didn't see one. Slowly twisting the handle to the staircase corridor, I was pleased to find that it was open. I walked upstairs.

The door to Henry's apartment on the second floor was predictably locked. I twisted the handle and pushed my body against it, hoping my martini strength might bust it open, but it didn't budge. On the ground by the door, there was an ice scraper. I picked it up and wedged it into the doorframe, thinking I'd crack it open like a chestnut. Instead, I chipped off a piece of paint before losing my balance and slamming my body into the door.

I wasn't sure what my plan was if I got inside. Mostly, I just wanted to look around. I wanted to sift through his belongings and piece together what had happened between us, like a detective examining a crime scene. I wanted to take that book he wouldn't let me borrow. I wanted to sleep in his bed like Goldilocks, but instead of finding the perfect mattress, I'd have my boyfriend back when I woke up. I held the ice scraper in my hands, debating whether or not I should use it to smash a window, but that felt like a lot of work, not to mention a real crime. I was only interested in breaking and entering if it was fairly easy. But I couldn't leave without doing something.

I scanned the staircase for inspiration. As I did, my bladder began to softly scream. The martinis were catching up. I looked down at the generic doormat that said "Welcome" and, before I could second-guess the impulse, pulled down my pants. I squatted, hovering on the top step and releasing my pee onto the ground. It made a hissing sound, like a horse freeing a day's worth of water. I watched my pee trickle down the staircase, cascading like a dehydrated waterfall of vengeance, then drip-dried for a second and pulled my pants up. The staircase smelled like piss. I felt better already.

Outside, a car door slammed. I froze in place, considering the scene around me: the ice scraper in my hand, the pee on the ground, and the general drunken state I was in. I cursed myself for not putting on makeup before leaving my apartment, though I wasn't sure any amount of foundation could adequately cover for urinating on your ex's doorstep. I zipped up my pants and rushed down the stairs. Would Henry be home this early? Did he drive to work? I realized I didn't even know if he had a car. I hovered in the doorway, craning my neck to see who was in the vehicle,

which was positioned in the driveway on the side of the house and directly in my escape path. There was a possibility it was just the neighbors. But if it was Henry and he saw me like this, he would think I was a crazy person. He would get a restraining order.

If I ran now, there was a chance he wouldn't catch me. The driver rustled in their trunk, looking for something. Now was my chance. I grabbed the door handle and sprinted as fast as I could, my heart pounding. The martini gave me the confidence of a Division I athlete as I pumped my arms by my sides and ran toward the street.

"Hello?" said a startled woman's voice from behind me.

I was relieved that it wasn't Henry. I was tempted to turn around and answer the woman; to falsify a story about getting lost and wandering into the wrong apartment, like a dementia patient. Or maybe I could ask her what she thought of her rude upstairs neighbor. I decided it was better to flee. If I spoke to her, there was a chance she would relay the information to Henry; then the two of them would sit down with a sketch artist who would deliver a perfect replica of my likeness. Getting out of there had to be my main priority. I ran faster than I had ever run in my twenty-nine years, a little more pee escaping my bladder as I did. I waited for footsteps behind me to follow, but they didn't.

I was free.

CHAPTER EIGHT

ON MY FOURTH DAY OFF work, I checked my work inbox. I had three unread emails from Candice, which, while polite, still managed to be passive aggressive. A message sent just yesterday said:

Hey you, just wondering if you're going to make it in tomorrow. The Wellness Witch is coming in and I would love to see the deck beforehand. X

In my drunken haze and heartbreak, I had mostly forgotten about the presentation. I pulled up the half-finished deck and added a slide at the end that said: "Questions?" That would have to be good enough. I emailed Candice back with the PowerPoint attached.

Feeling much better. Be in at ten. 😊

I hit send before I could change my mind. I put some wine into a coffee mug and headed out for the train.

I DIDN'T WEAR concealer to work, hoping my coworkers would clock my under-eye bags and how tired I looked, prompting them to feel bad for me. I slunk over to my desk slowly, sighing loudly a few times on my way, but no one turned around to acknowledge me. Annoyed, I settled into my seat and turned on my laptop. Seconds later, Candice appeared behind me.

"How ya feeling?" she asked, her mouth scrunched in a sympathetic frown.

“Okay,” I lied, sipping my wine. “Finally able to hold stuff down, at least.”

I needed to numb myself if I was going to get through the day; I felt like my insides were going to leak out of my body. I feared if I wasn’t a little bit intoxicated, I might cry, or scream, or throw myself onto the ground and kick my feet like a child who was breastfed for too long.

I usually turned to my mother for comfort when I was heartbroken like this; I could always count on her to be more dramatic than I was. During breakups, she often would refer me to her tarot card reader, or her Reiki healer, or some old woman at the grocery store she had met who seemed wise. But I was delaying breaking the news to my mom. I wanted to live in the alternate timeline where Henry and I were still together and had the potential to work out. And perhaps we still *did* have the potential to work out; he just would have to grovel quite a bit. Maybe he would text me soon and say: “Sorry things got out of hand the other day. I miss you.” That couldn’t happen if I told my mother the truth. When you gave a mother information, she stored it like a scar.

“The Wellness Witch will be in at eleven,” Candice said, hovering by my desk. “I took a look at your deck.” She picked at her nails. “Was the one you sent this morning the latest version?”

“Yeah.” I took another sip of my wine. “I hope you liked it,” I said cheerfully, hoping that false confidence would cover for the fact that I had half-assed the project.

“Um, yeah. It was a great start! But I’m actually thinking that maybe we’ll keep this meeting more informal? Just so we don’t overwhelm her... Let her get a sense of our company’s general vibe, you know? Then, for the follow-up, I can do a pass and add a few things to what you started...” She trailed off.

This was the closest Candice had ever gotten to telling someone they’d done a bad job. Clearly, she didn’t think my presentation was good enough. And maybe it wasn’t, but I still felt deeply offended that she wasn’t going to pretend it was. Candice once high-fived my coworker Julie when she pitched that we hire an Adele drag queen to promote AIDS medicine for a

client. There were no bad ideas here. I did my best to put on an amicable face, both for Candice and my job security.

“Sounds great,” I said.

“Okay, cool!” she chirped, clearly relieved to have this conversation over. “I’ll see you in there in a bit.”

When Candice left my desk, I checked Henry’s LinkedIn. He had congratulated his coworker Amanthi on her promotion.

THE WELLNESS WITCH’S real name was Bekah, and she unforgivably spelled it “Bekah” with a *k* and an *h*. She was less pretty in person than she was online. On her Instagram profile, she appeared well moisturized and eternally dewy, a generous filter covering any flaws she might have had. In person, she was still pretty, but in a more human way. Her skin wasn’t quite as glossy; her eyes and teeth were not as bright. While she spoke, the wrinkles on her neck jiggled, and I wondered if she had lied to her followers about being thirty. She looked more like forty-five in person. Maybe rejecting modern medicine had aged her.

Candice had given Bekah a broad overview of our client list and the kind of work we did before opening the floor to Bekah to talk about herself, which clearly this woman loved to do.

“So, my biggest thing is radical honesty with the universe,” Bekah said.

Everyone on our team oohed and aahed in response, nodding like that made any fucking sense. This was how people in marketing were with their clients: They pretended like whatever abstract bullshit the person spewed was so impressive it might merit a Nobel Peace Prize. You could have two guys named Tom and Tim who had a seltzer brand called TT inspired by their dead grandma’s alcoholism, and we’d all have to pretend it was a touching story that deserved the \$20 million of seed money they had received from investors.

“You can ask the universe for what you want, and it can say no. That’s allowed! But if it says no, then...well, that’s where I come in,” Bekah continued.

I understood that she was probably a cult leader.

“I don’t believe in being a victim of your own life. I believe in grabbing life by the horns and riding it under the full moon.” She smiled.

I looked around to see if anyone else was registering her as cuckoo banana puffs, but everyone seemed enthralled. I took a big sip of my wine. I should have brought more.

“I make potions, tinctures, treatments—and, yes, even spells that address whatever your issue is with the universe. I think of myself as a healer, but really, it’s on all of us to heal ourselves,” Bekah continued. This got a big response from the team.

“So, you could help me get rid of my noisy upstairs neighbors?” Candice joked.

Bekah looked at Candice, deadpan. “I can help you do anything you want. My work might seem unconventional—even trivial at times—but the truth is I give people back control of their lives.”

The women in the room nodded, rapt.

“I can help you get things done that you’ve never dreamed you could accomplish. I can help you get the job you want. The house you deserve... The man who broke your heart,” Bekah said, looking directly at me.

I swallowed nervously. Did this charlatan actually have some kind of intuition about what had happened between me and Henry? She held my gaze. I wondered if she could sense the seismic shift that I was going through. I wondered if she could feel my pain. Or maybe she saw me as a kindred spirit, someone who also had the capacity to make shit happen.

“That’s what I want my brand to be: I want to give people their power back.”

I looked at my arm, which pathetically had goose bumps on it. Maybe Bekah was the real deal after all. Maybe she was a magical entity packaged in Reformation denim and an Anthropologie top. Under the table, I navigated to her Instagram profile, where she had 2.5 million followers.

I discreetly hit the follow button.

CHAPTER NINE

WHEN I GOT HOME, MY roommate, Elise, was in the kitchen cooking something that smelled vinegary and foul. Elise was technically not a bad roommate, but that didn't stop me from disliking her. She worked as a teller at Bank of America and seemed to have no aspirations beyond speculating about what might happen in the next season of *Bridgerton*. I knew that I shouldn't be judgmental of her lack of direction. I wasn't doing much with my life, either. But at least I fucked people and worked in marketing, which felt like the bare minimum you could do to maintain some semblance of relevancy in Boston.

"Hi," I said to Elise.

"Hi," she said back, flinching a little like a scared mouse.

Elise quickly transferred her meal into a small bowl that she could take to her room and put her pan in the sink to soak.

"I'll do that later." She nodded at the sink.

"Okay," I said.

This was usually the extent of our conversation.

Part of me wanted Elise to ask if I was okay. I had barely left the apartment in four days. My take-out boxes had accumulated by the trash, grease seeping through them in a way that was starting to emit a slight odor. I wasn't making an effort to do my dishes, and I had been monopolizing the common space to watch reality television and get quietly drunk. If Elise did notice something was wrong, she either didn't care or didn't want to pry. This was a major reason why I would never be friends with her: She had no interest in my objectively more interesting life.

I picked up my phone, deciding to text Jamie. I couldn't bear to be alone anymore. I needed to talk to someone.

Wanna come over and get takeout?

If she had plans, she would cancel them.

A moment later, she texted back:

Sounds great!

She was such a loser.

FOUR MINUTES AFTER Jamie arrived, I told her that Henry and I had broken up. I couldn't help myself; it was all I wanted to talk about. Jamie raised her eyebrows and said "Oh no" with all the gusto of a dead battery. I could see that she was relieved that this chapter of my life was ending. She should have known better, though; we still had months of dissecting where the relationship had gone wrong ahead of us. Henry would remain the subject of our hangouts for the foreseeable future. We would pick apart each interaction until I had diagnosed Henry with several mental illnesses that made him incapable of falling in love. In truth, I did think he could have borderline personality disorder. He definitely had generalized anxiety, and he was probably on the spectrum—or maybe he was just bad at eye contact.

I decided to be mostly honest with Jamie about what had happened, including telling her about the unexpected anal sex. I tried to make it sound like a funny story that Carrie Bradshaw would relay to her friends at brunch. Jamie listened silently, sipping her wine and refilling both of our glasses as soon as we emptied them. I told her about the morning after and how Henry told me he could get used to waking up together. I told her about the blow job. I told her how he cuddled me and how I used his toothbrush before everything went to shit. Jamie poured the last of the bottle into my glass. She looked like she was going to cry. I wondered if I had gone into too much detail and accidentally made her jealous.

"That is horrible, Lillian," she said. "I'm so sorry he did that to you."

“Which part?” I asked, genuinely wondering.

“The blow job before the breakup. The anal. Everything. It sounds like he was using you for sex,” Jamie said. “Honestly, it sounds fucked up in general.”

This wasn’t the response I needed. I needed her to laugh and for us to make fun of Henry’s mediocre dick. I needed her to tell me I was way hotter than he was, and that he would never date someone on my level again. I needed her to say something Samantha from *Sex and the City* would say that would diffuse any weird feelings I had about what happened. But Jamie was not Samantha. She wasn’t even Charlotte. She was just Jamie, and she was looking at me like I was the last dog left at the shelter.

“He wasn’t using me,” I said. “It’s complicated. We had a very complicated dynamic. Relationships can be like that sometimes.”

I defaulted to treating Jamie like it was her first day on earth whenever I sensed a hint of judgment from her about my dating life. Because it was true, wasn’t it? Shit like this *did* happen when you hooked up with people. Sure, I hadn’t expected it to happen with Henry, but it didn’t mean I was *entirely* surprised about it. Jamie had no idea what it was like to be in a relationship. She was a baby giraffe that hadn’t even taken its first steps. I was a hyena that had bested its predators by finding its own prey.

“What do you want to do to get your mind off of it?” Jamie eventually asked.

“I want to get drunk,” I said firmly.

So, we did.

AN HOUR LATER, I was properly shit-faced. Jamie was drunk, too. She kept looking at me like she wanted to kiss me, and I allowed her to stare because it wasn’t terrible to be reminded that I was still wanted by someone. I had spent the last hour oscillating between anger and sadness as Jamie did her best to keep up with my mood shifts. I landed on missing Henry. I decided I wanted to talk to him as soon as possible. I wanted to clear up this nasty misunderstanding we’d had. He didn’t mean to end it with me! He was just

trying to have a conversation about where our relationship was going. And sure, maybe we had some weird sex—but that was fine. We were just fun and kinky. Maybe I didn't need something serious immediately, either. I was okay taking things slow. There was no reason for both of us to react so severely. We could go back to taking it one step at a time. We could have fun.

"I'm going to call him," I said, grabbing my phone and rising from my seat with newfound energy.

Jamie's eyes widened. "What? No, Lillian. He's awful."

"I just need to speak to him."

"I really don't think you should," she pressed, standing up.

Jamie didn't understand what it was like starting from scratch with a person. She didn't get what it felt like to go to dinner and be so bored that you asked someone their favorite color. Plus, she didn't know what Henry and I were like behind closed doors. She only knew a few sound bites of a story I had told her. She didn't have the full picture. She hadn't seen any of the good bits. I couldn't let Henry Davis go, not yet. He still had potential. And I still wasn't blocked.

"I'm too old to play these games with people," I said, dialing his number as I paced the room.

Jamie exhaled, knowing she wouldn't be able to talk me out of whatever I was going to do next. She sat back down on the couch and poured herself some more wine, defeated. As the phone rang, I suddenly felt sober. Henry's photo populated the screen, shooting a pang of longing into my stomach like a metal rod; I had saved his LinkedIn picture to his contact after our second date.

"Lillian?" Henry said, answering on the third ring.

I realized I didn't have anything prepared to say. Maybe I should have practiced first.

"Hello," I said, sounding colder than I would have liked to.

"What do you want?" He matched my tone.

"I feel like we left off on a bad note," I confessed.

There was a long pause on the other side of the phone.

“Um, yeah. We did,” he said and waited a beat. “Did you want to apologize?”

So that was what he needed for things to go back to normal. He needed me to even the playing field by apologizing, to admit wrongdoing so he would be absolved of his own bad behavior. He needed to feel better about himself so he could feel better about us as a couple. I could do that. I could be wrong this time. I could forgive him if it meant I didn’t lose him entirely.

“Uh, yeah. I shouldn’t have said that stuff,” I said. “About your hairline and how long you last and stuff.”

“And the thing about...keeping a baby if you got pregnant?” he asked, anxiety coating his voice.

“I’m on the pill,” I lied.

I wasn’t on birth control, but I didn’t feel like explaining my own personal diagnosis to him. On the other side of the phone, I could hear Henry release a breath that he had been holding.

“Okay. Good. Well, thanks for calling. Take care, Lillian—” he said, ready to hang up.

“Wait,” I stopped him. “I feel like things got unnecessarily weird between us. I wanted you to know that I’m completely fine taking it slow. I’m not in—like—a massive rush to get into a relationship or anything,” I said, my words slightly slurring together. I hoped I didn’t sound too drunk. I wanted him to know that I meant every word of this.

There was another long pause on the other side of the phone.

“Lillian, I don’t think we should see each other. Your behavior really scared me the other day. You lashed out. And you’re clearly more invested in this situation than I am. That’s not fair. To either of us,” Henry said.

Jamie mouthed “What’s happening?” to me and I mouthed back “Shut the fuck up.”

“I have a feeling you will regret that,” I said, trying to find the sliver of dignity I had left. Henry cleared his throat, and I heard him stifle a laugh.

“Okay, Lillian. Is that all?” he asked.

My blood was boiling. How did he not care about losing me? How was he completely fine with going back to being strangers? He had been inside

me, inside almost every hole in my body with the exception of my ears! He owed me more than whatever the fuck this polite sign-off was. He owed me love, and foot rubs, and homemade dinners. He was supposed to treat me like I mattered to him. I wanted to scream. I wanted to dig my nails into the sides of Henry's arms until he bled. I wanted him to suffer like he had made me suffer. He owed me a future.

I must have been silent for too long, because my phone beeped to indicate the call had been ended. "Whatever, goodbye, Henry," I said, attempting to save face with Jamie.

I took a deep breath and put my phone down. Jamie looked at me, waiting for a debrief on what had happened. I was grateful I hadn't put the phone on speaker.

"Good riddance," I said.

Jamie stared at me with the kind of sympathy that someone would give a person begging for change on the street. I opened my phone, absentmindedly navigating to Instagram so I would have something to look at other than Jamie's stupid face. I didn't want her to see me cry. I was supposed to be her cool, fun, and sexy friend. I didn't want to be the weaker version of myself that emerged in front of her now, a blackhead pushing its way to the surface. I stared at my phone, my eyes beginning to blur with tears.

A post from the Wellness Witch popped up on my feed. She was talking to the camera with a caption that said "Hexes: The Good, the Bad, and the Ugly." Suddenly, my sadness shifted to something that felt a little like hope.

Here was my answer.

CHAPTER TEN

IT TURNED OUT JAMIE WAS a pussy about hexes. She grew up in a superstitious household, so she was worried that putting a hex on Henry could somehow get misdirected and hit me or her instead. I assured her that we would be fine and did my best to sound like I had done this before. We watched the Wellness Witch outline how to complete a hex on YouTube. It was a twenty-minute video that was interrupted by two-minute advertisements every five minutes, so it took a while to get through.

Bekah—who I now believed might actually be the real deal—said that we would need a candle, a photo of Henry, a black string, and a lot of willpower. I found the Yankee Candle Henry had wished me happy birthday with and some stray black string from a disintegrating Forever 21 sweater, and asked Elise if I could use her printer so I could print Henry’s LinkedIn photo. Elise was sleeping when she answered her bedroom door. I acted as sober as humanly possible and told her that I had a work emergency, pretending to be apologetic as I sat on the floor of her dark room waiting for her HP Inkjet to finish printing the photo of Henry. Once we had everything, I scribbled Henry’s name in Sharpie on the candle, per Bekah’s instructions.

“What do you want to do to him?” Jamie asked, clearly nervous.

This was a good question. I wanted him to be sterile. And probably never have sex again. I wanted him to be single forever. I wanted him to get a deep, painful pimple in the middle of his forehead that never went away. I wanted him to poop his pants at work. I wanted him to miss the train by three seconds every single day on his commute. Maybe I wanted him dead? That felt extreme, but after two bottles of wine, it somehow seemed better than running into him at a bar.

“I want him to hurt like I hurt,” I said vaguely.

The candle flickered.

“I want to be the last person he’s ever with,” I said.

On a cookie sheet, I lit the black string, which ran from the candle to the photo, and watched as the flame touched Henry’s face. His smug expression caught fire. Jamie and I watched it burn, and I felt a sense of calm come over me. When the photo turned black, Jamie looked at me for permission and I nodded, giving her the okay to dump a glass of water onto our operation and prevent an apartment fire.

“How will we know if it worked?” Jamie asked.

“We’ll know,” I said ominously.

I had no clue if there would be any actual indication that the hex had been a success, but this sounded like the right thing to say. I scanned my body for some spiritual confirmation that my powers had worked, but the only thing I felt clearly was that I was drunk.

I pulled out my phone and opened up a text thread with Henry. I typed:

You’re going to get what you deserve.

I looked at the text on-screen, debating if I should send it. It seemed more menacing, written out like that, than I had intended it to be. It would be impossible to convince Henry to get back together with me if I sent this; it would be the nail in the coffin of our love story. I showed my phone to Jamie.

“Should I send it?” I asked.

“Definitely,” Jamie said, eager for me to put the stamp of death on our relationship.

I hit send.

AFTER JAMIE LEFT, I was too wired to sleep. I felt a power I’d never felt before running through my veins. It was nearly one in the morning and I had to work the next day, but I felt jittery—like I was coming down from a

drug. I knew that I needed to get some rest, to deflate my spiritual high. Tomorrow, I would have to wake up and move on with my life.

I opened up the bathroom cabinet, scanning Elise's prescription bottles. I spotted a bottle of Ambien that I had snuck a pill or two from before. I twisted open the childproof cap with some difficulty and popped one pill into my mouth. After a little while, I could feel the medicine begin to take effect. I crawled into bed, enjoying the way the Ambien made my body feel heavy. I chugged a glass of water in hopes of avoiding the Worst Hangover of My Adult Life and pulled the covers over me. The hex was complete.

I could rest.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE SINGLE GLASS OF WATER I drank the night before did not effectively prevent the Worst Hangover of My Adult Life. I was throwing up in the handicap bathroom at work, the one everyone used to take discreet shits in. I imagined my coworkers outside, whispering confirmations to each other that I pooped out of my buttock. The reality was much worse: I was twenty-nine, freshly broken up with, and emptying the bile of my stomach into the bathroom all my colleagues shit in. I had done a hex, for fuck's sake. It dawned on me that I might not have my life together.

I exited the bathroom and walked out onto the office patio, hoping the fresh air would ease my upset stomach. The outdoor space had bright green turf grass with bocce ball and cornhole set up. In my three years at the company, I had never seen anyone spend more than five minutes outside. The games felt like mere props to support the illusion of work-life balance. I kicked one of the bocce balls with my foot and pulled out my phone to call my mother. I was finally emotionally low enough to believe that reaching out to her might bring me some solace.

My mother answered on the second ring.

"Hey, you," she said.

"Hi, Mom." I hated how childlike my voice sounded.

"What's wrong?" she said immediately.

The benefit of my mother's dramatics was she always assumed something horrible had happened—and occasionally, she was right.

"Henry ended things with me," I said.

My mother sighed on the other end of the phone.

"I can't say I didn't see that coming," she said.

This was not what I needed to hear. I needed to hear that she was shocked anyone would willingly remove themselves from my life. I needed

to hear that she thought I was too good for Henry—or for anyone, for that matter. I needed to hear that I could, and would, do better.

“We can be a lot for men, you know. It’s in our DNA. We feel things very intensely, Lillian. We’re empaths,” my mother said.

She had told me her empath theory many times before. She believed that she and I felt things on a deeper level than everyone around us. I had regurgitated this information to friends, lovers, and even coworkers before. I went as far as telling my colleagues that I had received “Most Empathetic” as my high school superlative. I did not receive this award, nor was I sure it was something that existed, but no one bothered fact-checking. Who would lie about something so specific anyway? Plus, I assumed empathy meant something different for everyone. For me, it meant I could guess exactly what the person I wanted to sleep with wanted before they told me. That had proven to be very helpful.

“He’s an asshole,” I said.

“Well, he went to Brown,” my mother said, like that explained everything.

“Beyond pretentious,” I agreed, though his education had little to do with our breakup.

“Did I tell you that Janice set me up with her cousin? Oh, it was awful, Lillian. He was bald. And he was *renting* his place. He didn’t even own it. Which, I know I rent, too, but I’d like someone to own their home by this point in their life. I’m sixty-four, but I don’t need to be set up with a bald renter. I wouldn’t mind dating someone younger, actually. I’m a young soul, you know? And I look good for my age,” she said. “Do you think I could date someone in their thirties?”

It was clear that she was done talking about my problem. She had given me the small kernel of support that she was capable of offering.

“Please don’t date someone thirty years younger than you, Mom. Hey, I have to get back to work,” I said, rushing her off the phone.

“Oh, right. Of course.” She snapped out of it. “Well, call me if you need anything.”

“I will,” I said.

I wouldn't.

The moment I hung up, I saw that Jamie had sent me several texts.

Jamie—Thursday 1:42 PM

Did you see?

Jamie—Thursday 1:43 PM

Lillian?

Jamie—Thursday 1:43 PM

I'm kind of freaking out.

Jamie—Thursday 1:45 PM

We need to talk. I don't want to text it.

Jamie—Thursday 1:45 PM

Call me!!!! I'm panicking.

A second later, Jamie was calling me. I picked up, annoyed with her pushy energy, which was radiating through the phone.

"I'm at work," I said curtly. My hangover was making my fuse shorter than normal.

Inside, Candice had spotted me on the patio. She gave me a small wave that she could have meant to be friendly but translated as "Why are you taking personal calls during work?"

"Did you see the *Globe* article?" Jamie asked.

"No?" I questioned.

I didn't have time to talk about whatever *Boston Globe* article Jamie was referring to. Did Taylor Swift come out as bi? Did someone speculate on whether or not she would come out as bi again? Was Tom Brady returning to the NFL for the forty-seventh time? Was the United States

funding another genocide? Did science say that wine was good for you again? I didn't have time to speculate on whatever this breaking news might be.

"He's dead, Lil," Jamie said. "Henry is dead."

My head swirled. It was unlike Jamie to make dark jokes, especially while I was at work. In fact, she barely had any sense of humor at all. Maybe she was still drunk from the night before? Maybe I had misheard her? Maybe I was still drunk? The sour feeling in my stomach grew in intensity.

"What?" I said, my voice coming out in a squeak.

"Google it," Jamie said.

I put Jamie on speaker while I navigated to the home page of the *Boston Globe*, my hands shaking. Splashed across the top of the website, there it was: a photo of Henry that I had never seen before with a headline that read "Local Man Killed Outside Bar." The bile in my stomach rose up quickly—too quickly. I searched for a safe place to release it, but it came too fast. I threw up violently onto the green turf grass, my bright yellow puke interrupting the uniformity of the lawn below me. I looked down at it, a splotchy mess reminiscent of a Jackson Pollock.

"Are you okay?" Jamie asked.

"No, I'm not okay."

"I know. Me, either," Jamie agreed. "I'm freaking out."

"Fuck. Fucking hell," I said, drawing a breath. "How the hell did this happen?"

"Do you think—" Jamie started.

"My boyfriend is dead," I interjected, trying to register the information.

There was a long pause, and I dared Jamie to challenge me on my use of the word "boyfriend" versus "ex." I would obliterate her if she said anything. How could this happen? How could Henry be dead? Who would kill him? I had just seen him the other night. I had just talked to him last night. I remembered the hex, the private wish I made for Henry to die.

"Do you think we did this?" Jamie sounded like she was going to break down in tears. Maybe she already was crying.

My stomach churned. No. That wasn't possible. Was it? The Wellness Witch didn't *actually* teach us how to do a hex. In the sober light of day, she was full of shit. Wasn't she? And on the off chance she did have any actual knowledge of witchcraft, we were amateur sorcerers at best. The likelihood of us accomplishing such a monumental spell on our first try was impossible. Sure, maybe I had made myself sterile with my own magical thinking—but I couldn't kill someone. The hex had nothing to do with this. His death had nothing to do with us.

"No way," I assured her. "We were just messing around."

I skimmed the article for more details on Henry's death. It said he was stabbed four times outside of a bar in Somerville near his apartment. I recognized the bar that he had been at. It was Henry's local haunt—a place he frequented when he had a bad day at work, which was most days, it had seemed. I had met Henry near this bar once before, but he never invited me inside. I assumed this was a sacred place where he liked to be alone and think. I had pictured him inside on a barstool, sipping a draft Guinness and reading Octavia Butler while he decompressed from the day. I had no clue if Henry had read Octavia Butler, but he seemed like the kind of guy who would make an effort to read novels written by women, at least in public.

"He was stabbed four times," Jamie said, repeating the contents I had just read.

My body trembled from a mix of cold and adrenaline.

"I can't believe this," I breathed. "But it wasn't us. Obviously," I added.

"Right," Jamie said, sounding like she didn't fully believe me.

"I mean I basically loved him. I would never actually want anything bad to happen to him."

"Right," Jamie said again, taking a deep breath. "Of course. This is so insane."

Henry was the first person who'd passed away that I had been this close to. Sure, my grandfather had passed away when I was a kid, and the father I didn't know had also died. But Henry was the first person who was a semi-constant in my life to leave it prematurely. I felt dizzy knowing that I wouldn't see him again. I wondered if I did really love Henry. Now that he

was dead, I felt my affection for him growing with each second. Henry's Sad Dead Wife Montage played in my head. I saw him sitting across from me at a bar, snuggling me in bed, making himself a drink. I didn't have much content for the montage—but what I did have was enough to nearly bring a tear to my eye. *My boyfriend is dead*, I repeated in my head.

"What do we do?" Jamie asked.

I thought about this. We couldn't go to the police and tell them we had done a hex on Henry. They would think I was mentally unstable. Maybe I could blame it on Jamie? Say it was her idea? I wasn't sure if she would take a clean fall for me like that, no matter how much she loved me. I remembered the text I had sent Henry the night before:

You're going to get what you deserve.

My heart started to beat faster. Why had I sent that message? What was I thinking? Why had I let Jamie talk me into dispatching such a petty, and now incriminating, text? The police wouldn't think I did anything to Henry, would they? I needed to stay calm. I had been with Jamie in my apartment! Then I went to bed. Elise was there the whole time! I had an alibi! Several alibis, actually. And we all were white women, who the police would be inclined to believe. I had nothing to worry about. The police—if they did suspect me of anything—would clear my name quickly. Everything was going to be fine. They would get it right. At least for me.

"We don't do anything," I insisted. "We just need to let the police do their jobs."

"Okay," Jamie exhaled.

"It's going to be fine. We didn't do anything wrong," I repeated.

"Okay," Jamie said again.

She finally sounded like she believed me a little. Now I just had to convince myself.

I noticed Candice looking out at the patio curiously. "I've got to go. I'll call you later." I hung up the phone.

I gathered myself before I walked back into the office. I wondered if anyone had seen me projectile vomit. I hoped not, though that was the least of my problems right now. Candice walked over, concern coloring her face.

“Everything okay?” she asked.

“My boyfriend died,” I blurted before I could question if it was a good idea to share this.

Candice’s mouth fell open. “Oh my God. Oh my God, Lillian. I am so sorry.”

She pulled me into a hug.

A few of the other women in the office turned around from their desks, having overheard my news. There was an abrupt chorus of hugs and apologies and “you’re so brave.” Candice told me to take the day, or the week—however much time I needed to cope with my loss. She said that the company would send some food over to my apartment. Amanda from the social media department (who was typically extremely cunty) was in instant tears. How had she started crying so quickly? Did she have a tear stick in her desk? Should I have been crying, too? Amanda told me—through sobs—that her dog had passed away a few months ago, so she “understood” what I was going through. Everyone around me sprang into action, collecting my bag from my desk and ushering me out of the office. Jessica added her number into my phone, insisting that I text her if I needed anything. Julie said she was sending me a Postmates gift card for a hundred dollars so I “wouldn’t have to think about nourishing myself.” Despite the loss that had inspired it, the attention from my colleagues felt nice. Sort of amazing, even.

Sure, it was under horrific circumstances, but it felt good to be seen.

CHAPTER TWELVE

IT TURNED OUT HENRY DID use his social media. I guess when people die, everything about them rises to the surface. In Henry's case, instead of leaving behind diaries or priceless works of art, he left behind an internet footprint. I was furious when I found out that he had lied to me about being a Luddite. I knew I shouldn't wish ill on the dead—especially after I had already wished quite a bit of ill on Henry—but I found myself extremely upset by the discovery. He had a whole world online that I didn't know about.

I got home after being dismissed from work and opened up an old bottle of champagne. It felt weird to have a drink deemed as “celebratory” after someone had died, but it was the only alcohol I had in my house, and I needed to dull the influx of emotions that were threatening to pull me apart. By the time I got myself onto the couch, I had another text from Jamie. It was a link to Henry's sister—Amelia's—Instagram page, which was public. On it, she had posted a black-and-white photo of her and Henry as children. The caption said:

No words. I'll miss you forever, Big Bro.

Amelia had thousands of comments from friends and strangers alike, all offering their condolences and some sharing stories about Henry's kindness. Many claimed that Henry lit up any room he walked into, and a few said they would miss hearing his distinct laugh. I tried to remember what Henry's laugh had sounded like, but I didn't recall it being anything particularly noteworthy. I worried suddenly that he had never laughed in front of me, but pushed that idea away just as quick. I was very funny. He

must have. In the photo Amelia had posted of him, hovering over baby Henry's face was a tag: HenryNotThe8th.

This was Henry's supposedly "inactive" account that I had previously found and tried to follow. In the wake of his death, the account had been made public, likely as a way of communicating what had happened to the people who knew him. I clicked on it.

The top photo was the same picture that Amelia had posted, also shared to her brother's page. Once again, she announced his tragic passing along with her intention of using Henry's page as "a place to honor him" going forward. I was surprised at how fast Amelia had rebranded her brother's profile to be a virtual tombstone. I wondered how she had hacked his page so swiftly, and felt slightly annoyed that I hadn't been able to do the same when he was alive.

Henry didn't post often, but he certainly did have social media, and he wasn't entirely inactive on it. Most of his photos were of landscapes, with him occasionally holding a beer in front of the view. There was one picture of him wakeboarding from 2020. There was another from his college graduation. Another of him with a group of guy friends I was never introduced to. There was one of his family on a trip to Hawaii. As I clicked through the photos, I mourned the activities we never got to try together, and the people I never got to meet. I noticed a photo from five months ago featuring the back of a woman's head as she looked out at a mountain vista. It didn't look like the back of his sister's head. I clicked on the photo, and the tag NoraNora26 popped up.

I clicked on it.

Henry's face was all over Nora's Instagram. I stared at the screen, feeling like my eyeballs were vibrating in my skull. I wondered if people could have self-induced seizures from anger. There were nearly as many photos of Henry as there were of Nora on her feed. There were perfectly staged camping pictures. There were candid shots taken by friends. There were posed photos from several Halloweens, where they had expertly coordinated joint costumes. There was a sepia-toned photo booth picture of

them kissing. I scanned through the photos on Nora's profile quickly and greedily—like her account might disappear at any moment.

She was Henry's girlfriend. I let that sink in.

Henry had a girlfriend. Henry was fucking me while he had a girlfriend. Henry was putting his dick into my ass and then into his girlfriend's vagina. I knew this was the case because there was no way a woman like this let anyone put anything into her ass.

I didn't need to know Nora personally to know that I hated her. She was a Lilly Pulitzer Boston bitch, the kind of girl who wore boat shoes and went to Nantucket in the summer. She probably drank vodka sodas and got gel manicures every two weeks. If she had any rough edges, they had been carefully buffed out years ago. She was the kind of girl finance guys in Boston loved, the kind of woman they settled down with. From her page, I quickly surmised that Nora was an event planner at a boutique company in Cambridge and that she and Henry had met at Brown. My mother was right: Fuck Brown.

Adrenaline coursed through my body as I gobbled up all the content I could find. I started to feel like I was cutting myself—looking at all the places I'd thought Henry's and my relationship might go but with someone else plugged into the equation. Nora's most recent post featured Henry, mid-laugh, putting his hand over the camera like he was trying to stop the photo from being taken. The caption read:

I'll love you and miss you forever, H.

All of the little clues that felt like proof that Henry had his shit together were suddenly glaring red flags. The busy weekends. The late-night hangouts. The volunteering. The bar cart. The linen sheets. The bathrobe. The general attention to fucking detail in the apartment. This was his girlfriend. This was his girlfriend, and they'd probably lived together. This was his girlfriend, which meant I was not.

And now Henry was dead. And this woman would be the one to mourn his death publicly while I'd have to stay in the shadows. I searched for my own photo of Henry to post as a retaliative tribute, but all I had was his LinkedIn picture and a blurry photo I had taken of him sleeping the night he passed out at my apartment. I started inhaling and exhaling, unable to find a normal cadence for my breath. Pins and needles prickled across my hands; my heart was beating so fast that I thought it might burst. Maybe a heart attack would be a good thing. Maybe I would die young and everyone would be devastated. My marketing company would post a sweet tribute to me on their Instagram page, and the *Boston Globe* would run a piece that said "Young Woman Dies of Broken Heart" with a beautiful headshot of me next to it. All the people I had fucked would see the paper and regret not loving me. My mom would lie over my coffin like Nancy Reagan at Ronald Reagan's funeral, except no one would be mad at me for war crimes. I would die a hero.

Henry's sister had commented on Nora's recent post:

You'll always be my sister.

I felt like I was going to be sick. Not only did he have a girlfriend, but he had a girlfriend who was fully integrated into his family. I wanted to message Nora and tell her about Henry and me. I wanted to screenshot the dick pictures he had drunkenly sent me and say, "I miss him, too." I wanted to tell her every single sexual position we had done. I wanted to blow up her life more than it had already been blown up. I wanted her to feel like the other woman, too.

I started drafting a message to Nora in my Notes app:

Hey, you deserve to know who your, or should I say "our" boyfriend really was—

Before I could complete my message, my phone started ringing. The caller ID said “BOSTON PD.” My breath hitched. Why were the police calling me? Did Jamie tell them about the hex? Did they suspect me of harming Henry? Could I ignore the police department’s call? Or would they show up at my apartment if I did? Would they kick down my door and accidentally shoot me like they sometimes did to people? I decided the best course of action was to answer.

“Hello?” I answered.

“Is this Lillian O’Malley speaking?” a man’s voice asked.

“It is,” I said.

“This is Detective Michaels from the Boston Police Department. I’m not sure if you’ve seen the news about your, er, acquaintance, Henry Davis...” he said, waiting for me to confirm whether or not I knew that Henry’s body was probably being put on ice as we spoke. I wasn’t sure if I should lie and say that I hadn’t seen the news, or if that would make me seem more guilty than innocent. Maybe it would just make me appear uneducated, like I didn’t read Boston’s biggest newspaper every day, which I didn’t. I decided I would start off telling the truth, at least for now.

“My friend sent me the *Globe* article,” I said. “I’m obviously a wreck.”

“Right,” the detective said, clearing his throat. “I’m sorry for your loss,” he added half-heartedly.

“Thanks,” I said curtly.

I wondered if he was being nicer to Nora about all this. I wondered if he was handling her fragile emotional state like an appraiser holding a priceless artifact on *Antiques Roadshow*. People were always so careful with women like Nora. No one ever bothered to be careful with me.

“We would love to have a conversation with you,” he said.

“Oh. Um, sure,” I said. “Why?”

“You were, uh—acquainted—with the deceased. We’re talking to everyone who knew him,” the detective said. “Getting all the information.”

“Do I need a lawyer?” I asked.

I wasn’t sure why I felt like I might need an attorney already. Did Nora have a lawyer? I hadn’t done anything wrong, but I wasn’t sure if innocent

people preemptively hired legal counsel or if they just spilled their information freely, trusting the justice system to bring justice. I had seen enough true crime documentaries to know that having a lawyer was never a bad idea; the police could coax even the most innocent person into a false confession if they wanted to. There was a long pause on the other side of the phone. The detective cleared his throat again. Maybe he had allergies.

“That’s up to you,” he said.

“When do I need to come in?” I asked.

“Today, if you could. As soon as possible. To the Cambridge precinct.”

Panic washed over me. They wanted to talk to me immediately. Which meant they might actually think I had something to do with Henry’s death. Did they really think I was capable of killing someone? That I was dangerous? I decided the best course of action would be to continue acting how any innocent person would act. Getting a lawyer seemed guilty. I would talk to the police alone and clarify that I had nothing to do with this. I would put this behind me. Then I would figure out who the fuck Nora was and how long Henry had been sleeping with both of us.

“I’ll be there soon.” I swallowed.

I hoped I wouldn’t regret it.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

THE EVIDENCE OF THE HEX was easy enough to destroy. I googled “how to get rid of evidence” in an incognito tab and was told that the best thing I could do to cover my trail was spread any clues of a crime over a wide geographic radius. I put the Yankee Candle into my neighbor’s trash bin and cleared my desktop of the saved photo of Henry. Then I donated what was left of the falling-apart Forever 21 sweater to Goodwill, hoping some hot teen would pick it up and inherit my bad luck.

I didn’t want to tell Elise what was going on, but I knew there was a possibility that the police would reach out to her to confirm where I had been the previous night. Before I left for the precinct, I cornered her in the bathroom while she was brushing her teeth. I told her what happened, omitting the details of the hex but giving her the broad strokes: My boyfriend was dead and the police needed to speak with me about it. I left out the part about him two-timing me by fucking another woman.

“You had a boyfriend?” Elise asked incredulously. “That guy who came over a few times?” Of course this was the detail she had latched onto.

“Yes. And he’s dead.” I overarticulated the second *d* in “dead” so Elise would get it through her thick skull that this was a sensitive subject.

Elise put her toothbrush down, a little bit of toothpaste lingering on her chin.

“Wow,” she said. “I didn’t know you two were serious.”

This was why I never spoke to her. She was so preoccupied putting a label on what Henry and I had been that she had barely acknowledged the loss I was going through. My mother was right: Not everyone else was as empathetic as we were.

“He wasn’t around that much,” she mused. “It was that guy, right?”

“Yes. Henry. And he didn’t come over a lot because I know you don’t like having people here,” I said, venom building in my voice.

Elise had never said outright that she didn’t like having company over. In fact, she was usually quite nonconfrontational with me. During COVID, I had joined an African drumming class on Zoom and attended it in the middle of the living room twice a week. At the time, I thought taking the class would help my understanding of the Black Lives Matter movement. In reality, all it did was slightly improve my sense of rhythm and introduce me to one hundred percent more Black people than I knew before. When I was in class, Elise would breeze by me as I pounded my drum with the vigor of the Energizer Bunny on cocaine, always a half a second behind the rest of the class—which I blamed on the internet connection.

“How did he die?” Elise asked.

“He was stabbed outside a bar,” I said.

Elise gasped. “Oh my God. I read about that.”

“Yeah, it’s horrible. I can’t believe I have to talk to the police about it.”

“You’re not a suspect, right?” Elise asked, worried now.

Was she nervous because she thought I did it, or because she thought I didn’t?

“Of course not. I was home with you last night,” I said.

Elise finally spotted the toothpaste on her face in the mirror. She wiped it off with the back of her hand, which felt counterproductive.

“Well, I was sleeping, wasn’t I?” Elise said.

“Sure, but you would have woken up if I left the apartment.” I resisted rolling my eyes.

“I usually have earplugs in and my fan on. You know I sleep with white noise,” she said.

What was she suggesting? That I had left the house in the middle of the night and killed Henry? Someone who was my loving partner? Why was she being like this? Why did she want to hurt me when I was already hurting?

“Jesus Christ, Elise. I was with Jamie and then I went to bed. If the cops ask, why wouldn’t you just tell them that? I’m devastated, okay? I don’t

need to be dealing with the police *and* you,” I said. “I need to think about the funeral and stuff.”

“You’re planning the funeral?” Elise asked.

“I’m helping,” I said, nearly barking the words back at her.

Elise looked taken aback. I didn’t normally snap at her. All of the fighting we usually did happened in my head while I showered. And I had no clue how I would track down an invitation to Henry’s funeral, never mind assist in planning it. But this claim sounded like something that Henry’s girlfriend would say.

“Of course. I’ll tell them whatever makes sense. I’m sorry for your loss,” she finally said.

After everything was squared away with Elise, I FaceTimed Jamie.

When she answered, I could have sworn I clocked a hint of excitement, like she was thrilled that we had permanently been trauma-bonded to each other. I told Jamie that if the police contacted her, under no circumstances was she to mention the hex. I insisted that it would be best to avoid the subject altogether.

“It makes me sound vindictive. And, like, indicates motive,” I theorized.

Jamie nodded gravely. “Of course. I won’t mention it.”

“Hopefully I’ll be able to clear this up quickly,” I sighed.

“I can’t believe you have to even talk to them.” She paused, collecting herself. “I can’t believe this is happening.”

“I know. They should be looking into actual leads,” I affirmed.

I considered telling Jamie about Nora. After all, Nora could have had something to do with Henry’s death. But I wasn’t prepared to share that I wasn’t the only woman in Henry’s life. Jamie had already been skeptical of my relationship with him; I didn’t want to give her further ammunition that would invalidate the significance of what we had—or, worse, risk her taking Nora’s side. I would tell her later, after I had cleared up things with the cops.

“Are you nervous?” Jamie asked.

“I didn’t do anything,” I insisted. “I have nothing to hide.”

“Well, ACAB,” Jamie said.

I wanted to punch her in the face.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

THE DETECTIVE INTERVIEWING ME WAS not the one I had spoken to over the phone, but instead a butch lesbian named Detective Jennings. She had a short, tight haircut, visible neck tattoos, and a pierced nose. Her muscles bulged from under her police uniform and I wanted her to like me desperately, partially so I wouldn't be implicated for a crime I didn't commit, but also because I hoped she might put me in handcuffs for fun one day. I felt like my future was in her hands, which made her extremely attractive to me. I wanted to signal to her that I wasn't totally straight before we started the interview about my very heterosexual relationship. As Detective Jennings set up the recorder, I quickly opened the Spotify app on my phone. I hit play on MUNA's album and pretended not to notice when it started playing out loud.

"Is that your phone?" Detective Jennings asked.

I feigned surprise. "Oh, is it?"

I pulled out my phone and turned it off. "Sorry. Love that song, though."

Detective Jennings looked at me, concerned. "Are you hard of hearing, Lillian?"

"What? No," I said.

"Okay, because that would be relevant information to have," she said.

This was off to a terrible start.

Detective Jennings made me state my name and age for the record twice. The first time, I added that I was a Pisces, hoping Detective Jennings would tell me her sign so I could research if we were compatible later on. She did not share her natal chart and instead made me restate my information, insisting that we get a clean take. The detective started by asking me where I had been the night of Henry's murder. I told her the

truth: that I was with Jamie and Elise. She collected both Jamie and Elise's contact information and said that she would follow up with them to confirm this. The detective asked about me and Henry's relationship next: where we had met (a bar), how long we had been seeing each other (four months), if we were physically intimate (yes), and if we fought (not really). Then she asked me about Nora: whether or not I knew about her while Henry and I were dating (no), if I had met her (no), and if I was upset Henry was seeing her (I didn't know about her until recently, but yes, I was sad that my boyfriend was cheating on me). The detective jotted down notes as I spoke.

"Aren't you recording this anyway?" I asked.

"Yes," the detective said blankly.

"But you're still writing it all down?"

"Just the headlines," she said.

I looked at the paper in front of her, which said "LILLIAN" across the top. Detective Jennings opened up a folder and pulled out a paper with printouts of text conversations between Henry and me. My pulse quickened with anxiety. She laid a few down on the table, pointing first to the text I had sent Henry on the night he died:

You're going to get what you deserve.

"Can you tell me a little about this?" Detective Jennings asked.

I tried not to fidget. Only nervous, guilty people fidgeted. Innocent people sat still. Or maybe sociopaths sat still and innocent people fidgeted? I should have done a bit of research on criminal body language before I went into the station. I tried to find a middle ground, squirming just a little bit, but not excessively.

"We had a tiny rough patch. I felt like he wasn't communicating well with me. So, I was annoyed with him," I said.

"Before this text, you two had a brief conversation on the phone that lasted two minutes and fifteen seconds. Can you tell me what was said during that conversation?" she asked.

“I called to make sure he was okay. He had a bad week at work and he was taking it out on me. Drinking a lot. I was worried about him,” I said. “I was with my friend Jamie when I spoke to him.”

“These texts seem like you guys were, uh, on a break of sorts. You still called to check on him?” the detective asked.

“Of course. I cared about him,” I said. “I still do.” I saw a flash of myself in a Lifetime movie as the words left my mouth.

I would have to fill Jamie in so she could corroborate my slightly tweaked version of the events. It wasn’t a lie anyway. I had called Henry because I cared about him. Sure, we hadn’t reached the resolution I had hoped for. And yes, I had sent a vindictive text afterward. But my intentions were pure. If I was honest about how tense the phone conversation had been, and what had happened before it, the police would get hung up on the wrong details. It was better for them to think that Henry was the tipsy instigator, that he had been nasty enough to merit a message like that. If he truly cared about me, he wouldn’t mind shielding me from unnecessary scrutiny anyway. It was the least he could do, even if he was dead.

“He was already kind of drunk when we spoke. It was a short conversation, but he was pretty harsh to me. It hurt my feelings and I sent that text. I regret it, obviously,” I said.

I tried to bring a tear to my eye, but it didn’t come. I wiped under my lash line for good measure, sniffing and waiting for Detective Jennings to offer me a tissue. She did not.

“I was with Jamie until pretty late in the night. Then I said good night to my roommate, Elise, and went to bed. I didn’t find out about what had happened until I saw it in the *Globe* the next day. I was so disturbed by the news that I actually threw up at work,” I said.

This was true. I bet my throw-up was still on the patio, now bleached by the sun.

“It’s probably still on the grass,” I said, hoping that proof of my emotional distress would clear me of any further suspicion. And shouldn’t it? I was nearly positive that murderers had stronger constitutions than I did.

“What?” Detective Jennings asked.

“My puke. It’s probably still out there,” I clarified. “On the patio of my office.”

“Oh. Um. Okay,” she said. She wrote down “PUKE” on her paper.

“But you were angry with Henry the night he died, right?” the detective asked.

I considered how to answer this. This felt like the kind of question a wrongfully incarcerated person would point to from their jail cell as the moment where it had all gone wrong. I knew I had to proceed with caution to make sure I wasn’t misunderstood.

“I wouldn’t say angry,” I said. “Sad, sure.”

“Have you ever been convicted of any other crimes?” the detective asked.

“No.” I paused. “Or does a parking ticket count?” I added, trying to lighten the mood.

“No. It does not.” She stared at me.

“You guys have that information anyway, right? Like parking tickets and stuff? Or do you ask those questions to see if people will lie about it?” I realized I was tapping my foot. I put my hand on my knee to stop it.

“We haven’t run your record yet. But yes, we would know if you had been involved in any other interactions with law enforcement,” Detective Jennings said.

She wrote “RUN RECORD!” on her paper. The exclamation point felt like overkill.

“Is there anything else you want me to know? Anything that could provide insight on Henry’s murder—or his state of mind—the night of his death?” she asked.

I thought about this. I wondered if I should float my theory about Nora’s potential involvement to the detective. Wasn’t it usually the partner who killed the victim in most murder cases? Or did that only apply when a woman was murdered by a man? Then again, I was dating Henry, too. Suggesting that Nora might have killed him could—in turn—shine a brighter light on me. And I had nothing to do with Henry’s death aside from

casting a middle school hex on him. I didn't need to point the finger elsewhere to prove that I was innocent—it was clear.

“Not that I can think of,” I said. “I just really hope you find the person who did this. I can't believe anyone would hurt Henry.”

“Yeah. It's pretty messed-up stuff,” the detective agreed.

She turned the recorder off. “This should be good for now. We'll let you know if we need anything else or if we have any trouble confirming your whereabouts the night of.”

“Do you have any leads?” I inquired, feeling braver now that the tape recorder was off.

The detective took a deep breath, probably considering if she should tell me any revealing information. After some hesitation, she said, “There's nothing concrete yet. It's very early in the investigation. But the bar where he was killed has some homeless folks with mental health issues and drug problems around it. We're looking into every avenue.”

Of course they would nail some unhoused person for Henry's death. Knowing Boston, if it was a random act of violence, it was more likely that it was some drunk and diabolical frat bro who wanted to know what stabbing someone felt like. Or maybe someone's sports team had lost and they needed to relieve their frustrations by watching the light leave someone's eyes. Or perhaps, if it wasn't Nora herself, maybe her family was to blame. Maybe they had found out about mine and Henry's romance and decided to inflict the ultimate punishment on their daughter's boyfriend like mafiosos. I made a mental note to check if the family had any ties to the mob later. Did they keep that kind of information in the library? There were several avenues that I was almost positive the police weren't looking into.

“That statement is all we'll need from you for today.” The detective glanced at the door to indicate it was time for me to leave.

I stood up, gathering my belongings.

“Oh, and, Lillian?” the detective said. “Please don't leave the area. We may need you to come back in to answer some more questions. If you do

leave the state, it will be seen—at best—as refusal to cooperate with law enforcement.”

“Of course,” I said. “I won’t go anywhere.”

I needed a lawyer. Preferably a cheap one.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

I ASKED JAMIE TO MEET me at a bar after I left the police station. It was four in the afternoon and she had to cancel on a physical therapy client to make it—but this was an emergency. Jamie showed up in workout clothes and with her mouth pursed in a tight, apprehensive knot. I had already ordered a bottle of wine, which she eyed when she sat down at the booth.

“Go grab something at the bar.” I motioned.

I had endured a horrid enough day to merit having the bottle to myself. I could see Jamie internally debate asking for a glass, but ultimately decide against it.

The discovery of Nora and the interaction with the police had put me on edge. I sat at the table, picking at my nails, my body unable to find a comfortable position. I chugged a half glass of wine while I watched Jamie politely order a draft beer, probably overtipping as an apology for her existence. I realized my entire alibi hinged on this weak, easily frightened person. I had seen Jamie say sorry to pieces of furniture when she bumped into them, and she once said thank you to a homeless man who had called her a slut. I needed to make sure that she wouldn’t fold under pressure and tell the police about the hex.

Jamie slid into her seat. “So, you have to go back in?”

“I’m not sure yet. Maybe,” I said. “Either way, I should get legal counsel. Do you have any family members who are lawyers?” I asked, realizing I knew very little about Jamie’s family other than the fact that her mom was kind of hot.

“My aunt is a notary,” she said idiotically.

“Okay.” I took a sip of my wine. “Not helpful.”

We looked up lawyers online and quickly realized that they would cost a ridiculous amount of money. I had about ten grand saved up, but that

would burn quickly with the hourly rate for most halfway decent attorneys. I didn't like when my savings dipped below six grand. One of the side effects of growing up poor was I needed a certain number in my account to sleep at night. When my finances dropped below it, I began to imagine myself juggling at the intersection of a stoplight, begging the cars that passed for a spare dollar.

"I'm never going to be able to afford this," I said.

Maybe Jamie would pay for my wine on top of her own drinks if she felt bad enough.

"Can you ask your mom for help?" Jamie frowned.

"No. That's not on the table," I said firmly.

My mother was already in heaps of credit card debt. She had a tendency to treat her income like Monopoly money, spending it like it was for show and had no real-life implications. She would say yes if I asked for help. She would open a new card, or take out a loan, or do whatever financially irresponsible thing she needed to do to assist me. But I couldn't allow that. Plus, if I told my mother what happened, she would blow everything out of proportion. She would catastrophize, sobbing as she googled "jail visiting hours" and "how to send money to prisoners." She would watch YouTube videos on how to make DIY shivs, and hold my hand during her fiftieth rewatch of *The Shawshank Redemption*. I didn't need to involve her in this. I only needed a lawyer as a precaution.

Jamie furrowed her brow, thinking of other options. "I have a little money you could borrow...if you need."

I thought about this. It wasn't a terrible idea. I wouldn't be in this mess if Jamie hadn't encouraged me to send such an incriminating text to Henry in the first place. Plus, if I had been alone that night, I probably wouldn't have even bothered doing the hex. Lending me money was really the least Jamie could do. After all, she wasn't the one who had to be questioned by the police, but she had played just as much of a part in everything that had incriminated me.

"That would be great. Thanks," I said.

Jamie's face flushed with panic, like an animal caught in the middle of the road. It was clear now that her offer had been an empty one. I could see her dwindling bank account flash across her eyes as she considered how to revoke her favor gracefully. This would be a good lesson for her: Don't extend a kindness that you aren't ready to give.

"Write down your credit card information here." I passed her my phone.

Jamie begrudgingly pulled out her wallet, looking at my Notes app like she was writing her last will and testament. She copied her card details down and handed the phone back to me. This wasn't the first time I had borrowed money from Jamie. She often covered our bar tabs and Ubers, and in college, she once lent me \$200 that I paid back by buying her a lottery ticket, with which she had the potential to win even more money (she didn't win). What was one more financial ask in the grand scheme of our friendship?

"Have you spoken to any of Henry's family yet...or anyone he knew?" Jamie asked.

I knew she would find out about Nora eventually. Jamie was just as adept at social media stalking as I was. She joked that in the future she would become one of those old women who got so bored that they picked up a cold case and solved it. These types of people often got crucified online for treating murder as entertainment, but I respected the fact that women with a hobby were still better at getting answers than men with full-time jobs (police). Jamie bit the skin on her bottom lip, a nervous habit of hers that got triggered when she wanted to talk to me about something. She knew about Nora. I could see it on her face. It would be better to beat her to the punch.

"He had another girlfriend," I said. "He was cheating on me."

Jamie put her hand over her mouth, feigning surprise. I hated her for it. Thank God acting wasn't her passion, because she had no natural ability for it; she looked like an awards show host reading their cue cards on a delay.

"Her name is Nora. She's incredibly basic," I added, like it would make her existence matter less. "And I'm obviously extremely hurt."

I pulled up Nora's profile on my phone and passed it to Jamie. I could at least count on her to tear Nora down with me. Jamie scanned Nora's profile, pretending like she was seeing it for the first time.

"Oh, wow. So, they've been together for a while?" she said.

"I guess so." I clenched my jaw.

"They met in college," she said, repeating information I had long since digested. "You're right," she agreed. "She's kinda basic."

This was the kind of support I needed. I needed to talk about how Nora's hair was thinning and where she was hiding her stretch marks. I needed to joke about her vagina sweating at her SoulCycle classes, and how her nipples probably pointed in opposite directions. I needed to find her Twitter and make fun of how unoriginal her jokes were, and how thin her eyebrows were—and not in a cute '90s way. I waited for more material from Jamie, but she just handed the phone back to me.

"Do you think I'm prettier than her?" I asked, self-conscious at her lack of response.

Jamie shifted. "Oh. Um, sure, Lil. It's just...I feel kind of bad. Her long-term boyfriend just died, you know?"

I had to physically stop myself from slapping Jamie. The impulse shocked me, but it also made sense: People did crazy things when they were grieving. I needed comfort from my friend, and instead, she was passing judgment on me. And why should she? She knew nothing about Nora and Henry's relationship. For all we knew, they were toxic. Maybe they hadn't slept together in years. They were probably the kind of couple whose friends called them "Mom and Dad" until they became sexless—their genitals slowly disappearing from their bodies like Barbie and Ken. Perhaps Henry had tried to end things with Nora many times, but she had pushed back. He had probably even told her about me. He probably said he met someone else, someone special. Maybe he admitted that he had fallen in love. Perhaps Nora blew up at him, threatening to ruin his life if he left her for me. I imagined the words "You'll regret this" leaving her thin, chapped lips as he broke the news to her. As I pieced things together, it felt likely that Henry had only ended things with me out of fear of Nora's retaliation.

She was the wrench that had been thrown in our budding relationship—the other woman he couldn’t shake. Maybe I had gotten it all wrong. He did want me. Maybe he paid the ultimate price for wanting me.

“I don’t even think he wanted to be with her,” I said to Jamie.

“Did he tell you that?” she asked.

“I can just tell. She isn’t his type,” I said.

Jamie studied Nora a little more. “Yeah, you guys are very different.”

I wasn’t sure if she meant this as a compliment or an insult, but it sounded more like the latter. Her presence was starting to grate on me. She was supposed to be here to comfort me, and instead, she was asking invasive questions that warped the reality of the situation, making it seem like I was the one who had done something wrong. I hadn’t even known about Nora, for fuck’s sake. Why should I feel bad for her? And I had just lost my boyfriend, too. Why was Jamie extending compassion to a woman she didn’t know over me? I chugged more wine, the liquid going down the wrong pipe. I stifled a cough and water pooled in my eyes. I took another sip, trying to recalibrate.

“Are you crying, Lil?” Jamie asked, newfound concern painting her face. “I’m so sorry. I didn’t mean to upset you.”

I cleared my throat, stifling another cough. “Yeah...I’m heartbroken about all this.” My throat continued to burn.

And I was heartbroken, but I also had a task to do. I needed to make sure my life didn’t end because Henry’s had. I needed to ensure that one stupid hex didn’t turn me into a villain that I wasn’t. I needed to maintain a tiny bit of control in a situation, which I was—by all accounts—still the victim of. I needed to protect what was left of my life. Henry would have wanted that.

“I also wanted to make sure we’re still on the same page about the hex?” I asked.

“Do you really think they’ll interview me?” Jamie said, turning her mouth into a deep frown that resembled one of those cats that were genetically bred to look sad so their owners would get brand deals.

“Maybe. Just to confirm what I already told them,” I said.

“Are you sure we shouldn’t mention it?” Jamie asked. “What if they do, like, computer forensics of your search history?”

“This isn’t the CIA, Jamie. It’s the Boston police on a power trip. And it’s not like the hex actually worked,” I said.

“The timing is so weird, though.” Jamie stared at her beer, anxious.

This was true. There was a less logical part of my brain that wondered if I had channeled some untapped power within myself. As a child, I’d convinced myself on several occasions that I had telekinesis after watching the movie *Matilda*. I tried to think back on whether or not I had ever effectively moved something with my mind. Maybe a pencil, but I wasn’t positive it hadn’t been positioned on an incline.

“It was just a stupid YouTube video. Nothing more,” I assured her.

“Okay,” Jamie said, exhaling. “I won’t mention it.”

“I also told the police that Henry had a bit of a drinking problem,” I added nonchalantly.

Jamie glanced at the wine bottle in front of me, surprised. “Did he?”

“Yeah. I didn’t want to mention it before because I was embarrassed. But he had a temper when he drank.” I shrugged. “It’s a disease. I felt bad.”

It was cleaner if Jamie’s perception of the situation matched most of what I had already told Detective Jennings. I reached across the table, touching Jamie’s hand with mine, running my finger across her thumb.

“I really appreciate you being here for me during all of this. It means a lot to me,” I said.

Jamie softened. “Of course. I won’t mention the hex. And I’ll do whatever I can to help.”

“Thank you.” I squeezed her hand.

I hoped she meant it.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

I FOUND JIMENEZ AND SONS advertised on a bus stop bench. They marketed themselves as cheap, quick, and, for the right cases, pro bono. Their poster said “For Accidentes Call,” and what had happened with Henry and the hex was certainly an accidente, so I called. From their website, it was clear that the law firm consisted of George Jimenez and his two sons, Carlos and Hector. George had a slicked-back black toupee and bushy gray eyebrows that drew a great deal of attention to his hairpiece by contrast. Carlos was plump and seemed friendly, like a school mascot out of costume. Hector, on the other hand, looked more serious. He had anxious eyes and a sense of dread that seeped out of my computer screen, pixel by pixel. I knew immediately that Hector was the one I wanted.

From my brief Google search, I learned that Hector had received his law degree from either SUNY Buffalo, the University of Phoenix, or a combination of both. I was set to meet with Hector at twelve thirty on Sunday, another reason behind my choosing them: They advertised their hours as “available 24/7, even on holidays.”

The Jimenez and Sons office was located in a run-down building in Brighton above a Dunkin’ Donuts, which made the whole office smell like burnt coffee and sugar. The decor was straight out of the ’70s, which could have been an artistic choice, but I sensed it was more likely a financial one.

When I got to the lobby, I was greeted by a receptionist who looked like a strong gust of wind might kill her. I assumed she was related to the family. In fact, her face was such a copy-and-paste of Hector’s own that it looked like his features had been pulled directly off his skull and put atop the body of a ninety-year-old woman. She was painting her nails bright purple and watching *Days of our Lives* on an iPad. I told her my name, and she instructed me to have a seat and help myself to water, motioning to the large

jug and triangular plastic cups. I drank four cups of water back-to-back while she watched me curiously. She raised her eyebrows, either impressed or deeply worried by my water intake. Maybe she thought I was dehydrated from a life of criminal activity.

Five minutes after our meeting was supposed to start, Hector emerged from his office, hurriedly wiping mustard off of his chin with a napkin. Seeing him next to the older receptionist was so jarring that I felt the need to verbally confirm that they were related.

“Are you guys related?” I asked.

“Yes,” said Hector, like it was the dumbest thing he’d ever been asked. “Come on back, Lillian.”

Hector’s office was a similar style to the waiting room except it was littered with pictures of his wife and children. There were so many pictures of them I wondered if they had died and this was some kind of morbid shrine. Or maybe some people really loved their families this much. Hector was tall in person, definitely over six feet, and he was slim, with the body of someone who’d played sports in high school. He still had a full head of hair, which seemed like a miracle compared to the other men in his family. He was subtly handsome, like a mediocre-looking man you might want to fuck if you saw him being a good father in public. When I saw Hector’s photo on the website, I toyed with the idea of trying to sleep with him. I thought it might be nice to date a lawyer and an older man. I also wondered if his services would be free if we slept together, though that probably breached some law in its own right. But the photos of his family were really bringing my mood down. I wondered if this was a tactic lawyers used to make their clients trust them more; maybe these people weren’t even his children, but just well-positioned props. Hector caught me staring at the pictures and mistook my curiosity for admiration.

“Luca is eight and Mariela just turned three.” He smiled proudly.

“Cute,” I said, trying to sound like I cared.

“So how can I help you?” Hector stacked some papers on his desk. “You get in a little fender bender?”

I had been intentionally vague about why I required Jimenez and Sons' services on the phone. I didn't want to scare away a lawyer before I had the chance to hire them. Though I hadn't *technically* done anything wrong, it was easier to explain the situation in person.

"My boyfriend died," I said.

I wasn't sure how honest you were supposed to be with your lawyer about these things. If I had actually killed Henry, would I really tell my lawyer the truth? Did Robert Kardashian know that O. J. Simpson had killed Nicole Brown? Did Kris Jenner know? Did Khloe? Did Kendall? Hector raised his eyebrows, worry taking over his face. He composed himself quickly, pulling out a paper to jot down notes as I spoke.

"Were you involved in any way?" he asked.

"Well, no. But the police had me give a statement. It turns out he was seeing someone else. I just found out." I smoothed my hands over my pants. "But the night he died, we were in a fight, so I sent him a kind of shitty text," I admitted.

It felt good to talk to someone about what had happened. I glanced at the photo of Hector's wife on the table. She wasn't that pretty. Maybe I had a chance.

"I see." Hector leaned back in his chair, sizing me up. "And where were you on the night that he died?"

I let out a small laugh. Hector looked horrified.

"Sorry. I just thought they only said that in movies." I bit my bottom lip to compose myself. "I was with my friend Jamie and my roommate, Elise. I told the cops that, too."

Hector visibly relaxed. I had an alibi. I was innocent. He wasn't sitting across from a cold-blooded killer who had just laughed when asked where she was the night her boyfriend died. He would be able to defend me.

"Can you walk me through your relationship with the deceased from start to finish?" Hector asked.

I launched into my relationship history with Henry, giving details that might be pertinent to the case but leaving out anything that felt overly unflattering, like the fact that Henry had kind of broken up with me and the

details of our fight the morning after I stayed over at his apartment. I also told Hector about Nora: how suspicious she seemed and my theory on her and Henry's emotional demise. I debated if I should tell Hector about the hex; maybe he could advise me on what to do if this information came out. I didn't think Jamie would crack if questioned, but I couldn't be certain. I needed to be prepared in case she proved spineless under pressure.

"Is everything I tell you under, like, attorney-client privilege?" I asked.

"Um, yeah," he said. "If I take on your case," he added, going rigid like he was bracing for my murder confession.

"The night that Henry died, my friend and I did a stupid thing. It was a joke, really. But she's sort of freaked out about it, so it could come up if the police question her."

"Did you hurt anyone?" Hector asked.

"No. Nothing like that. We did this stupid YouTube hex. It was basically like a séance. Just something dumb to help me get closure from our fight." I smoothed my hair self-consciously.

"A hex?" Hector raised his eyebrows.

"Like, a curse, kind of?" I explained, realizing how certifiable it sounded out loud.

The more I spoke about it, the more I could see how this confession made me look like a woman on the edge. I wondered if Hector no longer found me attractive because of this admission; that was fine. We could keep our relationship professional. Maybe he loved his wife.

"It was dumb. We learned it from this influencer—the Wellness Witch—I don't know if you've heard of her. She's pretty popular. Anyways, it's supposed to, like, hex a person who's wronged you...but she's a total hack, so it was just stupid fun. We were drunk—"

"You were drinking the night Henry died?" Hector interrupted.

"Well, yeah, only a little," I lied.

"You just said you were drunk," Hector pressed.

"Am I already on trial?" I said, growing defensive but laughing to soften the edge in my voice.

“On the off chance it does go to trial, I need all the information.” He ran his hands over his desk nervously. “I’ve never represented a client in a murder trial before,” he admitted.

Based on their shitty office, malfunctioning website, and extremely low rates, I had assumed Jimenez and Sons wasn’t the premiere practice for first-degree murder defendants. I didn’t mind this; the fact that Hector had never represented a client in a homicide case wasn’t a deal-breaker because I wasn’t a murderer. I just needed someone to tell me what I should and shouldn’t say so the police wouldn’t wrongfully convict me. Someone to sit next to me and gently put their hand over my hand if I started to reveal anything incriminating. I needed someone to say “She doesn’t need to answer that” if the police asked a leading question. Hector would just be an overpaid babysitter until this nightmare was behind me.

“I didn’t do anything,” I said. “Other than the stupid hex thing.”

Hector sighed, glancing at the cross hanging in his office. I hadn’t noticed that before.

“It was more of a joke than anything,” I added.

“I don’t enjoy dealing with anything in the occult or satanic realm. Is this something you dabble in often?” he asked, sounding way too religious for my liking.

Was everyone superstitious except me? I had done one measly little curse; I wasn’t going to make a habit of it. And if I did have any actual power, Hector wasn’t making a wonderful first impression on me. He should really be more careful.

“I don’t dabble in the occult or anything satanic. It was really my friend Jamie’s idea,” I lied. “She suggested it.”

Hector sighed. “The good news is this doesn’t sound like something that a secular courtroom would care much about. But I suggest you don’t tell the police about this if they want to speak to you again. It still suggests a motive. And I shouldn’t say this out loud, but I would also ask your friend to abstain from talking about this hex. If it comes out, we’ll say you watched a YouTube video for fun. Is there any evidence of this hex in your apartment?” Hector asked.

“No.” I left out the fact that this was only because I had recently destroyed it.

“Okay, good.” He exhaled but still looked doubtful.

Hector opened up his laptop and pretended to search his computer for something, maybe the willpower to deny me as a client. I tried to use whatever untapped powers I had to force him to say yes to representing me. I wanted Hector to *want* to help me. I wanted him to look into my eyes and see his daughter, all grown up and in an unfortunate situation. Or maybe I wanted him to see me like I was his wife who had stumbled into some bad luck. I wanted him to fight for me like I was a part of him. It would be nice to have someone on my side—someone I could finally count on. After a long pause and what seemed like an intense internal debate, Hector looked at me and let out a breath.

“Okay,” he said. “I will represent you, Lillian.”

I smiled and glanced up at the cross on the wall, silently thanking the God that Hector believed in.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

HENRY'S WAKE WAS SET TO take place on Friday at a hockey rink in Milton, Massachusetts—where he had played growing up. I learned the details from his sister's Instagram profile after she'd posted a flyer with a picture of Henry surrounded by doves to her page. Her caption read:

I still can't believe I'm planning a wake for my beloved brother. Hosting Henry's celebration of life at a hockey rink might seem odd to some, but for those of you who knew—and loved—Henry, you know that hockey was his church. He played at this rink all the way up until college. I watched hundreds of Henry's games here. At the time, I was annoyed I had to go to them, but now...I would give anything to be back in the stands cheering on my sweet brother. Please join us in honoring our beloved Henry. All who loved him are welcome. XO Amelia.

It would be a closed-casket wake that took place in the lobby inside the rink. The whole idea felt distasteful, like a cheap stunt for attention. I was sure Henry would have hated it. He had never even mentioned hockey to me before—not even the Bruins. Was this really what he would have wanted? Some spectacle in a venue that smelled like jockstraps? Or was this his family's idea of closure, honoring a hobby that Henry probably didn't even care about anymore?

I asked Jamie to borrow her vintage black Prada dress for the occasion. It was the nicest thing she owned and had been passed down to her from her mother, who, unlike Jamie, was extremely stylish and probably wore it well. Jamie looked pained when I told her I was going to the ceremony.

Maybe she didn't want to give me the dress; I was a few pounds heavier than her, and it would take several layers of Spanx to fit into it, but I was up for the challenge.

"Do you really think it's a good idea for you to go?" Jamie asked.

"Of course I'm going," I insisted. "His sister said it was for anyone who loved him."

Jamie bit her bottom lip. "Didn't your lawyer tell you to lie low?"

"Hector would never expect me to miss Henry's wake. This is an integral part of the grieving process," I said.

Hector did, in fact, tell me to stay away from Henry's loved ones. I was planning on honoring this request with the exception of this one affair. I was already making a massive compromise by not going to the funeral, which was apparently for "intimate friends and family only." Though I did consider myself to be a part of that group, I couldn't track down where the service would be held, and calling funeral homes to inquire felt like it could be misinterpreted as slightly stalkerish.

"Won't his girlfriend be there?" Jamie asked.

I had considered this, of course. Nora being at the wake was an inevitability and actually a large part of why I wanted to go. I had consumed every piece of information I could find about her online, but it wasn't enough to really understand what she was like as a person. I needed to see her in real life; I needed to get close enough to spot her enlarged pores and the grease at the base of her scalp. I needed to see what her resting face looked like from a side angle. I needed her to be a real person and not a perfectly curated picture of Henry's infidelity. If I could get close to her, then maybe I would understand what she had meant to him—who she was to him in the end. Maybe I could confirm that their bond had deteriorated, that he had distanced himself from her in favor of a connection with me. I would mourn Henry, too, of course. I desperately needed to mourn him. Since his death, I had barely had time to process my own grief. But seeing Nora was a necessary part of that closure.

"You really want the Prada dress?" Jamie asked, like she would have rather walked into the ocean with weights on her feet.

“Yes, please,” I said.

Jamie exhaled. “Okay.”

HENRY’S WAKE WAS packed. There were hundreds of people at the hockey rink waiting to say goodbye to a good Boston boy gone too soon. They set up heat lamps and catering tables in the parking lot to service the overflowing crowd. There was a long and sweeping line that snaked through the parking lot, which had been cleared of any cars to accommodate the mass of bodies. Outside the rink, an electronic sign read “RIP Henry” with a dove emoji next to it. I wondered why doves had become the symbolic bird of death. I felt that a pigeon would be more appropriate for such an ugly ordeal.

I scanned the crowd and confirmed that I was the best-dressed person there by a landslide, and definitely one of the hottest. Many women in attendance hadn’t even bothered to do their makeup. Hadn’t they heard of waterproof mascara? Henry would be disappointed to see such a lack of effort from his attendees. I found a place in line and pulled out a small flask, taking a sip of vodka. I wasn’t going to see Nora—or dead Henry—sober. A person in line clocked me drinking from my flask and looked at me judgmentally. I poured a tiny bit onto the pavement and then gave a small point to the sky, indicating that I was pouring some out for Henry. The person seemed satisfied by this gesture and shot me a sympathetic smile, which I reciprocated.

After an hour, I calculated that I was moving about three feet every two minutes. The line was excruciatingly slow. Were people delivering soliloquies to Henry’s dead body inside? I stood on my toes to see how much farther it was to the entrance. There was still about a baseball field between me and the doors. I had finished my flask of vodka, and it was moving straight to my bladder. Or maybe I had a delayed UTI from having sex with Henry. The thought warmed me; it would be nice to still carry a piece of him with me, even if it was via a bacterial infection. I stepped out of line, looking back at the girl behind me—a teenager who had been glued

to her phone the entire time. I wondered if she knew Henry personally, or if she was just drawn to the tragedy from social media updates, like a moth to a flame.

“Can you hold my place if I come back?” I asked.

The teenager shrugged in response, invested in whatever she was consuming on her device. I hoped she would be hacked by a foreign bot for her rudeness. I moved toward the entrance of the rink, dodging annoyed glances from the people standing in line as I did. Why should I wait in a queue with these strangers? I had known Henry intimately. We dated. He had been inside me! I was carrying his UTI! I shouldn't be standing outside in the cold; I should be inside with his family and his other girlfriend, accepting condolences from the masses for my loss.

The entrance doors were kept open as the line wove through them. I half expected there to be security at the threshold checking IDs, but it was unguarded. I slithered past the line with an expression on my face that said *I belong here*, and no one dared to say that I didn't. A wake for a dead boy wasn't the kind of place to pick fights with strangers.

Inside the building, there were about twenty people in line leading up to Henry's closed casket. When I saw the coffin, I felt a surprising wave of panic with the realization that Henry's body was inside of it. The living, breathing, fucking man I had known was now dead. I let that sink in. Beside the casket, his mother, sister, and father stood slumped and despondent, receiving people. His mother was crying silently while his father had a solemn expression fixed on his face. Henry's sister, Amelia, was the only one out of the three who thanked every person who passed by, shaking each guest's hand dutifully, like she was handing out diplomas. I was impressed by her composure, but judging by her parents' near-catatonic state, she was stepping up out of necessity rather than desire. It was odd seeing Henry's family offline, mourning their son in real life. They were beautiful and polished, all with the same shade of brown hair that made them look like a picture-perfect family you might create on The Sims. I scanned the group for Nora, but she was nowhere to be found, though there was an odd space

between Amelia and her mother. Maybe she had just stepped out. In a just world, I would have been the one filling that void.

As I got closer to the family, a wave of dread coursed through my veins. I reminded myself that I had every right to be there; that I was grieving Henry, too. In fact, I had probably spent more quality time with him over the last four months than most of these people had. There was no reason to be ashamed that I was here. I raised my chin and smoothed my Prada dress, wondering if Amelia would compliment it. I reached Henry's father first. He offered me his hand and I took it, shaking tentatively. It was warm, calloused, and a little bit dry. I wished I had lotion in my purse that I could offer him.

"I'm sorry for your loss," I said softly.

Henry's father blinked in response. I kept moving. Next I looked at Henry's mother, whose bottom lip was quivering, as if she might break at any moment. I blinked to try and bring some wetness to my own eyes. I should have invested in a tear stick. It felt excruciating to look at her and not match her pain, which radiated from her body in a way that made her look less like a human and more like an animal with an explosive device forcibly strapped to it. I looked at my shoes, breaking eye contact.

"I'm sorry for your loss," I said.

She nodded and I kept moving.

Amelia was next in line. She met my eyes, holding my gaze. I could see her trying to place me in her mind. Would the police have told her about me?

"I'm so sorry for your loss," I repeated.

"Thank you," Amelia replied.

She shook my hand, holding it longer than I expected as she tried to work out who I might have been to her brother. Anxiety engulfed me. I wondered if she could feel my pulse beating between our interlocked hands.

"How did you know Henry, by the way?" she asked, our hands still moving up and down in perpetual motion.

"Volunteering," I claimed vaguely, pulling my sweaty hand back.

I moved away from the line quickly, my heart pounding. I glanced back at Amelia, who reluctantly drew her eyes away from me and onto the next person in the queue. She couldn't leave her station. I was safe. I scanned the lobby for restrooms and saw a sign that said "Women's Locker Room." I marched toward it, ducking inside.

The locker room was thankfully empty. The mobile bathrooms outside were designated for guests, and I was surprised to see so many people following the rules—all on their most respectful behavior. I had to pee like a Pekingese that had been locked inside the house all day. I rushed into one of the stalls and sat down on the toilet, grateful to be alone. I relaxed my bladder and a loud fart escaped, echoing through the bathroom like the space had been built just for the acoustics of my flatulence. I waited to hear if anyone laughed, a reflex from middle school, but there was no sound outside of the lingering drip of a leaky bathroom faucet. I closed my eyes, allowing myself to fully release. For a moment, I thought I might cry, but no tears came.

Outside the stall, the sink turned on. My cheeks burned. Someone else was in here, which meant they had heard me pass gas. I waited for the person to leave, but they seemed to be stalling, washing their hands for a full sixty seconds like a serial killer. Eventually, the water turned off and I heard them dry their hands. After a beat, it was silent again. They were gone.

I opened the stall door cautiously and made my way to the sink, where I washed my hands for a normal amount of time (seven seconds). Then I saw her in the mirror: Sitting on one of the locker room benches was Nora. Nora looked up, catching my eye in the reflection. I looked down quickly, hoping to avoid recognition. Nora and I were in the same room. We were in the same room and she had heard me fart. My cheeks turned a deep red.

I started to walk toward the exit, my hands still dripping wet. Now that she was only a few feet away from me, I couldn't imagine speaking to her. I couldn't look her in the eye. I wasn't ready to confront the woman who had shared my ex's heart and penis—not after she had heard me pass gas. I was almost at the door when she spoke.

“Lillian?” Nora said.

I stopped moving. She knew my name. She knew my name and she was addressing me by it.

“Lillian, I know that it’s you.”

I turned around slowly to face her, allowing myself to look at her fully now. She was annoyingly quite pretty in person. She was still basic, but she looked good—especially with the slight redness she had around her eyes from crying. She wore a simple black dress with a high square neck and low black heels. There wasn’t a blond hair out of place on her head, and her blue eyes were even more piercing in person. She looked like someone who would play the only nondepressed character in a Sally Rooney adaptation.

“Do I know you?” I said weakly.

Nora took a deep breath. “The police told me about you. I assumed they might have told you about me, too,” she said.

Of course she had spoken to the police. Her—our—boyfriend had been murdered. They would explore all avenues, Detective Jennings had said. I guess one of those avenues would be telling Henry’s long-term girlfriend about his shorter-term girlfriend.

“I also looked you up online after I saw the texts between you two,” she said.

She had seen my texts? Didn’t the police need a warrant—or my consent—to share those with other people? Was that legal? Or maybe she had gone through Henry’s phone after he died. I wondered what my internet persona looked like from her point of view. I wondered if she felt threatened by me, if she found herself reading my bio on my company’s website and comparing her accomplishments to my own. I wondered if she had zoomed in on the curve of my cheek on Instagram to search for any signs of Facetune, like I had done to her. I cursed myself for not better curating my online footprint before she had seen it. I wanted to archive any Instagram photos taken before 2020, when I didn’t know how to do my eye makeup and had briefly thought an eyebrow ring was a good idea. I felt exposed knowing she might not have seen the best version of me.

“Are you here to apologize to me?” Nora asked.

“What?” I blurted, physically taking a step back.

Did she seriously think I had come to this wake to seek her forgiveness? If anything, she should be apologizing to me. I was the true victim here. I was the one forced to stand in the shadows while I mourned. Plus, it was likely Nora’s looming presence that had soured my relationship with Henry. She was the hurdle we couldn’t overcome—the reason Henry hadn’t chosen me. And I was doomed from the start anyway; how could I have won against a girl like this? She was polished, blond, and integrated with his family; men didn’t know how to end relationships with women like that, no matter how much they might want to. And now she wanted an apology for something Henry—and, by proxy, she—had done to me. I didn’t owe her anything. I was the one who had lost everything and was forced to be quiet about it.

“An apology? For what?” I spat.

Nora raised her eyebrows, shocked. “For fucking my boyfriend.”

“Maybe you forgot how sex works, but it takes two people,” I said.

Nora closed her mouth and held it in a thin line. She pinched the space between her eyebrows and took a deep breath. “Of course Henry is responsible, too. But I can’t exactly confront him about anything anymore.”

“Well, I’m not sure why I would apologize to you. I did nothing wrong.”

Nora removed her hands from her face. She looked like she was going to cry. Maybe I should have offered an olive branch. Maybe I should have said I regretted the unfortunate position we both had found ourselves in—that it wasn’t wholly either of our faults. But I didn’t. She’d started this fight. She should be ready to end it.

“I read the texts between you guys. I saw the photos you sent him. I know he played his part, but you were so...aggressive with him,” she said.

“It was mutual,” I claimed, annoyed.

“You once texted him six times in a row without an answer,” she said.

“I don’t remember that,” I lied.

I did remember it. Two months ago, I had done shrooms with Jamie and decided that overcommunication wasn’t necessarily a bad thing. I’d asked

Henry to hang out, and when he didn't answer, I sent him an article about deep-sea fishing; then a TikTok about a feral cat that was being rehabilitated; then a tit pic; then a movie trailer for a film I had no intention of watching; then, in a desperate moment, a text saying my mom was direly sick (she wasn't). He finally answered and said he hoped my mother felt better. In retrospect, he was probably with Nora at the time.

"If he said he wasn't free, you didn't drop it. You sent topless photos when he wouldn't answer you," she said.

"That's a violation for you to look at those. And illegal," I added, though I wasn't quite sure if that was true.

I was embarrassed she had seen my boobs. From the looks of it, she might have bested me in the tit department. But what did she know about my relationship with Henry? I had never been "aggressive." Our dynamic was a sexy push and pull. It was erotic. Given the sexless, stagnant state of her and Henry's connection, it was unsurprising that she didn't understand the games people played while courting each other.

"He was in love with me," I said, hoping to shut her up.

Nora looked like she had been punched in the stomach.

"He told you that?" she asked.

"Yes," I lied.

Nora looked like she was going to be sick.

"He said he had never felt how he felt toward me with anyone else. That I was the best sex of his life. He said that he was going to leave you," I claimed, pouring salt on the wound.

"Oh," Nora said, the blood draining from her face. Good. She looked worse this way. "I—I didn't realize he was thinking about ending things with me." Her face turned from sad to angry in a flash. "So, you *did* know about me, then?"

Shit.

I had made a mistake. Now Nora would think I was willfully—even gleefully—the other woman. This was the exact kind of negative characterization that I had been trying to avoid. In one comment, I had just

confirmed all her worst suspicions of me—suspicions that, by all accounts, weren't even accurate.

"I mean, I thought he'd already left you," I backtracked.

I didn't know where I was going with this. I willed my brain to remember what I was saying in case it came up in a future court of law.

"He mentioned he had broken up with someone recently. He said he was scared of her—that she wouldn't accept the breakup. I wonder if that's relevant for the police?" I said, attempting to inspire some fear in Nora so she would back off.

And maybe Henry had been scared of her. It wasn't a bad question to pose. She was certainly being combative with me; she had cornered me in a bathroom, where no one else could intervene. Who was to say she hadn't hurt Henry?

Nora shifted on her feet, uncomfortable. "You're full of shit," she said.

A tear escaped her eye. She wiped it away angrily. "Why are you even here? Why are you doing this to me? Can't you see I'm fucking grieving?" she said, her voice getting louder.

"I'm grieving, too!" I yelled, shocking myself at the volume of my own voice. "I have just as much of a right to be here as you! As anyone! He loved me, too!" I barked.

"I was with him for almost ten years!" she volleyed back.

"And your relationship was probably stale as fuck!" I spat.

I could feel the adrenaline coursing through my body. It felt good to yell at her, to remind her that I was just as affected by this as she was. Henry and I might not have had ten years together, but that didn't mean I was immune to the pain of his death. She had already gotten a life with him—mine had been cut short. The anger rose in me, turning my breath ragged like that of a bull getting ready to charge.

"He didn't want you. He wanted me," I said firmly, and the words rang true.

Nora put her hand on her stomach like she had been shot. She was so dramatic.

The locker room door swung open. Henry's mother and sister walked in, taking in the scene before them.

"Nora, what's going on here?" Henry's mother asked, her arms crossed.

"This is her. This is the crazy girl that he was cheating on me with," Nora choked out. The level at which she was crying was really overkill.

Amelia glanced at me, finally putting the pieces together.

"This cannot happen here," Henry's mother hissed, clearly more worried about her son's reputation than either of his ex-girlfriends' feelings. "You need to go," she said, looking at me. "Right now."

"I have a right to be here," I said.

"Leave," Amelia said sternly. "Please."

"She's horrible," Nora whispered, half to herself. "I don't get it."

"You need to go," Henry's mother said again.

"He would have wanted me here." I tried to hold firm.

"Well, we don't." Amelia glared at me.

I swallowed, feeling the emotional reverberation of those words.

This was not how I had imagined meeting Henry's family. I had always pictured us at a small and intimate dinner together, where his mother whispered to Henry how much she liked me and his sister joked that I was too good for him. I looked at Henry's mom—a person who could have been my future mother-in-law. Who I could have spent holidays cooking with, watching *It's a Wonderful Life* as we tipsily sank into Henry's family couch. A woman who could have just as easily been on my side—not Nora's. But because Nora had gotten to Henry first, everyone was looking at me like I was the loose thread that had undone their perfect lives.

I hated them all for it. I would not let these women make me feel small.

"It's not my fault your son couldn't keep his dick in his pants," I spat, then breezed past the three women as Henry's mother's mouth hung open in shock.

Finally, I could see the resemblance between her and her son.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

HECTOR WAS FURIOUS. APPARENTLY, HENRY'S family had called the police and reported an "altercation" between Nora and me at the wake, and the police had then relayed this information to Hector. Hector asked me to come to his office to discuss a game plan should the police want to bring me back in for questioning after my "erratic behavior." I didn't understand why I was the one in trouble. I had a right to attend Henry's wake. And I was in mourning. If I reacted less than perfectly to being accosted by Henry's other girlfriend (and potential murderer), then that deserved a bit of grace.

In the office, Hector was staring at me like I was a foster kid who had just been kicked out of their last-shot home. He didn't make an effort to hide that he was disappointed, and probably a little scared of me.

"Why did you go?" he asked.

"To get closure," I said, like he was a moron.

Was this really so hard to believe? Where was anyone's compassion? I wondered if this was how Nick Cannon's various baby mamas felt; they were constantly being judged for loving a man with too much love to give. I made a mental note to have more empathy for all six of them going forward.

"The police still aren't considering you an official suspect, but getting into a fight with Nora certainly doesn't help," he said.

"She's the one who approached me," I rebutted, irritated.

"Henry's mother claimed it was very inappropriate. The guests could hear you two yelling even with the door closed."

"My boyfriend died. I'm allowed to be upset."

"Yeah." Hector sighed. "We'll stick with the closure story."

"It's not a story," I insisted.

“Right. Sorry. It’s just—we’ve got to make them understand why you would go to the same place as his girlfriend. Not a lot of people would do that.”

I got the feeling that Hector didn’t know many women outside of his wife. Women were terrifying, vindictive creatures. We stalked each other online and competed relentlessly. We would cut a beating heart out of another woman’s body if it made our own stronger. What had happened between Nora and me was a kind of hatred that could only happen between two women who had cared about the same thing—and it was the most natural thing in the world.

“By the way, have you told your parents what’s going on?” Hector asked. “It would be good if they were primed on the situation in case the police want to cast a wider net and look into your history.”

“My dad passed away,” I said.

“Your dad’s dead?” A concerned look painted his face again.

“Yes,” I said.

“How did he die?”

Jesus Christ, did Hector think I killed my father?

“Drunk driving. When I was a kid. I never had a relationship with him, though.”

“Hmm,” Hector said, considering this.

A lot of people assumed that my not having a dad explained everything about me. I think it was easier for people to imagine that I was a textured person because of some deep past trauma rather than the reality: I was born this way. I considered Hector’s suggestion to share the news with my mother and wondered how she would react to it. I had been dodging her calls for a week, sending her texts to tide her over but refusing to get on the phone with her. I knew once we spoke, I wouldn’t be able to keep the news from her any longer. But now—per my lawyer’s orders—I had to tell her.

“I’ll tell my mom,” I relented.

“Good,” Hector said.

I stood up and collected my stuff. With each meeting we had, Hector became slightly less attractive to me. I reminded myself that this was a

good thing.

“Do you go to church?” Hector asked.

“What?” I said, taken aback.

“It might be good for you.”

So now this was a religious intervention. I considered whether it was too late to hire a new lawyer. But I had already given him Jamie’s credit card information and charged a deposit to Jimenez and Sons. And Hector was familiar with my case. I couldn’t turn back at this point.

“I don’t need Jesus,” I said curtly. “I need a lawyer.”

I grabbed my tote bag and stormed out of the office.

ON THE BUS ride home, I called my mother. Part of me hoped my signal would drop and I would have an excuse to put off breaking the news a little bit longer. Though if we did speak, at least the people around me would have something juicy to eavesdrop on. I imagined their eyes bulging when they realized this poor girl on public transport had lost her boyfriend. I was happy to be a conversation topic for these strangers; I was never afraid to be the main character of someone else’s life.

My mother answered immediately. It made me sad that she had nothing better to do than wait for my calls. She still worked the same office job she had had since I was a child, except she had been promoted from receptionist to office manager over those twenty years. This title bump and her tenure had shifted her annual salary from \$25,000 a year to \$43,000. If I thought about it for too long, it made me want to walk into the Charles River.

“It’s about time,” my mother answered.

“Hi, Mom.”

“What’s wrong?” she said by default.

“Henry’s dead.”

A girl across from me stopped reading her book and looked up at me, suddenly aware that there was an interesting person in her proximity. I locked eyes with her, and she looked back down, embarrassed.

“OHMAHGAHD,” my mom screamed, her Boston accent jumping out like it did during emergency situations. “Whatthefhellhappenedbabyareyou okayohmahgahd.”

“I’m okay,” I said. “He was stabbed—”

“OHMAHGAHDHONEYOHMAHGAHD,” she gasped.

Several people on the train were looking at me now. I looked back at a few of them like: *Yeah, my life sucks, my boyfriend is dead.*

“I’m driving there tonight,” she said.

“No! Mom, don’t,” I pleaded.

“Lillian, this is insane!” she shrieked. “You need me!”

The last thing I needed was my mother in my apartment. Elise had already been hesitant about not telling the police that she was wearing earplugs the night of the murder. She insisted that she felt it was “important information,” though I promised her it wasn’t. I told her if every microscopic detail of our day was to be reported to the police, then Elise should also tell them that she left a skid mark on the bottom of the toilet bowl the day that Henry died. Maybe they would need to sample it and confirm it wasn’t Henry’s feces in our communal bathroom. This shut her up. Still, it was the closest she had ever been to standing up to me. I didn’t want anything to push her over the edge. If my mother came to town, she would sleep on the couch, drink Barefoot wine, and play “Fast Car” on repeat until Elise decided to blow my alibi out of spite. Then the police would look into me further, scraping my computer and unearthing my since-deleted YouTube search for the hex, plus all the questionable porn I watched. Maybe they would figure out that I hadn’t properly filed my taxes in a couple years and nab me for that. I hadn’t hurt Henry, but I didn’t need the Boston PD poking around my life to prove that.

“I want to be alone,” I said. “Jamie has been helpful, though,” I added.

“Well, Jamie’s in love with you,” my mother exhaled.

“I had to talk to the police, but everything is okay. I have a lawyer—” I said.

“The police! And you have a lawyer?! Oh, honey, this isn’t good.” She was really spiraling now. I could picture her pinched expression on the

other end of the phone. I imagined her pulling a hangnail off of her finger until it bled, sticking it in her mouth to stop the bleeding with her phone propped against her ear.

“It’s a precautionary lawyer,” I said, trying to comfort her.

“That’s an expensive precaution,” she said.

“He’s doing it pro bono,” I lied. “He has a daughter. He said I remind him of her.”

“Aw.” My mom perked up. “Is he single?”

I wasn’t sure if she meant for her or for me. Either way, I knew I had to get her off the phone. I promised her seven to twelve more times that everything was going to be okay and that I would update her if anything changed. Thirty seconds after we hung up, she texted me:

I AM ALWAYS HERE AND I ALWAYS WILL BE.

EVERYTHING IS GONNA BE OKAY.

I LOVE YOU.

YOU SURE U DON’T WANT ME TO COME?

JUST SAW THE ARTICLE.

STABBED FOUR TIMES!

OUCH.

😞 SAD.

I shoved my phone into my bag. The bus lurched to a halt, and I realized we were at my stop. I stood up. The woman across from me hadn’t flipped a single page in her book.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

WHEN I GOT HOME, ELISE was still at work. I decided to take advantage of the empty apartment and spend some time online-sleuthing Nora. I made sure to search for her in an incognito tab, now more conscious of the police presence that was looming over my life like a dark cloud. I poured myself a midday glass of wine that reached the brim so I wouldn't have to get back up to get more, and settled onto my couch.

After the wake, Nora had blocked me on Instagram. At first, I was stung by this. Then the hurt soured into anger that I hadn't had the opportunity to block her first. Nora was lucky that I wasn't actually a stalker, because she wasn't nearly savvy enough to elude my online gaze. She had a public profile, and I imagined that Nora had debated making her account private after meeting me, but I knew she couldn't stand the idea of not capitalizing off her boyfriend's death and the new followers the tragedy brought with it.

To watch her stories, I'd created a private account called goblingirlxo with a picture of Smeagol from *Lord of the Rings* as my avatar so I could easily lurk on Nora from the shadows. I'd found myself watching her from my secret account until late in the night. I wondered if the police were keeping tabs on her as adeptly as I was.

Since Henry's passing, I had watched Nora's profile climb from seven hundred followers to nearly six thousand. She was still a ways away from being a micro influencer and getting a brand deal for HelloFresh, but she was getting there. Sometimes I masturbated while looking at photos of her—not because I was attracted to her, but because I wanted to know how it would feel, which it turned out was: pretty good.

From what I'd gleaned in the past week, in addition to event planning and following thirty-four goldendoodle accounts, Nora also appeared to be

an aspiring writer. She had an Instagram highlight labeled “words” where she pinned shitty poems and short stories she had written.

I hadn’t checked Nora’s Instagram since leaving for Hector’s office that morning, but I assumed I would return to much of the same content: non-update updates about Henry’s murder, posts with long-winded captions about their time together, pictures of tea with the caption “self-care,” and various historical quotes about martyrdom that she felt somehow applied to her situation—including one from Maya Angelou.

But when I opened up her profile, I noticed a new grid post. It was a screenshot of a *Teen Vogue* article. The headline read:

My Boyfriend Died...Then I Found Out He Was Cheating on Me.

My stomach dropped so quickly I thought it might fall out of my butt, shooting a Magic School Bus full of kids out with it.

Nora’s caption read:

I have been debating writing this. But sometimes the only way to process our feelings is to put them out in the open, for all to look at. Thank you, in advance, for your kindness and compassion.

I clicked on the article.

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My Boyfriend Died...Then I Found Out He Was Cheating on Me By Nora McCormick

Henry and I met at Brown University the spring of our freshman year. He was studying Economics while I was studying Communications and Media. Henry and I had mutual

friends on our dorm room floor and one night found ourselves at the same party. I liked his scruffy hair and the fact that he read books for fun. He liked that I played *Mario Kart* and didn't wear a lot of makeup. When he offered me a Solo cup full of beer, I couldn't help but feel like I was accepting a drink from my future husband. It felt like destiny. Serendipity, even. Later that night, after drinking one too many Miller Lites, we kissed. We never stopped kissing after that.

Two weeks ago, I found out that Henry—my boyfriend of nearly ten years—had been killed in cold blood outside a bar in Somerville, Massachusetts. If you're from the Boston area, you may have seen it in the news. His case still hasn't been solved, and every day I wait by my phone hoping for answers and justice. I didn't get out of bed for nearly three days after I found out that the man I had spent my life with was dead. We shared an apartment, and everything about our place still screams "Henry" to this day. It still smells like him. In fact, I still have the last towel he used hanging on the back of our bathroom door. It's still a little bit wet.

I am devastated that Henry was taken from us too soon. I grieve with his family and friends every day over this earth-shattering loss. For my part, I feel like my other half is missing. He was the person I thought I was going to marry—to have kids with. He was the person I talked to after a bad day, the one I leaned on when my grandma (who I was very close with) died last year. We were even planning on getting a goldendoodle together and calling it Golden Nugget. We were supposed to have so much more time ahead of us.

But it turns out, I didn't know everything about my boyfriend.

During the police's investigation into Henry's murder, they informed me that Henry had been seeing another woman for the last four months of his life. When I found this out, I felt like

he was dying all over again. I will call the woman Henry was seeing “Jane” to protect her identity for this piece, though that is not her real name.

This past year, I started doing event planning at a small company in Boston. I’ve always been a writer, but event planning is how I pay my bills. For the most part, I love it. It has been a rocky but rewarding road. In any given month, I take anywhere from two to three trips around the country, and I typically work late at least three times a week. I love my clients and my company, but the time apart had been hard for me and Henry. I thought we were managing the distance with frequent texts and FaceTime calls, and by sharing the occasional midday TikTok. But while I was working to establish myself in my new position, Henry was establishing a relationship with someone else.

When the police showed me Henry and Jane’s text exchanges, I almost fainted. I couldn’t believe that my partner of ten years—my sweet Henry—would do something like this to me. I was surprised to see the woman he had chosen, too. She was the complete opposite of me. I am a feminist, so I won’t waste time detailing all the ways in which we’re physically different; like our queen Taylor Swift says: I refuse to pit women against each other. All you need to know is this woman is not like me at all.

At first, I didn’t want to blame Jane for my boyfriend’s indiscretion. Maybe she hadn’t known about me, after all. But when I went through Henry’s phone after he died, I saw that Jane’s texts to Henry were not only forward, but extremely aggressive. I am in no way excusing Henry’s behavior, but merely acknowledging that it would be hard for *any man* to say no to advances like that. In fact, there were many times when Henry tried to politely let Jane down, but she insisted they keep seeing each other. Again, I don’t want to point the

finger solely at Jane. It takes two to tango. I was even willing to forgive Jane.

That is, until she showed up at Henry's wake.

Again, you may have seen this in the news, but we held Henry's wake at his favorite childhood hockey rink. It was a special place to both of us. I sat in the stands countless times cheering on his travel hockey team, and I drank so many hot cocoas in that rink that I get a stomachache just thinking about it. It was a formative place for us as a couple.

Jane and I ran into each other in the bathroom of the hockey rink where the wake was held. Once again, I don't want to be cruel, but I noticed someone was in the bathroom when I heard a person loudly pass gas. (Which is okay! Everybody farts! Let's not fault Jane for that.) I was outside the stall when Jane exited. Before I could second-guess myself, I said hello. I suppose I wanted to talk to this woman and to try to understand what the man I loved so deeply had seen in her. Call me crazy, but I had to say something. I tried to be polite—I really did. But the interaction that proceeded to take place has stayed with me since that day. It's ultimately what compelled me to write this piece.

Jane was not apologetic at all about Henry cheating on me with her. She was cruel and said horrible things to me that bring tears to my eyes even now as I think about it. She claimed that Henry didn't love me, and revealed that she had known about me all along. It became very clear that Jane came to Henry's wake with one intention and one intention only: to hurt me. And spoiler alert: She succeeded!

The conversation ended in an extremely tense altercation that Henry's mother and sister were forced to break up when they found me in shambles, cornered by Jane as she screamed violently at me. I've been thinking about this interaction quite a bit in the days that have followed the wake. I've realized there

are many things I can't control: I can't confront Henry about how he disrespected our relationship, nor can I change what happened between him and Jane. But I can control the kind of woman I am. I firmly believe there are two types of women in this world: women who lift each other up, and women who tear each other down. Jane is a woman who seeks to tear other women down. And for that day: She succeeded. She won.

With the encouragement of my therapist, I decided to no longer stay silent about my story. I decided to do the thing that always makes me feel better when nothing else works: write about it. For all the women who have been cheated on: I am here for you. For all the women who have lost partners: I am here for you. For all the women who have lost partners AND been cheated on: I am here for you. It's okay to have complicated feelings about your relationship! It's okay to love your late partner, but also toss and turn at night wondering how they could have done this to you. Maybe we can find solace in knowing that we're not alone. Maybe we can lean on each other. Maybe we can lift each other up. Maybe we can meet each other with the kindness and compassion that I so wish I'd gotten from Jane that day. So that's what I hope this piece will do: lift others who have been through something similar up.

Let us all be Taylor Swifts in a world full of Janes.

CHAPTER TWENTY

I WAS TWITCHING WITH FURY. How dare she publish this about me? It was a small consolation that Nora was a shitty writer. Her prose read like that of a sixteen-year-old Wattpad teen who had just proudly published a dissertation on why Jacob and Edward should ditch Bella and fuck each other instead. I navigated back to Nora's Instagram profile to read the comments, which were flooding in at an alarming rate. There were dozens of people who had not only already read the article, but who were ready to share their thoughts. Many praised Nora for her bravery; others simply left heart emojis. One person said that writing about Henry so soon after his death was in poor taste—that it was unfair he wasn't around to defend himself. I was glad to see there were at least a few sane people left on the internet.

I marched over to the bottle of wine that I had planned on drinking over the course of the night, and I brought it back to the couch, taking a large swig from it and pouring the rest into my glass. After checking to make sure that I was on my secret Instagram account, I commented on Nora's post:

This is fucked up she wrote this.

I hit send.

Anyone else thinking it? Nora totally killed him!

I hit send.

Ummmm...I smell motive!

I hit send.

Justice for Jane! I wanna hear her side!

I hit send.

This is in such poor taste.

I hit send.

I was itching with unfocused outrage. I needed to do something. I needed to right this wrong. I wanted to yell at Nora. And maybe extract one of her teeth while she was unsedated, like they did in mob movies. I wanted to get the *Teen Vogue* editor who had commissioned this shitty piece fired. I brainstormed that avenue: What was the best way to quickly get someone canceled? I decided I would search the editor's tweets for problematic words later on. I went to Nora's comments, refreshing over and over, waiting for people to like goblingirlxo's stance on the situation. No one did.

I navigated back to the *Teen Vogue* article. It wouldn't hurt to leave a few comments there, too. *Teen Vogue* was the offshoot of a prestigious brand, after all. They needed to be more responsible with the kinds of things they published. The internet was an endless pit of information; it was only a matter of time before someone deduced that I was the subject of this piece. In a way, it was slander. I made a note in my phone to ask Hector if I could sue Nora for defamation, even if she hadn't used any identifying details. By positioning herself as Taylor Swift and me as the oppositional "Jane," she could easily turn the masses against me. Swifties could do anything they wanted to when they were motivated enough. They could crash the stock market, solve climate change, and convince the entire world that Harry Styles had been wearing a wig for the last ten years. I did not want to be on their bad side.

I scrolled to the comment section at the bottom of the article.

Who edited this?

I hit send.

I can't believe this got published.

I hit send.

His body isn't even cold yet. Thought Teen Vogue was better than this.

I hit send.

Will not be financially supporting Teen Vogue anymore.

I hit send.

I had never financially contributed to *Teen Vogue*, or any other publication, for that matter. I hadn't made a charitable donation in my life, unless you counted giving a homeless person my Lebanese leftovers one time. But I knew the only way you could get a company to care about something was with a looming financial threat. No corporation actually had moral values. Glossier would sell hand grenades in pastel pink if their customers showed an appetite for it. I navigated back to the *Teen Vogue* home page, where Nora's piece was splashed across the front of the site. Accompanying the headline was a photo of a man lying between two women in bed; a skull emoji had been placed directly over the man's face. Henry would be rolling over in his grave if he saw this. *This is the bitch you picked over me*, I said to his ghost.

My phone buzzed. It was Jamie. I assumed she had seen the article. She was obsessed with me and had nothing better to do than to stay on top of the situation. I debated ignoring her, but I needed to talk to someone.

“Hello?” I answered.

“Have you seen it?” Jamie asked.

I appreciated that she was at least giving me the courtesy of being honest. I didn’t have the bandwidth for her Hallmark Channel acting today.

“I just read it.”

Jamie let out a breath. “Are you okay?”

“What do you think?” I said coldly.

I didn’t know why I was so mean to Jamie. She made it too easy to be rude, and she forgave me far too quickly when I was. I knew I should be thankful to have her as a friend. My other friends were less consistent about answering my texts, and I rarely saw them in person. I had one friend, Alexa from yoga, but I really only saw her at yoga, and she also did teach the class. I also had a group of friends from high school, Jenna, Sara, and Courtney, but the three of them had all gotten married last year, and not one of them had bothered to invite me. Now they all were simultaneously pregnant, like some heterosexual cult. When I thought about it, I guess Jamie was my only real friend aside from my mom, and I did value that. But there was an undercurrent of judgment in Jamie’s voice lately that made it near impossible not to snap at her.

“Do you want me to come over?” Jamie asked.

I wondered if she was sitting in her apartment alone, staring at her phone while she waited for me to beckon her, like an overeager genie. I debated if I wanted to be around her right now. It would be nice to have someone to drink with. Drinking alone was the marker of a true alcoholic, and I didn’t want to be a true alcoholic, just a social one. When you started creeping toward thirty, getting blackout drunk and having a hangover on a Wednesday began to seem like less of a fun and interesting story, and more of a coping mechanism for something deeper. Plus, Elise wouldn’t be home for a few more hours, and being around her was like hanging out with a piece of cooked pasta anyway.

“Yeah. Come on over,” I said to Jamie.

JAMIE ARRIVED WITH a fifth of cheap vodka that had been collecting dust in her apartment. She said she'd wanted to pick up wine for us, but that she was saving money for the lawyer fees. She glanced at me when she mentioned this, waiting for me to say, "I'll pay you back," but Rihanna would release new music before I offered Jamie a penny of my own money. I had started looking at my legal defense like it was free since it wasn't coming out of my pocket. It was a huge relief to not deal with the financial burden on top of the emotional stress of losing someone. Messaging Hector had become a vital part of my daily routine. I had even started sending him memes at night, not really caring that these texts might be tallied into one big billable hour. He didn't usually answer, but sometimes he would react to a text with a thumbs-up, which felt like a win.

Jamie and I tore through the vodka quickly as I outlined every terrible physical trait Nora had, as well as my rising suspicion that she was the one who killed Henry. Jamie nodded and said "yeah" or "totally" at the moments that called for it, but her heart wasn't in it. I could tell. After about an hour of Nora-centric vitriol and some speculation on whether anyone would assume I was "Jane," I started to tire out. I turned on *RuPaul's Drag Race* to distract myself. I could sense from Jamie's reactions that my commentary was toeing the line between entertaining and the kind of thing women get called anti-feminist over. I didn't feel like being lectured tonight.

After one episode of *Drag Race*, I realized I was pretty drunk. I had already had a bottle of wine before Jamie arrived, and I felt myself sinking into the couch, my muscles loose from the booze. I didn't know if it was the alcohol or my loneliness, but I gradually started to scooch closer to Jamie as the show went on. I hadn't checked my dating apps since Henry died; prowling for sex felt dishonorable after your boyfriend prematurely kicked it. But I was craving affection. Physical touch released oxytocin, which was good for the body and brain. I tried to think of the last time I had truly been touched by another person. There were a couple handshakes here and there: one with Hector, the ones with Henry's family at the wake. There was the occasional crowded train ride where I found myself grazing against

someone who smelled nice. But I hadn't been meaningfully touched since Henry. And our last night together wasn't exactly perfect. I needed a palate cleanser.

I looked at Jamie, who kept talking to me/the television, mumbling half sentences and jokes that she didn't bother finishing. For a woman who didn't know how to apply makeup, she had a lot of opinions on drag queens' eyebrows. When she was absorbed with something, Jamie was actually kind of attractive. I understood that she was appealing to many people; I had seen men and women alike turn their heads at her on the street and in pubs. In college, a girl named Rachel had been infatuated with Jamie, asking her to join the intramural kickball team and various other gay extracurricular activities. Jamie and Rachel grew close during this time, so much so that I couldn't hang out with Jamie without Rachel waiting in the wings, like a queer MI6 agent. Jamie was too naive to see that Rachel was unhealthily obsessed with her. To protect Jamie, I told her I had gone to a fortune teller who had warned me of a woman named Rachel with a deceptive spirit. This was—of course—a lie, but Jamie had always been superstitious, so she stopped seeing Rachel, and I got my friend back. According to Facebook, Rachel was now an avid Disney adult, so I could confirm that my protective instinct had actually done Jamie a favor.

Jamie and I had kissed once before in college. We were at a frat party that was being held in the depths of hell: a basement in Allston, Massachusetts. I was trying to attract the attention of a guy I liked named Sam Frankel, who I knew was into queer women. I understood that using a friend to attract the gaze of a queer-chaser was wrong, but I really wanted to fuck Sam, so I'd been willing to try anything to get his attention. I'd kissed Jamie, keeping my eyes slightly open to make sure Sam was looking. I didn't remember much about the kiss other than it was sloppy and that Sam and I successfully made eye contact during it. When we pulled apart, Jamie had a wide grin on her face. Fifteen minutes later, I detached myself from her and had sex with Sam in an empty bedroom upstairs. I couldn't recall why Sam and I didn't work out. I think he ended up pursuing the lesbian who led the gay-straight alliance on campus. Jamie brought up our kiss

occasionally, as if it was proof that we had really lived in college. For my part, I hadn't thought about kissing her again until tonight. I made a mental list of pros and cons of kissing Jamie in my head.

Pros

- She looks nice lit by the television
- I'm bored
- Could be a good distraction
- I haven't been touched in a long time (relative)
- She's obsessed with me
- It would make her day
- She looks clean
- She probably brushed her teeth recently
- She's probably improved her kissing since college
- She's probably ~~good~~ giving in bed

Cons

- She's in love with me
- She's maybe my only friend left (relative)
- She's too earnest
- She has no sense of humor
- I don't like her toes
- I don't like hearing her chew
- She cries randomly about Steve Irwin
- She always wants to talk about politics
- Her face looks weird from the side
- I don't actually want to see her vagina

Reviewing my mental list, the reasons to kiss Jamie were much better than those not to. Sure, it would be a temporary distraction from my current issues, and likely a confusing one for her. But then again, it might feel nice for both of us. I wondered if she would expect some kind of romantic

declaration after a kiss, or if she would let it be easily forgotten. I was nearly thirty. I knew I was supposed to move through the world making choices with some awareness for the consequences, but I didn't feel any heightened sense of responsibility as I got older. Instead, I only had an increased awareness of the shame I was supposed to feel. I felt like Dexter Morgan, making choices that were ultimately for the best, but that would be difficult to explain to others. But unlike Dexter, I wasn't a murderer.

On *Drag Race*, RuPaul was at the judging portion of the runway. Michelle Visage, his co-judge, was destroying one of the girls for wearing a leotard and tights on the runway. I wondered how many times Michelle would have to give this same lesson before the queens finally learned. Jamie was enthusiastically nodding her head in agreement with the critiques, which briefly gave me the ick, but I brushed it off. I poured some more vodka into my glass, adding a splash of LaCroix to be responsible, and took a sip of my drink. Then I leaned over to Jamie and grabbed her face in my hands. She looked shocked, like a child who had just been told they needed a tooth extraction and it was happening right now. I ignored her expression and leaned in and kissed her. Jamie's mouth was still for a moment until she slowly opened it and let my tongue in. I roamed around her mouth like I was Nicolas Cage searching for the Declaration of Independence, but the declaration was our chemistry and it was proving extremely difficult to find. Jamie pulled back after a minute of aimless slobbering.

"What are you doing?" she asked.

"Isn't it obvious?" I volleyed back.

"Okay. But...why are you doing it?"

"I thought it might feel nice."

Jamie considered this.

"Do you like me?" she asked.

"Of course I do."

"I didn't think you did—like that—I mean."

She needed to stop talking before she ruined this.

"Yeah, I like you," I said reassuringly. "You're so pretty."

Jamie looked like she was making her own pro and con list. She opened her mouth like she was going to ask me another question and then closed it again. She glanced back at the television, where RuPaul was about to announce his winner. She drew her eyes back to me.

“It’s not a big deal,” I assured her.

Jamie didn’t really hook up with people. Maybe she was demisexual, if that was a thing that existed and not just another word created by my generation to make us feel special. From my understanding, being demisexual entailed being attracted to someone’s mind and the emotional connection you had with them rather than just their physical body. I had been told before that I had a very interesting mind, so her being attracted to me made perfect sense if she was demisexual. Jamie opened and closed her mouth again. I leaned toward her in a way that said *Take it or leave it*, as if it was my last offer at a flea market. Jamie finally leaned closer to me and made contact with my lips.

The kiss was better now that both of us were participating in it. For someone who I suspected was a virgin, Jamie didn’t kiss like one. She had a slow and intentional rhythm to her kissing. It was romantic, but not super sexual. I put my hand behind her neck and pulled her closer to me. I had planned on only kissing Jamie, but now that it was happening, I considered the idea of doing more. It would be interesting to explore my friend’s body. Also, it would be nice to have a new sexual experience so the last person who entered me wasn’t a dead man.

“Should we go to your room?” Jamie asked tentatively.

I wondered if the process of changing venues would deflate the moment. I didn’t need to risk doing something that would cause me to slow down and really think about what was happening.

“Here is fine,” I finally said.

I wasn’t sure when Elise would be back, but I didn’t want to think about her existence and risk losing what little wetness this interaction had brought me. I reached my hand under Jamie’s shirt and was surprised to find a sports bra underneath. I shoved my hand past the tight band and discovered Jamie had really great breasts. I pulled her shirt over her head and kept

kissing her, moving her hands away when she instinctively wrapped them around her bare stomach. Jamie kissed me back with an eagerness that confirmed my suspicions of how besotted she was. Though her head was moving with vigor, she held her hands stiffly at the sides of her body—like she was afraid if she did too much, I might change my mind. I grabbed her hands and put them on my waist, and she squeezed it thankfully.

I didn't realize Elise had walked into the apartment until Jamie abruptly pulled back from our kiss and began frantically trying to pull her shirt on. Elise stood in the threshold of the doorway, staring at us. Maybe she was enjoying the scene in front of her? That was fine; she could toss it in her clit flicks and save it for later. Elise let out a long, exaggerated sigh, and I realized she wasn't happy with what was happening. Was she homophobic? We had never discussed queer people before, but she dressed like she was a trad wife, so I guessed it was possible.

"I'm going to move out," Elise said.

"What?" I said, shocked. "Because of this?"

"No. I've been thinking about it for a while." She dropped her bag onto the floor.

"Why?" I asked.

"I'm not really comfortable with everything that happened with your boyfriend. And you don't have any respect for my boundaries. My therapist thinks you're a narcissist," she said, it all tumbling out at once.

Jesus Christ, was everyone in therapy?

"Are you homophobic?" I asked.

Elise grew flustered, her face quickly reddening. Jamie looked surprised by my accusation, too.

"What? No." After a pause, Elise asked, "Are you gay?"

"I'm bisexual," I said.

I had never taken the time to publicly identify myself as anything before, but it served me in this moment, so it felt like as good of a time as any to do so.

"And it's fucked up you're telling me this now," I continued.

"You're having sex in our living room!" she exclaimed.

“We were just making out,” Jamie said quietly.

“I’ll pay for this month’s and next month’s rent, but then I’m moving out,” Elise said.

I worried that Elise might retract what she had told the police in her statement, that she would mention the stupid earplugs now that she had an escape route from me. I needed to be nice to her and end things as kindly as possible so she wouldn’t fuck me over out of spite. I needed to appease her.

“If that’s what you want, I respect it,” I said. “I’ll miss you, but I respect it.”

Elise and Jamie didn’t bother masking their surprise at my calm reaction.

“What?” Elise asked. “Really?”

“I just want you to be happy,” I added, doing my best impression of someone who meant it.

“Oh...well, thanks, Lillian,” she said, unsure of how to respond.

In reality, I didn’t give a shit about Elise’s happiness—but I needed her to sit for me like a good dog. Elise looked skeptical, like she was walking into some sort of trap that she couldn’t see laid in front of her. She crossed her arms and uncrossed them, unsure of what to do. Maybe she was already regretting her impulsive decision. We paid \$2,100 for a two-bedroom, two-bathroom apartment with hardwood floors and natural lighting in Mission Hill. We were walking distance from the Green Line and several restaurants. Elise had been in the apartment for a year before I moved in, and our landlord had only raised our rent in minimal increments in the three years since. She would never find a deal like this again, or a roommate like me again.

“We can discuss details soon...figure out how to transfer the internet into your name and everything,” Elise said, walking backward toward her room.

The idea of making different log-ins for different sites that required an uppercase letter, a special character, and a piece of my soul made me want to scratch her eyes out. I resisted the urge to do this and instead smiled at her politely.

“Sounds good,” I said reassuringly. “We’ll get it sorted.”

Maybe Jamie could set those things up for me. After shifting back and forth on her feet a few times, Elise apologized for interrupting us and retired to her bedroom. When she was gone, Jamie let out a breath she had been holding.

“Damn. I’m sorry,” she said. “That was crazy.”

I shrugged. “Whatever. I hate her anyway. It’ll be nice to have her gone.”

“Do you want to go into your bedroom?” Jamie asked, clearly hopeful.

She looked at me like I was a team captain for gym class and she desperately wanted to be picked.

“I’m tired.” I slumped back on the couch.

The moment had passed. And it would probably never come back.

CHAPTER TWENTY - ONE

IT HAD BEEN TWO WEEKS since I had been in the office. Aside from the initial flurry of gift cards and care packages, I hadn't heard much from my coworkers since going on leave. I checked in a few times with Candice, letting her know periodically that I needed more time. She always responded with the same message:

Whatever you need! x

I didn't feel any desire to return to work, but I had used up my allotted bereavement days, and now that Elise was moving out, I couldn't afford to dip into my savings. Hector agreed that going back to work was a good idea. He said it would be nice for me to be "around people" while the police continued their investigation. I got the sense that he really believed I was a murderer who needed to fill my days with reliable alibis. I emailed Candice to tell her I was coming back in; she responded almost immediately:

Already? Okay. Let's chat when you're in.

She probably thought that I was coming back too soon. And she was right. In a perfect world, I would have a few months to properly mourn Henry. I wondered if I could petition the company to extend their bereavement policy so it matched what new mothers received for maternity leave. After all, shouldn't there be equal paid time off for life and death? I pictured Candice at the office, scrambling to buy flowers and chocolates in anticipation of my return. Maybe she would give me a stipend to see a therapist, or a gift card to a spa so I could focus on self-care. I wore black

for my first day back. I read that in Greek culture, widows wore black for a full year following the death of their husband. Sometimes they would take this tradition a step further, wearing the color for their entire lives. Most of my wardrobe was black anyway and the color was slimming, so I was happy to adopt the practice.

When I got into the office, I made a show of walking toward my desk with my head hung low, a sullen expression fixed on my face. I wasn't sure exactly how sad I was supposed to seem. Of course I was truly upset that Henry was dead, but as time passed, I didn't feel that sorrow seeping into my bones in the way that other people might. In truth, sometimes I forgot that he had died altogether and felt like I was merely on a vacation from my real life. I understood that this was probably some sort of trauma response, a coping mechanism my brain had developed to block out the difficult emotions I was processing. Maybe, in my grief, I was forming new neural pathways that avoided being sad altogether.

I gave a weak hello to a few of my coworkers as I made my way to my desk. A couple said hi back, and one woman—Margaret—turned back to her work like she hadn't heard me. Were they being weird? And why had no one run to the front door to grab my coat? Or pulled me into a hug upon my arrival? Or handed me flowers? Maybe Candice hadn't told people that I was coming back in. I cursed myself for not giving more notice. I spotted Jessica, who was occupied by the shitty newsletter she wrote every week.

"Hey, Jess," I said.

She turned around from her desk and looked taken aback when she saw me. "Oh, hi. You're back."

"Yeah. I wanted to take more time off, but capitalism, y'know?" I joked.

Jessica gave me a half-hearted nod. "Totally."

"Working on the newsletter?" I asked.

"Mmhmm." She nodded.

"I'm excited to read it," I said.

I had the bandwidth to be generous with her after some time off.

"Oh. Thanks." She gave me a tight smile.

Was she being short, or was I just imagining her coldness? Jessica was usually the type to salivate at a compliment or pretend she didn't hear it so you would have to repeat it again. I considered the possibility that my colleagues didn't know how to be around me in the wake of my devastation. I thought about how awkward I had been toward my coworker Maria when her father died last year. After finding out what happened, I went to the "sympathy" greeting card section in CVS. I opened a few cards that felt vaguely religious and definitely overpriced, eventually opting to forgo the card altogether and buy myself a bag of Twizzlers instead. Maybe the people I worked with were similarly paralyzed by their inability to rectify the loss I had endured.

When I arrived at my desk, there was nothing on it aside from the few items that I had left behind. It seemed like the cleaners had dusted the surface, but other than that—all was as I had left it. Candice's office door swung open, and she squeaked over in her Crocs. Today they were pristinely white, and she wore a matching black-and-white polka-dot dress with bright red earrings. Was she wearing some black for me? If so, it was a tacky display of emotional solidarity.

"Hey. Got a sec to chat?" Candice asked.

There was an edge in her voice. Was she mad that I had come back too early? Was she going to do the guilty-millennial-boss thing where she insisted that I go home and take more time to myself? I pictured her lovingly chastising me: "Don't you dare log in to Slack! I want you offline!" she'd say. That was fine. I would happily go back home if she wanted me to. She just needed to pay me for my time off. I followed Candice into her office, and she closed the door behind her, lowering the shades of her floor-to-ceiling windows. That was odd. Candice only closed her shades when someone was getting fired or being put on a performance-enhancement plan.

"How are you doing?" she said, looking at me skeptically.

"Not great, obviously. I'm just trying to put one foot in front of the other. Take it day by day. Hour by hour, if I have to," I said.

This was advice that I had heard on a mental health podcast that I watched four consecutive videos of on TikTok. It wasn't necessarily advice that resonated, but it seemed like the kind of thing Candice would nod her head at warmly. She remained stone-faced.

"I don't exactly know how to broach this...but I need to chat with you about a client boundary that was crossed." She folded her hands on her desk.

I tried to remember if I had tried to fuck any of our clients recently. Six months ago, I pretended to accidentally walk into the men's room when a hot influencer was in the office as my way of staging a meet-cute, but that was so long ago. I doubt he would have mentioned it now.

"The Wellness Witch said you sent her quite a few DMs the other night," Candice continued. "She brought it up in a meeting yesterday."

Oh. Right.

I had forgotten about that.

After the wake, I had taken a sleeping pill and woken up to a slew of outgoing messages to the Wellness Witch, Bekah, on my Instagram. I thankfully hadn't mentioned the hex in these messages, but I did send the following:

Lilz1290-10:47 PM

is there a spell that could make me a full lesbina
*****lesbian

Lilz1290-11:03 PM

Also something for constipation lol
U probably don't answer your DMs

Lilz1290-12:13 AM

Have u seen Practial Magic?
Practic
Pratical

Practical Magic
Have u seen practical magic

Lilz1290–12:25 AM

Wanna grab coffe

Lilz1290–12:34 AM

Jiiiiiiiiiiiiiiii

Lilz1290–12:42 AM

Omg u don't even know wtf ur doing anyway

Magic my ass

Cut leader

Cult

Cult leader

But i wuld join lmao

;)

Since Bekah had such a big following, I assumed these messages would land in her “Other” folder and remain unseen. I hadn’t expected her to read them, never mind tattle on me to my employer. I made a note to remove where I worked from my Instagram bio. Maybe I would go private, though that sounded drastic. I was inexplicably getting an influx of followers who lived in India, and I didn’t want that river to stop flowing. My DMs were full of men telling me that I was more beautiful than the sunrise and that I would make an impressive wife someday.

I wasn’t sure what to say to get out of this. Candice looked uncomfortable in her forced role as a disciplinarian. She didn’t want to punish me; I could tell that much. This would just be a small slap on the wrist, then she would be back to her horrifyingly chipper self.

“I took a pill that my therapist prescribed to help me get through the night. I don’t remember sending that,” I said, presenting a mix of fact and

fiction. I hoped inserting my imaginary therapist into the narrative would garner some sympathy from my boss.

“Things like this can’t happen. We nearly lost the account.” Candice frowned.

“I would be happy to reach out and apologize to her,” I offered.

“No. Please don’t,” Candice said immediately. “I mean, definitely don’t say anything else to her.”

I looked into my lap, forlorn. “I’m just going through a lot right now, you know?”

“With your boyfriend’s passing, you mean?”

“Yes,” I said, looking up at her like she had just lost the show *Are You Smarter Than a 5th Grader?*

“Right...” Candice said tentatively. “Well...this is not necessarily a work thing, but a few people did put it together that you were seeing the man who died in that bar stabbing.”

I wished they had heard how Henry had died directly from me; I had planned on telling my coworkers the carefully arranged details of Henry’s death as a way to bond with them at a later date—but this was fine. I could still work with this.

“Yeah. It’s really horrific,” I said.

“And then we saw his girlfriend’s piece in *Teen Vogue*,” Candice added.

My jaw tightened and my vision briefly blurred. I wondered if I was having a stroke. Was that likely to happen at age twenty-nine? Was this why everyone was being standoffish? Because they believed I was the “other woman”? Nora’s bullshit account of what happened at the wake had totally misrepresented who I was. I wondered how my colleagues had pieced together that I was “Jane.” Had Nora DMed my place of employment to exact revenge on me? I wasn’t sure how far she would go to ruin my life, but it didn’t feel out of the question. And if she would stage such a targeted attack on me, maybe she was just as volatile toward Henry. The more I learned about her, the more I saw her as a fame-hungry leech who was using her boyfriend’s death for attention—who had maybe even orchestrated his death to get it.

“That article wasn’t really accurate,” I said. “That woman is crazy. She hasn’t even been ruled out as a suspect yet.”

I explained to Candice that Henry had been double-timing us both. I clarified that Nora—in her grief—had approached me at the wake while I was there to pay my respects and say goodbye to the man I loved.

“She verbally accosted me,” I insisted. “I thought she might even get physical.”

Candice’s mention of Nora’s piece had unlocked a voracious need to defend myself. I finally felt like I had the opportunity to add the context that Nora had withheld from the thousands who had read the article online. I told Candice that I had every right to be at the wake—just as much of a right as Nora did. And while I acknowledged my relationship with Henry was complicated, it didn’t make losing him any less significant. I told Candice that I was broken from his death, and that the article had only further traumatized me. I said all of this while channeling the mind and spirit of Taraji P. Henson as Cookie in *Empire*. I would not be dragged down because Nora had branded me a whore. I would not let her win. Candice seemed surprised to see me so vehemently defend myself. What did she expect? For me to roll over and accept this slander? I made another mental note to tell Hector about this. My potential defamation lawsuit was shaping up to be quite strong.

“It sounds like you have a lot going on, Lillian,” Candice said. “And I don’t want to speculate...but you also seem a bit drunk right now.”

I considered whether this was true. It was possible that I was still a little drunk from last night. I had also consumed a big glass of wine that morning to take the edge off, but nothing substantial.

“That’s absolutely not true,” I said.

Candice took a deep breath.

“I’m afraid that, given the Wellness Witch’s discomfort, I need to protect the company and our employees’ peace right now.”

“Are you firing me?” I made no effort to hide the acid in my voice.

“No. Um...not right now,” Candice said. “But I do think that we should make accommodations for you to work remotely for a bit until we figure

out what makes the most sense for the team at large.”

“So, I’m in time-out basically?” I spat. I guess I did sound a little drunk. Whatever, it wasn’t like I drove to work.

“No, it’s just...a break,” Candice insisted.

I would be temporarily banned from interfacing with clients. She was going to assign me some data entry to do in the interim. I was livid. I assumed the company’s plan was to force me out slowly, to make me feel so undervalued and ostracized that I would quit of my own accord. I had been in the marketing field for eight-plus years. I was an expert. Sure, most of marketing was just confidently saying you thought something would work on a group of people and hoping no one questioned it. But I was good at that! If Candice and the rest of the team thought they could intimidate me into submission, they were sorely mistaken. I would do their data entry. I would make spreadsheets and spend no more than one hour and fifteen minutes a day doing that mind-numbing work. If they wanted to pay me \$87,000 a year to color-code Excel docs, so be it. I would take every penny from them for as long as I could. I suspected that my punishment was about more than just my professionalism anyway. Nora’s article had sparked the kind of rumor mill that left all of my colleagues clutching their pearls, worried I would fuck their boyfriends if they left them unattended. By publishing the piece, Nora effectively ostracized me from my own life.

And I would get her back for it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

HECTOR WAS DISPLEASED TO HEAR that I would be working from home. He didn't like how isolated I was, especially now that Elise was moving out of the apartment. He said that I was beginning to seem like a recluse, which wouldn't look good to a jury. Clearly, Hector had begun to imagine the network-drama version of my case in his head. I had gotten into the habit of calling him every day to let him know what was going on in my life. I told him about Candice's addiction to rubber footwear, Jamie's romantic delusions, and even Elise's homophobia. On more than one occasion, Hector reminded me that these confessions were technically billable hours, but I didn't mind. Jamie was paying for it.

Jamie and I had texted very little since our make-out session, and I felt the nagging sense that she wanted me to bring it up again, to confirm that I had meant for the kiss to happen and we hadn't just tripped and fallen into each other's mouths. The morning after, she'd texted me "last night was really fun!" with a GIF from *Drag Race* of a queen saying "Okurrrr." I was instantly put off and vowed to myself that it would never happen again, nor would I acknowledge it further. I would avoid any mention of the kiss until Jamie started to question if it had happened at all. I would brush it under the rug with all the other things I didn't want to look at. I could already feel the memory of it melting out of my ears and onto the floor, ready to be mopped up by someone else. It was her own fault if she had created false hope in her head. I had never promised her anything.

On my third day of remote work, the police called Hector to let him know that they needed me to come back in for another round of questioning. They said Henry's family was adamant about "re-exploring old leads," which I guess meant targeting me, though I felt sure that in some way Nora was also responsible.

Before we went to the station, Hector and I met at his office to discuss what he called “off-limits subjects.” The list included: my sex life, Nora’s shitty haircut, Henry’s mother’s crow’s-feet, my theories about Henry’s stab wounds, me being put on work leave, and the amount that I drank. Basically, Hector was terrified I might actually be myself in front of law enforcement.

“Just say as little as possible,” he said, pacing in his office.

“You don’t have to coach me on how to talk to people.”

“That is literally what you hired me for,” Hector said, turning to look at me.

I straightened in my seat. “I don’t understand why they want to question me again. I have alibis.”

“One of them wasn’t with you during the window of Henry’s death, and the other was maybe asleep.”

“Elise wasn’t sleeping. She hears everything,” I reaffirmed. “Plus, if I went from Mission Hill to Somerville in the middle of the night, someone would have noticed. That’s a long trek. It would be on, like, public transit CCTV or whatever.”

“Well, it’s best to do everything we can to cooperate,” Hector said definitively.

Hector had me print out my credit card statement from the week of Henry’s death to prove that I had no charges from Uber or the subway during that time period. As expected, there were no unusual travel expenses, though I had ordered \$321.99 worth of vibrators from Adam & Eve and spent \$62 on Taco Bell one night, which I hoped the police wouldn’t get distracted by.

“I also think it might be a good idea for you to get a psych evaluation,” Hector added. “Just to cover all of our bases.”

My shoulders tensed at this suggestion. I didn’t need a psych evaluation to prove my innocence. I never should have told Hector about the hex. We had been on the wrong foot since I admitted I might have had some supernatural responsibility for Henry’s death. The moment I said it, he had stopped seeing me as an innocent person and started looking at me like a

Manson girl. We were already in an uphill battle, and now he wanted me to see a psychiatrist.

“Do you really think that’s necessary?” I asked, hiding the fury that was budding below the surface of my skin, filling my pores like wet cement.

“Probably not, but it could be helpful. I have a lot of clients who get evals during the divorce process, too. It helps solidify your ability to testify on your own behalf should it come to that. I can recommend a few people.”

I considered what actually going to a therapist might be like. The thought of entering an hour-long session with the goal of receiving a stamp of approval that would keep me out of prison was unnerving. What if they didn’t get my sense of humor or my blunt honesty? What if they diagnosed me with all the things I was afraid I might have? Or, worse, misdiagnosed me? What if they told Hector I was a sociopath? Or that I was capable of murder? How would I move forward with my life after a diagnosis like that?

Hector opened up his desk drawer and pulled out a few business cards. He slid them over to me. On the cards were various names followed by psychiatry qualifications. I wondered if Hector had already spoken to these people; the thought invoked a deep sense of betrayal. Maybe he was friends with a few of them. I pictured Hector and five mousy-looking therapists out to drinks, laughing about what a lunatic I was.

“Just think about it,” he said, hopeful.

“Fine. Whatever.” I snatched the cards from him.

Hector cleared his throat like he had one more thing to say. I glared at him.

“I don’t want to be rude, but”—he paused—“as a Latino man, if I were in your shoes—I, uh, I would probably be in jail by now.” He cleared his throat again like he was having an allergic reaction holding this thought in. “They at least would have held me overnight after seeing that text you sent. I know this is...inconvenient for you...but you’re very lucky considering your complex history with the deceased.”

“What are you saying? That I’m only walking free because I’m white?” I asked, raising my eyebrows.

I wondered if now was a good time to mention to Hector that I was also part Sicilian. Being Caucasian had nothing to do with the police not pursuing me as a suspect. Sure, I could recognize my privilege: I didn't have panic attacks when I was pulled over for a speeding ticket, and I had never been accused of shoplifting when I was shoplifting. But this had nothing to do with me being a white woman and everything to do with me being innocent. How dare Hector suggest otherwise?

"I'm innocent, Hector," I said, holding firm. "Regardless of the color of my skin."

Hector held his hands up. "I'm just saying. It's easier to represent someone who's not guilty."

"Then your job today should be a piece of cake," I spat.

WHEN WE GOT to the police station, I was told I would be interviewed by two detectives named Robert and Jimmy. They both insisted I address them by their first name, which felt like their way of tricking me into being unprofessional. If they were planning on playing good cop/bad cop, I couldn't yet tell which was which. I spotted Detective Jennings sitting at her desk. I tried to make eye contact with her, but she didn't look up from whatever she was working on. I would have to say hello to her on my way out.

Robert and Jimmy brought me and Hector into a small room with a table and four chairs, like we were about to have the world's shittiest dinner party. They asked if I wanted coffee or water, and I said I would love a sparkling water if they had it. Hector didn't look pleased by the specificity of my request, but Jimmy said he thought there might be a LaCroix in the communal fridge. He came back with a grapefruit one, my least favorite kind, but I didn't make a fuss about it to prove I was accommodating.

"So, we'd love to chat about what happened at the wake," Jimmy started.

I cleared my throat. "I ran into Henry's family and Nora. That's pretty much it."

“Nora has a slightly different story,” Robert said, chiming in.

He pulled out a copy of Nora’s *Teen Vogue* article, slapping it on the table like a crime scene photo. I was annoyed they had wasted state resources printing that trash out.

“This has been getting some traction online. Have you seen it?” Robert asked.

I looked at Hector, who nodded, giving me permission to be honest.

“I have,” I said.

“It says in here, ‘It became very clear that Jane came to Henry’s wake with one intention and one intention only: to hurt me,’ ” Jimmy said. “Is that true? Did you want to hurt Nora?”

“No. I wanted to grieve,” I said, sticking to my talking points.

I hadn’t gone to the wake to hurt Nora, at least not physically. I went so I could understand her better. I wanted to know what her voice sounded like and know how she smelled. I wanted to imagine Henry beside her, and then picture him beside me. I wanted to see the woman who had come between me and the future I deserved in the flesh. Now I had seen her, and I knew how ugly Nora really was. Her need for attention had only grown since the article came out. She had begun posting long-winded Instagram captions detailing her every emotion about Henry’s death, accompanied by black-and-white photos of herself, like she was doing a half-baked performance piece. She insisted she needed to be “honest” about the loss with her followers, pretending she was being vulnerable and not just milking Henry’s death for likes.

“Henry’s mother mentioned that she and her daughter, Amelia, walked in on quite a tense encounter between the two of you,” Robert said, leaning back in his chair and raising his eyebrows like this was a piece of juicy gossip.

I looked at Hector for guidance, but he was distracted doodling in his notebook. I guess this was what hiring the cheapest lawyer in the city got you.

“Nora was being very rude to me, if that’s what they mean...”

Jimmy perked up at this.

“Aggressive?” he asked.

I wondered if they were finally considering Nora a suspect. My heart leapt at the prospect. It made sense; I’d always thought so. She was the only one who was doing better after Henry’s death than she was before it. She was gaining followers and attention, and somehow losing weight. Perhaps the police were recognizing her behavior for what it was: highly suspicious. My heart beat faster as my own distrust of her further crystallized. I thought of the possibility of me and Henry’s murderer alone in that locker room. I wondered if Nora was strong enough to overpower me and how she would’ve killed me if she were to do it. Would she have smashed my head on the porcelain sink? Drowned me in a toilet? Strangled me? Would I have been able to fight back, to overpower the 120-pound woman on top of me? If Henry couldn’t stop her, I wasn’t sure I could, either. I shuddered at the image.

“I would say *she* was aggressive, yes. She clearly had it out for me. I was just trying to mourn in peace, and then she approached me, accusing me of being some sort of harlot who’d seduced Henry. I didn’t even know about her in the first place,” I said.

“She had a different account of things,” Jimmy said. “She claimed you knew about her and pursued Henry regardless.”

“He told me that he had broken up with someone recently. That was it,” I said, tracking the same lie I had told Nora that day.

Were they the morality police or trying to solve a crime?

“I don’t go after taken men,” I added, with more bite in my voice than I intended.

Hector looked up from his notebook now, concerned by my tone.

“My client is clearly still very emotionally affected by the loss of her, er, lover—I think we should be sensitive to that,” he said, glancing at me like I was an untrained dog ready to snap.

“Of course. Just getting more context,” Robert assured us.

“Nora is not a nice person. I can tell you that much,” I declared confidently.

Hector looked like he wanted to put a plastic bag over my head.

“Henry’s family has also found some of Nora’s behavior a little...erratic lately,” Jimmy admitted. “The amount of public attention she’s soliciting could be seen as odd.”

I bit my lip to suppress a smile. Of course Henry’s family hated the article Nora had written and her subsequent need for attention since publishing it. She had tainted their golden boy’s legacy—she had labeled him a cheater. Meanwhile, I had gracefully stayed quiet—like the dutiful wife of a dirty politician. It should have been me standing in that receiving line with them. Not her.

“We’re also considering the possibility that Nora might have found out about your relationship before Henry’s death. Maybe she found text messages...pictures...that kind of stuff,” Robert offered.

I pinched my eyebrows like I was thinking about this theory critically as I did joyful cartwheels in my mind. They could finally see Nora for who she was: manipulative, spiteful...a merciless wolf in Lululemon clothing.

“Women are detectives with those kind of things. I mean—not as talented as you guys...but they can be savvy,” I said, leaning into both flattery and sexism. “It’s definitely possible she found out we were seeing each other and was mad at him when he was killed.”

“It is possible,” Robert confirmed.

“You’re right about the phone stuff. Women are detectives,” Jimmy chuckled. “My wife won’t even let me have a lock on my cell.”

I got the sense that Jimmy probably cheated on his wife. Hector shifted in his seat, unsure of how to handle the turn this interview was taking.

“I think my client has been extremely accommodating today. Is there anything else you specifically need to ask her about?” Hector said, attempting to prove he was worth \$290 an hour. “Because this seems like more speculation than anything else.”

“Just one last thing. We’re wondering if you ever felt threatened by Nora?” Robert asked.

“Definitely,” I said without hesitation.

Hector looked at me, surprised.

I did feel threatened by Nora. Perhaps not by her physicality or outward appearance, but there was something deeply sinister about her behavior. She'd turned my life upside down—there was a strong chance her finger-pointing was merely to deter from her own sinister actions.

“That’s good to know,” Robert said. “We’re just trying to piece together the state of mind everyone was in around his death.”

“Thank you so much for your cooperation, Lillian.” Jimmy smiled, clicking off the tape recorder.

“Of course,” I said. “Anything to find out who did this.”

WHEN WE WERE done, Hector and I stood outside of the police department, idling as if we had just finished a date. It was cold, and our hot breath made little clouds that danced in the air above us. I moved closer to Hector, trying to inhale some of his cloud, curious what it would taste like. Hector took a step back.

“How did I do?” I asked.

“Fine.” He shifted. “I didn’t know you really thought Nora was dangerous.”

“I mean, she could be,” I said. “You didn’t see her at the wake. She’s clearly not a well person,” I added matter-of-factly.

Hector seemed like he wanted to say something else, but he swallowed the thought. He crossed his arms, trying to stay warm. I was coursing with adrenaline from the success of the interview. I looked up at my lawyer, enjoying how he towered over me. I imagined peeling off his cheap suit and rubbing my naked body against his while he thought about his wife.

“Well, hopefully this will be the end of it,” Hector said, interrupting my fantasy.

“What do we do now?” I hoped he might suggest we go grab a celebratory drink.

I was too antsy to go home. Elise spent most nights at her new apartment. She was still paying rent for our place, but every time I came home, more of her things had disappeared—as if the house had been

politely burgled. One day, I had no pans to cook in, then no bookshelf, then no television. I had propped my laptop onto a foldout chair in the living room as a temporary solution. On top of the sparseness of the apartment, my toilet was also acting up, making a loud groan every time I flushed it. I wondered if Elise had clogged it with something as retribution before leaving. Unfortunately, calling Jamie (who was pretty handy) to help me fix it felt out of the question. I didn't want to have a conversation about our kiss yet.

"Just keep yourself busy until this all officially blows over," Hector said, rubbing his arms, trying to warm himself up.

"Wanna go grab a drink?" I asked, hoping I didn't sound too desperate.

"No, thanks. I'm going to head out. Call me if anything comes up," he said, digging his CharlieCard out of his pocket.

Hector walked quickly toward the train station, leaving me standing alone. I knew I was supposed to feel relieved that things had gone well; that the police were clearly moving toward other, more viable leads. I was supposed to feel happy that this would soon be behind me; that Jamie's credit card wouldn't be completely maxed out by Hector's fees, and I wouldn't be wrongfully incarcerated for a crime I didn't commit. But my energy had nowhere to go. I felt like the void that was once filled by Henry and then filled by the spectacle of his loss was opening up inside me again. I worried that maybe there was no person, or thing, that would be able to plug it up for good.

I wandered down the street, aimless and looking for something to do, like a zombie whose brain function only sparked with sound or smell. I passed a restaurant where a couple sat inside, their elbows on the table, leaning toward each other, deep in conversation. I stopped in front of the window and stared at them until they looked at me, confused.

I gawked at them for a moment.

Then I spit on the ground and kept walking.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

THE THINGS THAT NORMALLY NUMBED my brain weren't effective anymore. My alcohol tolerance was at an all-time high, and I had watched four seasons of *Real Housewives of New York City*, two seasons of *Below Deck*, and one terrible Netflix show about ten hot people in a house fighting over money. Elise was fully moved out and—as a result—my apartment now had a serial-killer glow to it. I put a folding chair in Elise's old bedroom in an attempt to make it look less barren, but it only made it appear like the room a captor would torment their victims in.

My life was horrifyingly silent. Jamie was barely talking to me. She still responded to most of my bids for attention, but she no longer initiated conversation. And when she did answer, it was emoji-less and curt. The police hadn't updated Hector and me about the investigation since my last interview, either. Hector said that no news was probably good news for me, but the lack of information left me on edge. I thought about going to the police station and trying to court Detective Jennings; having a lover on the inside would certainly help me stay in the loop—but it wasn't worth the inevitable lecture I would have to endure from Hector if he found out I was sleeping with law enforcement to stay in the know.

While the police were looking into Nora alongside some other leads, I figured the least I could do was rule out my own magical thinking as the cause of Henry's death. I started to do some research on the origin of hexes. Apparently, they were as old as civilization itself. They were referenced in ancient Greek, Egyptian, and Roman texts and later adopted in pagan rituals. There were even mentions of hex-like sorcery in the Bible. Basically, if there were human beings, there was a need for revenge. The more I thought about it, the more it seemed like there were three avenues to explain Henry's death: 1. I had accidentally killed him using some

previously untapped magical power. 2. Nora had murdered him in a crime of passion. 3. A random person killed him for some unknown reason, like maybe Henry hadn't held the door for them, or he shoulder-checked them at the bar.

After drinking three vodka sodas, I decided the only way to rule out my own part in Henry's death was by talking to the Wellness Witch. I understood Candice wouldn't like this. I was under strict instructions to leave Fizzle's clients alone—especially Bekah—but getting answers felt more important than following some unnecessary boundary my boss had set. Plus, I was fairly confident Bekah wouldn't recognize me from my Instagram if I spoke to her in person. She would probably be flattered to have a fan, someone who wanted to know more about her work. Maybe we would even become friends once she got to know me offline. I didn't really want to be friends with someone like her, but I wasn't in a place to be picky at the moment.

It was easy enough to figure out where Bekah was in the city at all times. She was one of those unbearable people who posted and tagged every single place she ate dinner, shopped, or, in her case, held events. Seeking attention was a compulsion for people like Bekah. In a way, I felt bad for her. It was unfortunate she couldn't find confidence from her own inner world, like I did.

Bekah was doing a small sound bath in a Catholic church at eight that evening. The theme of the gathering was "cutting out toxic people." It felt like kismet that she was hosting the event in a church; now I could tell Hector that I had spent the night at Mass. When I got to the church, I learned it was a ticketed event. Bekah was charging forty-five dollars a head for people to lie in a room and listen to her whack bowls. Everyone seemed to have brought a yoga mat, which I felt should have been noted in the flyer. I debated paying for a ticket but promptly decided that I had already sacrificed enough in the last few weeks. I didn't need to part with forty-five dollars, which would cover at least three bottles of drinkable wine. I scooted past the woman collecting money at the front, ducking my head and moving quickly while she was distracted ripping someone else off.

Inside the church, several women were already lying on their mats with their eyes closed while Bekah played monks chanting from a Bluetooth speaker.

I took off my jacket and spread it out on the ground, using it as a makeshift blanket. After a moment, an event organizer with a T-shirt that said “Get Well, Bitch” (the Wellness Witch’s slogan) got off of her own mat and approached me. I worried she was going to chastise me for not paying, but instead, she gave me a small, nonthreatening bow.

“Would you like to borrow a mat from us this evening?” she said, motioning to a pile of blue yoga mats in the corner. I flushed, embarrassed that I hadn’t seen them. I didn’t want this woman to think that I lacked basic observational skills, so I doubled down.

“No, thanks,” I said. “Those are really bad for the environment. And not very grounding.”

The woman frowned. “Oh. Shoot. Okay. I’m so sorry.”

After a moment, she walked back over to her own mat. She sat down, looking at the piece of rubber below her with a new, judgmental perspective. Then she crawled off the mat and opted to sit on the floor.

“Once everyone’s settled, we’ll get started,” Bekah said in a soft voice that felt completely different from the authoritative one I had heard at the pitch meeting.

Bekah stood at the front of the church in the space a priest would usually occupy. The lights dimmed so the interior was only illuminated by the candles on the altar. I lay down on my jacket and tried to relax. After a moment, I was overcome with a sudden wave of panic. I had been raised Catholic, mostly because the church we went to growing up gave out free food on Sundays, which my mom liked to capitalize on. I remembered sitting through Mass as the priest occasionally screamed in Latin, wondering if everyone around me was having a transcendent experience or if they just were monitoring their bladder like I was. Being back in a place of worship made me feel like I was lying down naked in front of God, willing him to smite me for dabbling in, as Hector said, “the occult.” I took a deep breath to center myself. Surely, if God was going to strike down

anyone in this building, it would be Bekah, the woman who made a living bastardizing spirituality, not me.

Bekah began to hit her bowls, the loud reverberations echoing through the space. She wasn't very good at this, as each noise seemed disconnected from the one that followed.

"I want you to think about any toxic people in your life...and begin to let go of them," Bekah said. "Take a breath in and picture the person in your head...and on the out breath...let them go." She exhaled, exaggerating her own breaths.

I thought about Nora and all the ways in which she had upended my life. I pictured her small, heart-shaped face in my mind. As Bekah hit another bowl, I imagined Nora in a pile of quicksand. I pictured her slowly being overcome by the earth, like that horse in *The NeverEnding Story*. I made eye contact with Nora in my mind's eye as she disappeared beneath the surface. I wondered if I was having my first divine experience.

Despite Bekah's lack of talent, the sound of the bowls eventually began to relax me; my body sank deeper into the ground. Maybe it was the booze, but at some point, I must have dozed off, because I heard myself snoring. I hadn't slept well in a long time—nightmares about Henry had been plaguing my REM cycle—so this was probably the first good nap I had had in weeks. It was unclear how much time passed, but when I finally opened my eyes, Bekah and the event coordinator were standing above me, smiling. Around me, other women were packing up.

"Good morning," Bekah said.

"Sorry." I sat up quickly, rubbing under my eyes and hoping my mascara hadn't smudged.

"It happens more than you would think." The event coordinator grinned.

I looked around, and most of the other attendees were already gone.

"I'm going to pack up the bowls," the event coordinator told Bekah.

"I'll help," Bekah said.

"Actually," I interrupted, "could I speak to you about something for a minute?"

My heart started thumping. I was certainly awake now. Bekah looked at me, surprised by this request. She gave me a once-over. I hoped that she didn't recognize me.

"Sure," she finally agreed.

We walked over to a pew in the corner and sat down. Bekah scooted a few feet away from me, seemingly still unsure whether I was a threat or not.

"I was actually hoping to ask you about the accuracy of the spells you do, and, um, the hexes if you have any data on that..."

Bekah raised her eyebrow. "Are you a reporter? Because you'll need to make an interview request through my publicist—"

"No, no. Just a fan," I assured her, hoping flattery would get me further with her than the truth. "I really appreciate everything you're doing for people."

Bekah sized me up. "Well, thanks. I mean, I don't really have any data. Testimonials, sure. But I would say it's all about your own power of manifestation for the spells. Is there a particular one you are having trouble with?"

"I'm actually thinking more about the hexes," I said.

"Oh," Bekah said, cocking her eyebrow. "Which one?"

"The revenge hex."

Bekah laughed. "What'd you do, break someone's leg?"

I remained silent.

A flash of panic crossed Bekah's face. "Jesus. Wait, are you serious?"

"No. I mean, I didn't break anyone's leg or anything. I just want to know: Do they work? Like, no offense, but...is this a crock of shit or not?" I was tapping my foot nervously now.

"I don't think I want to have this conversation." Bekah stood up suddenly.

I sprang out of my seat. "I didn't mean to offend you. Or your work." I grabbed her arm to stop her. "Just—wait. Please."

Bekah looked down at my hand on her, horrified. "Let go of me."

"I'm not a reporter. I'm not going to tell anyone. I just need to know... for my own peace of mind, okay?" I said, speaking quickly. "Do you

actually know what you're doing with this stuff? Does it work?"

Bekah tried to shrug me off of her. "Stop. You're freaking me out."

"Just answer me then!" I said a little too loudly, growing frustrated. "Please."

Bekah glanced around the church, looking for backup. It was empty; everyone else had trickled out, and the event coordinator was gone, probably bringing the bowls to her car. I dropped my hand from Bekah's arm. I didn't want to scare her. I just wanted answers.

"The hexes are mostly crap, okay?" Bekah relented. "I did that hex video in like...2019. I didn't know what I was doing when I first started. I'm sure you didn't do anything if you tried one." She rubbed her arm dramatically.

I felt bad for the way our conversation had taken a turn. But I was also immensely relieved to hear her admit that she wasn't actually capable of any sort of magic. I was upset that I had even entertained the idea of her having some sort of otherworldly knowledge. She was just an influencer—another person who paid their bills by pretending to be something that she was not. She wasn't dangerous; she was just a fraud.

"Oh my God." Bekah gaped at me. "You're the fucking girl from Fizzle, aren't you?"

"What are you talking about?" I said, hoping that playing dumb would work.

"You sent me all those weird messages. Your boss said you were being put on leave for that. Oh my God, did you try and hex *me*?" She put her hand on her chest, growing more outraged.

Of course she was so self-absorbed that she thought she was important enough to be the subject of my curse. People like Bekah were truly sick in the head.

"I didn't hex you." I crossed my arms, defensive. "And the messages were a misunderstanding. I was hacked." I cursed inwardly; I wished I had thought of the hacking excuse for my earlier conversation with Candice.

"Everything okay here?" the event coordinator asked, walking up to us. She had come back for the final bowl and was looking at the two of us like

we were two dogs at a park that might mount each other or bite each other, and she didn't know which.

"We're fine," I said. "Everything's good."

I waited for Bekah to challenge this.

"Don't message me again." She glared at me. "Let's go," she said to the coordinator, gathering her stuff and walking out of the church quickly. She glanced back at me like I was going to run after her and steal her purse.

We probably wouldn't become friends, I guessed.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

I WAITED FOR A MESSAGE from Candice scolding me for my interaction with the Wellness Witch. I wondered if I should get ahead of whatever Bekah's narrative about me might be; I could claim running into her was a coincidence, or that I had gone with the intention of clearing the air. But no email came. I decided it would be better to stay silent. I had gotten the answer I needed and been absolved of any supernatural responsibility. That was all that mattered.

In my downtime, I began to pore through the moments Henry and I had spent together, adding the newfound context that Nora was out there the whole time—waiting in the wings while he fucked me after dark. The booze in my system was starting to turn my nostalgia for my ex-boyfriend into contempt. I wondered: Did he shower before he got into bed with her? Did he save my name in his phone as one of his coworkers so she wouldn't notice? Did I take up space in his mind like he occupied my own? Did Nora know about me before his death? Had she killed him because of it? Desperate for someone to talk to, I texted Jamie.

Do you want to come over?

I watched the ellipsis on my iPhone pop up and then disappear. I waited, hoping she would take the bait, but she didn't. I scrolled through my contact list in search of a replacement friend, but I realized I had suffered quite a few fallings-out with people over the years. I thought about joining Bumble BFF, but decided I would rather kill myself.

I logged into my goblingirlxo Instagram account.

Nora had reposted a story from a blond podcast host named Kaylor, who had shared Nora's article with the caption "Come on the pod any

time!” Nora had added several heart-eye emojis to the repost, with text that said, “I would love nothing more.” I clicked on the podcaster’s profile and was disturbed to see that she had over two million followers. Her podcast was called *Sexy Baby*, and her bio said that the podcast covered “feminism, friends, and fake bitches.” On the goblingirlxo account, I left a long comment on an ad Kaylor had recently posted for Nutrafol, a hair-growth supplement:

I think your podcast is problematic and a terrible example of feminism. Also, your hair looks greasy and thin. I definitely would not trust this product if you endorse it because...yikes! X

I scanned the rest of Kaylor’s posts, falling down a rabbit hole and watching clips in which she interviewed celebrities or influencers who thought they were celebrities. She asked them softball questions with dramatic music edited over it to make it seem like she was an investigative journalist and not a twenty-three-year-old with a marketing degree. In every clip, there was a new product placement, and as the podcast audience grew—so did Kaylor’s cosmetically altered lips. I found myself clicking through post after post. I knew there were a thousand podcasts just like this one: Uninteresting white women usually found easy community with other uninteresting white women. But I was furious that Nora was going to be part of that community.

I went back to Nora’s account and started DMing her. So far, she hadn’t responded to any of goblingirlxo’s messages, but she also hadn’t blocked me yet. I had to take my shots while the gates were open.

What are you going to do next? Make a Netflix special about your dead bf?

I hit send.

You're sick.

I hit send.

Maybe you'll do a true crime podcast. Or no...because you're the murderer?

I hit send.

You're not even that pretty.

I hit send.

Sorry, I mean you're not even pretty.*

I hit send.

How do you sleep at night?

I hit send.

Do you have a lazy eye? No offense. Just wondering.

I hit send.

Lots of people have them.

I hit send.

I took some small comfort in the fact that Henry's family found Nora's behavior "erratic," too. I checked Nora's followers, searching for Henry's

sister's name on the list. I nearly squealed in delight when I saw that Amelia had unfollowed Nora. Of course she had! Any camaraderie they shared with Nora had since dissipated in the shadow of Henry's death. She might be a hero to the public, but she was a villain to Henry's family. And if the police uncovered anything else, the insufferable pedestal she sat on would crumble, taking her down with it.

I wondered if there was a way for me to slot myself into his family in her place. We could probably get past our misunderstanding at the hockey rink. I imagined attending holidays and birthday parties with them, leaving an empty seat next to me at the table for Henry's spirit. I imagined Henry's father hugging me at Thanksgiving dinner and saying, "Henry would have been so happy you're here." On his mother's deathbed, she would give me her own engagement ring. "He would have wanted you to have it," she would say, a tear rolling down her cheek.

I went back to my thread with Nora:

I bet Henry's family hates you.

I hit send.

I bet they're disgusted by you.

I hit send.

You're sick.

I hit send.

Get help.

I hit send.

Seriously. You need therapy.

I hit send.

Probably inpatient since your problems are so severe.

I hit send.

Perhaps if I made Nora feel bad enough, she might admit that she had some part in Henry's death. I pictured myself printing out her admission of guilt and slamming it on Detective Jennings's desk. "I got her," I would say proudly, and then the detective and I would kiss. Before I could continue my targeted investigation, three dots appeared. I dropped my phone onto my bed, staring at it like I had just accidentally entered a nuclear code that would launch a global war. A message appeared:

Lillian, you need to stop this.

My breath hitched. How did she know it was me? Was my email or phone number attached to my secret account? I double-checked to make sure neither were publicly available information. They weren't. Did she know someone who worked at Instagram? Someone who could provide her this intel? Or did she really have so few enemies that she assumed it was me? The three dots appeared again, as if she could hear my questions.

It's very obvious that it's you.

I considered my next move. I could deny her allegations. I could make up a false identity and tell her I was a good Christian woman from the Midwest named Amanda and that I was appalled by her behavior. I could say that God had compelled me to reach out to her and try to save her from sin. Or I could say I was a distant friend of Henry's, and I was disappointed

to see someone so beloved be dragged through the mud, taking down another woman (me) in the process. Or...I could admit that she had sniffed me out, that she was right. I wondered if this would implicate me to the police and if Nora would rat me out if I confessed this. Though she might want to avoid any unnecessary contact with law enforcement now that she was a suspect. The three dots appeared again. Nora messaged:

I want to talk to you. Let's get a drink.

There was a part of me that wanted to go. I wanted to better know this woman who I felt intrinsically connected to. Maybe in an alternate universe—where our mutual boyfriend wasn't dead and I didn't suspect her of killing him—we might have even been friends. Sure, she was attention seeking and potentially dangerous, and the ammonia from her highlights had probably made her stupid. But still, I felt compelled to find out more.

Before I could change my mind, I texted back:

Fine. But I'm picking the place.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

I SUGGESTED TO NORA THAT we meet at the bar *Cheers* was inspired by to disarm her. For anyone who lived in Boston, opting to go to this bar was like choosing to eat dinner at a strip club: It was overpriced and had subpar service, but they served surprisingly decent chicken wings. It was probably the last place I wanted to have a drink, but making Nora uncomfortable and maintaining the upper hand outweighed my hesitations.

I arrived first so I could pound a pint of Guinness before Nora got there. I texted her to let her know where I was sitting and threw my jacket over the chair next to me to reserve her spot. Nora had given me her phone number the night before so we could plan our meeting. Since receiving it, I had signed her up for forty-seven different politicians' text lists, spanning every party line. I imagined Marjorie Taylor Greene's and Nancy Mace's campaigns passionately texting Nora, begging her to help them eradicate trans people from the earth. I wondered what her reaction would be. From her Instagram, I could deduce that Nora was the kind of liberal who believed "love is love" but who also called the police if a party was too loud. In reality, I wasn't much different, but I at least had the awareness to pretend I was more radical online.

I was admittedly nervous to see Nora. At the wake, I felt somewhat protected by the crowd of people I could easily slip into. Even in our locker room interaction, I had stood with my body angled toward the door, like a skittish foster dog. Now I was letting myself be vulnerable to an attack. I resisted the urge to check my phone and did my best to sip my beer naturally, hoping I was doing a decent impression of a normal person. I wondered if this was how extras on movie sets felt—stiff and only pretending to do the thing they were meant to be doing.

I was halfway through my drink when Nora walked in, five minutes early for our seven o'clock meeting. She was wearing a green T-shirt and jeans with her hair down. She looked like she had put minimal effort in, but she was still agonizingly pretty. I straightened in my seat and smiled, offering a visual olive branch while I internally willed her to wake up with an ingrown vagina hair the next day.

Nora sat down. The moment her ass hit the stool, the bartender was in front of us. I tried to ignore the fact that her presence was eliciting the best service anyone not on television had ever received at the *Cheers* bar.

"Can I get you anything?" The bartender smiled.

"I'll have the same," she said, motioning to my beer.

I considered how to break the silence. Should I make small talk about the weather? Perhaps make a joke about the state of turmoil our country was constantly in? Or should I jump right into the subject of our mutual boyfriend's death by asking her if she had killed him?

"Are you excited for your interview with Kaylor?" I asked instead.

That morning, Nora had shared a link to Kaylor's profile, with a sticker that said "Coming soon," indicating that she would be a guest on Kaylor's podcast in the near future.

"Can you at least pretend you don't know everything about my life?" Nora rolled her eyes, tucking her hair behind her ears.

My cheeks flushed. Why shouldn't I mention her newfound fame? I was a large part of why she had launched into internet relevancy in the first place. I wouldn't pretend like she had climbed that ladder on her own; she had stepped on my face to get there.

"Now, do you want to explain why you're tormenting me online?" she asked.

I scoffed at her own lack of self-awareness.

"You wrote an article about me and published it online without my consent," I said. "You weaponized Swifties against me, which is terrifying."

"I didn't use your name," she rebutted.

"My work still found out about it. I got fired," I lied, exaggerating my punishment as well as the reason for it.

“You got fired? For being a mistress?” Her eyes widened, genuinely surprised.

“I am not a mistress.” I resisted the urge to pour my foamy Guinness down the front of her shirt. “But yes.”

Nora took another sip of her drink and considered this information. She took a deep breath. “Well, I’m really sorry that happened,” she offered, though her words seemed to lack a genuine ring. I wondered what one of Hector’s psychiatrists would think of her.

“How long are you going to do this whole Scorned Woman tour anyway?” I asked.

“I’m just sharing my truth.”

People loved to say shit like this; rebranding the way she was marketing her trauma for profit as “sharing her truth” probably helped Nora sleep at night, and it definitely helped her justify why Henry’s family was no longer speaking to her.

“I did actually want to talk to you about something else,” she said trepidatiously.

I wondered if the police had brought up their suspicions and my implication that Nora might be dangerous. I took a sip of my beer and waited for her to either scold me or attempt to clear her name.

“I thought it might be interesting to interview you for a piece.” Nora cleared her throat. “Anonymously, of course.”

I coughed up my beer, the alcohol stinging my nose. “What?”

“Look, I was very angry when I wrote that article for *Teen Vogue*. After what you said to me at the wake, I’ll be honest...I wanted to hurt your feelings. But the article resonated with a lot of people—people who have both cheated and been cheated on. I think we have the opportunity to talk about something really important here.” She paused. “With your perspective included this time.”

I didn’t believe that Nora actually cared about writing something “important.” Sure, there were creatives who made art to effect change, but this was not that. She was not them. This was Nora packaging Henry’s death and my relationship with him and slapping a “For Sale” sticker on it.

It was what our generation did best: We talked about cancer, death, STDs, breakups, reactive dogs—whatever we could get attention for. We flaunted our deepest traumas in TikTok videos. We claimed we did these things to feel “less alone” in the world, but we did them to feel special. I didn’t really blame Nora for that. And if I was being honest, I mostly just hated her for beating me to the punch. There was a version of this story where I had published the *Teen Vogue* piece first. Where I had received the rallying cries of support from strangers online. Where I went home and watched my follower count climb until I was lulled to sleep by the warm embrace of social capital. Not having a substantial chunk of followers in the world we lived in felt like not existing sometimes.

“I don’t trust you to write me accurately,” I said. “Actually, I don’t trust you. Period.”

“Are you worried I’ll tell people you’ve been harassing me?” she asked.

This felt like a dramatic summary of my behavior. I wasn’t harassing Nora. I was offering her an alternate perspective outside of the yes-men who had been camping out in her comment section. I was also trying to peel back the layers to get to the core of who she was—and what she was capable of. I was hesitant to explain my intentions to her. I felt like anything I said would be recorded and twisted for her own content. I imagined her writing the introduction to her next piece as she sat across from me, like a knockoff *New York Times* profiler:

My ex’s mistress ordered a Guinness and drank it steadily, eyes fixed on me. I had so many questions to ask her. The first was: Why?

“I’m not harassing you.” I chugged the rest of my beer. “I’m the only one being honest with you.”

“You’ve sent me over sixty messages from that account,” Nora pressed. “And it’s nasty shit you’re saying.”

Had I really sent sixty messages? I knew replying to her posts from my private profile had become a habit—maybe even a hobby—but surely I hadn't sent that many. And why was she counting them anyway? Either she was trying to collect her own dirt or, despite her micro fame, she was really bored.

"Well, you've handled things horribly," I said. "I needed to let you know."

In her selfishness, Nora had thrown me, Henry, and his family under the bus. Did she not think that there were things I wanted to expose Henry for, too? He'd lied to me, as well. If anyone had a right to speak out and be wrapped up in public support, it was me...not Nora. Nora had everything. She had a good job and a recurring group of friends and a family who loved her. She had a family Labrador and naturally straight hair. She had the world. Meanwhile, I had nothing, yet I was expected to keep my mouth shut about her and Henry's wrongdoings. I had resisted the urge to speak ill of the dead. I had been a good girl.

"Maybe I didn't handle it perfectly," Nora finally relented.

I was surprised that she was taking any accountability. I studied her face as she sipped from her glass to see if she was fucking with me, but she just looked tired. I wondered if this was from guilt, or if she was dealing with the sharp edge that came with online attention. Maybe she had other cyberbullies aside from me. Maybe she was hurt that Henry's family had cast her out. Maybe she wasn't a killer, but just tastelessly filling the hole Henry left in her life with the attention of strangers on the internet. I saw the sliding door open, showing me a version of reality where Nora and I might have been friends. I saw us laughing at the bar together and going to Target to buy candles. Depending on how this played out, maybe we could get along. I flagged down the bartender for another drink. This time, I ordered two shots and a big glass of wine for myself.

"You can really hold your liquor, huh?" Nora asked.

"What are you implying? That I'm an alcoholic?" I asked, genuinely curious if this was the impression I was giving new people.

"That wasn't what I meant," she said.

I waved her off, saying I was mourning my boyfriend and now my job, as well. If I wanted to drink a little more than I normally did, there wasn't anything holding me back. She nodded like she understood this, though she visibly flinched at my use of the word "boyfriend."

"He fucked both of us up a bit, huh?" she asked.

I eyed her warily. "Off the record?"

She nodded. "Yes. Off the record."

"Yeah. He fucked us both up."

I considered the possibility that Nora wasn't wholly an evil content-hungry witch or a murderer, but actually an okay person with empathy—like me. Or maybe this was a trap that she was hoping I would walk into, a way for her to coax more information out of me and load it into a weapon that she would fire my final kill shot with.

"What's your endgame here? With the article?" I asked.

Nora thought about this. "I just thought we might as well be honest with each other. And if that can help other people...then, great."

"And if I don't want to participate in your interview...then what happens? You'll tell the police I've been messaging you?" I asked. "Try and pin it on me?"

"No." Nora furrowed her brow. "This isn't, like, a threat or anything. I just thought you might want to talk either way."

I wondered if I could trust her. I was honest with very few people in my life. Maybe my mother, but not lately. Just that morning, I had told my mom that I was volunteering daily at an animal shelter and that my lawyer—Hector—had asked me out on a date. She was pleased by this; she said she thought that we would make an excellent couple. But that wasn't really lying, was it? Those were small fibs I told so she wouldn't worry about me. Every lie I told had a purpose. I was constantly guessing the needs of those around me and tweaking my reality to be what they needed to hear. I was doing a service to everyone. And Nora didn't actually want to hear the truth. Maybe she wanted to sit here and clink glasses and laugh over our mutual knowledge of Henry's crooked penis, but she didn't want me to be fully honest with her. She didn't want me to tell her I thought I was inherently

more interesting than her, and that I suspected her and Henry's sex wasn't just vanilla, but like curdled milk. She didn't want me to tell her that I wished the premise of the 1997 film *Face/Off* was possible so I could steal her face and live in her temporary fame. Nora—and really everyone—wanted a curated version of honesty. Their honesty came gift wrapped with a bow on top. My honesty was a leaky cardboard package, flagged by customs just before the bottom fell out.

“Why did you invite me to the *Cheers* bar, by the way?” Nora interrupted my thoughts.

I realized I had been staring at Nora's foot. It was a nice foot. She could probably make a few grand dipping it in peanut butter and selling the content on the right sites.

“I wanted to mess with you,” I said, testing her with a shot of truth.

Nora smiled, amused. “I thought so.”

We sat in silence for a moment.

“Do you miss Henry?” I asked.

Nora took a deep breath, thinking about this.

“We were together for a long time. I thought we would get married. But I also kind of grew up with him. I became an adult with him. So now I'm experiencing what it's like to be an adult without him. And it's horrible, but it's also a little bit liberating, if I'm honest. I'm figuring out who I am all over again.”

I was surprised. When someone you loved died, you weren't supposed to confess that any part of you was excited about your life without them. For a socially palatable person like Nora, this kind of transparency was very risky. Why was she telling me this? Maybe she thought I was such a dud that she felt comfortable around me. Maybe there was nothing at stake with me because I was nothing to her.

“Did you guys fight a lot?” I lobbed another question at her while she was feeling vulnerable.

Nora took another deep breath. “Toward the end, yeah. I was working a lot. Traveling a lot. I feel like when you're with someone for a long time,

you're a million different people, and sometimes those versions of yourselves don't totally fit together, you know?"

I nodded like I understood, though I had never been with someone through that many different seasons of life. At four months, Henry was my longest relationship.

"Did you know about me?" I asked, wishing I had set up my phone to record her in case her answer proved incriminating. "Before he died, I mean."

Nora scoffed. "No. I would have dumped his ass if I did."

I studied her face, trying to discern whether or not she was telling the truth. She seemed genuine, at least on the surface.

Nora turned to face me. "You know, I don't get you. You clearly hate me, yet you also won't leave me alone. I'm not sure why you said yes to coming."

I thought about this. I wondered if "hate" was the correct word for how I felt about Nora. It was more than just hate; it was frustration at how the world had treated her since Henry's death, and how he had treated her before it. Maybe it was jealousy, but that word didn't feel totally right, either. I didn't want to be like Nora; I just wanted people to treat me like I was.

I took another big gulp of my drink, swallowing it and waiting for my courage to bubble up to the surface like acid reflux. "It's always girls like you that end up with guys like Henry. You get to be the girlfriend, then the wife, then the mother, if that's what you want. I don't get that. It hasn't happened for me yet. I thought it might with him, but then it went to shit. Guys will do anything under the sun with me sexually—but they won't commit to me. It's like that's a bridge too far for them." I swallowed. "So yeah, sometimes I look at people like you and I get pissed off. I'm not sure if it's 'hate,' though."

My head was spinning at my own confession. The alcohol was making me reckless. It was beyond my control what I would say or do from this point. I wondered if I could take back what I had said, if I could cushion it with a joke or a jab. I had been too honest.

Nora looked down and sipped her drink.

“Do you want to go to my place?” she finally said.

And even though it was probably a terrible idea, I said yes.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

NORA SHOWED ME AROUND HER apartment like I hadn't been there before. In some ways, being there with her did make it feel new. She pointed out details that Henry had forgotten to highlight, like the shoe rack and the brass coat hanger behind the door. Since Henry's death, Nora had rearranged the living room furniture and added a few more throw pillows to the couch. As a result, the space had gone from a sophisticated bachelor pad to a warm and feminine landing spot. On the coffee table, there was a candle shaped like a woman's naked body. I considered the possibility that Henry had stowed away any signs of his partner before having me over. Was he that calculated? Nora offered me water and I accepted, hoping she would offer me something stronger next.

"You moved the couch," I said matter-of-factly.

Nora stopped in her tracks, the two glasses of water in her hands. It was clearly news to her that I had been to their apartment. I watched her digest the information in real time. I wondered if she would drop the drinks. I didn't want to help her clean up broken glass. Eventually, she resumed walking and set the two waters down carefully.

"How many times have you been here?" she asked.

"A couple," I said.

Though I had only been there once before, I wanted Nora to understand that what Henry and I had together was significant. It wasn't just a fluke decision that he made one night and then spent the next day sick over. It was a conscious choice he made time and time again. I might have initiated things, but he reciprocated them. I wondered what I would have done differently knowing what I knew now. I probably wouldn't have done the hex. But would I have approached Henry if I had known about Nora? I liked to think I wouldn't have, but I wasn't sure. Even now, deep down, I

still felt like I was better suited for him than she was. There was no need to compete with her anymore—the object of our affection was dead—but I still felt the desire to show her why I was a better match.

Nora sat down and sipped her water, still shell-shocked.

“How long have you had these pillows?” I asked, lifting up an orange-and-pink one that looked like a sunset in the middle of melting.

“I don’t know. A few years? I think they’re from HomeGoods,” she said, mistaking my curiosity for interest in her home decor.

“He put them away when I came over.”

Nora’s mouth dropped open like a broken nutcracker. “Oh.”

“I like them, though,” I added, throwing her a bone.

I looked at the second bedroom door, which was open and revealed the office.

I pointed toward it. “He told me that was his roommate’s room.”

“Jesus,” Nora breathed.

I stood up and walked over to the bar cart, fixing myself a drink. Nora seemed surprised at how at ease I was in the space. She slumped back onto the couch, defeated.

“Do you want anything?” I asked.

“Whatever you’re having, I guess,” she said, her voice shaky.

I wondered if she was going to cry. I hoped she wouldn’t. I was terrible at comforting people; I usually just placed a limp hand on the back of their shoulder and said “Let it out” until they put us both out of our misery and stopped. I handed Nora an old-fashioned and sat down beside her.

“Are you okay?” I asked.

“Let’s just get drunk,” she said.

Finally, we were on the same page.

TWO OLD-FASHIONEDS LATER, Nora and I were tipsily trading stories. She promised me she wouldn’t use anything I told her for a future article, and for whatever reason, I decided to believe her. Nora was more of a lightweight than I was, and the alcohol was turning her sadness into

silliness. We had covered a variety of topics: everything from our families, to Henry's orgasm face, to how much she secretly disliked her event-planning job. I realized that I didn't entirely hate spending time with her. When this thought entered my brain, I was mad at myself for it; if I liked spending time with her, then so had Henry.

"Sometimes I think I see him in the apartment," Nora said. "Like I'll see a shadow from the corner of my eye and I think it's him."

I wondered if Henry's ghost was haunting us. Maybe he was there now, watching his girlfriend and his paramour sit together and talk about his penis. I willed the ghost of Henry to give us a sign—a knock on the wall, a bang of the radiator—but nothing came. Maybe he was haunting the coworker who had received the promotion instead of him.

Nora turned her body toward me and looked at me curiously.

"Do you think we look alike at all?" she asked.

I considered the question. Nora and I were both fair skinned. Her hair was blond, while mine was reddish brown. She looked like she was designed by Mattel, and I looked like I was designed by a depressed teen on DeviantArt. I didn't think we looked alike at all, but as she lowered her guard more and more, some of her expressions reminded me of my own.

"Not really," I said.

"I don't think so, either. I am...just morbidly curious about you and him together."

"What do you mean?" I asked.

Nora shifted. She sipped her drink, trying to gain the confidence to ask me whatever question was playing on her mind.

"I don't know." She paused. "You mentioned at the wake that he said you were better in bed than me." Insecurity painted her face.

I had forgotten about that. I'd said this with the intention of hurting Nora, and clearly, it had worked. My comment had been festering in her body, spreading like an infection that had the side effect of shattering her confidence. It was making her envy me. And why shouldn't I have the upper hand on this one thing? It was probably true. Nora had been with the same person since college, which meant they likely did the same three to

four positions, sticking to a syllabus of what worked and never changing the lesson plan. I had been mostly single for my entire adult life. I was constantly adapting to different bodies and dispositions, learning what made them tick. Of course I was better in bed than Nora.

“Well, you’re the one he was in a real relationship with,” I said, offering her a small kernel of redemption.

On some level, this was true; her relationship with Henry had been legitimized by other parties, like his friends and family. My relationship with him existed only in the safety of my apartment walls in the depth of the night. I might have made him come harder, but she got the privilege of being with him in the outside world. I looked at Nora. Her pupils were dilated, and she was playing with her bracelet nervously. Were these loaded questions her way of making a move on me? Was she interested in me romantically? Was that why she had asked me to come back here? Maybe I could prove to Nora that all her worst fears about me being better in bed were true. Maybe I could show her exactly why Henry had liked me. Before I could think of all the reasons why I shouldn’t, I leaned in and kissed her. My lips met hers with more force than I meant for them to.

Nora pulled back immediately. “What are you doing?” she asked, shocked.

“What does it look like?”

I’d found that when you did something questionable, if you doubled down, like the thing you had done was not only normal but obvious, then people usually came around to the idea.

“You were asking if I’m better in bed. I figured you wanted to see for yourself,” I added.

Nora knitted her brow, thinking about this. I could tell a part of her did want this answer for anthropological reasons, but there also was a part of her that might be deeply straight.

“Are you straight?” I asked.

“I think so,” Nora said, like she was unsure if this made her less interesting (it did).

“Okay, fine.” I leaned back, losing interest.

I didn't have the energy to try and initiate anything further. I probably would have been able to convince Nora to give it a go with me if I really wanted to, but that would require a lot of work. Not only were women harder to get off, but I would be having sex with Nora to prove that I was better at sex, which meant I would need to be on top of my game—sucking and fucking her until she forgot her own last name. Normally, I would be up for this challenge, but the alcohol and conversation had made my limbs feel heavy and my head foggy. Plus, for whatever reason, being back in the apartment had drained my body of most of its natural sex drive. Maybe it was Henry's ghost's doing.

"I think you're a troubled person, Lillian," Nora finally said.

I snorted out a laugh. I thought about telling her all the ways in which I found her troubled, too, but I realized I had probably covered these points in the messages I sent to her; I had diagnosed her with every personality disorder under the sun and picked apart her appearance from head to toe, leaving no stone unturned. I studied her, wondering once again if she was capable of killing Henry. My heart began to beat faster.

"Did you ever hurt him?" I asked.

Nora raised her eyebrow. "Henry? Please."

"You have motive," I pushed.

"So do you," Nora scoffed.

"Where were you the night he died?" I asked. I felt a twitch of a smile on the corner of my mouth from how insane that question always sounded when said out loud.

"I was at drinks with coworkers, then went home...which I told the police, and my cell phone location confirmed it," Nora said. "You don't actually believe I killed him, do you? Why would you come here if you did?"

I remembered my first date with Henry, when I made the choice to meet up with a man I didn't know late at night rather than spend a night at home alone. I wondered if I could explain to Nora that sometimes the idea of something happening in my life—even if it was bad—was more appealing than a day passing with nothing of note occurring.

“I don’t know,” I said, opting for vagueness instead of the truth.

Nora yawned. “Okay. Whatever, Lillian. I need to go to bed.”

I stood up, assuming this was her indication that it was time for me to leave.

“You can just sleep over,” she said. “If you’re drunk,” she added.

Was this a trap? Would I wake up in the middle of the night with a linen pillow over my face, cutting off my oxygen? Would she turn on the stove and leave the apartment, inviting me to a slumber party I could never leave? Or had she changed her mind and now she did want to have sex with me after all? I wondered if she had an espresso I could make before I had to be a great lesbian lover. Nora stood up and walked into her bedroom, changing into her pajamas with the door open. She crawled into bed, and I sat on the couch debating what to do. Should I lie down and sleep here? Should I go into the bedroom? If I did, should I sleep foot to head, or side by side? Should I try and kiss her again? I opened up my phone and checked the prices on Uber. It was thirty-six dollars to get home. Maybe I should stay. If she did kill me, at least it would confirm once and for all that she was Henry’s murderer. I would be dead, but the social tides would shift and my body would wash to shore a hero.

I stood up and walked into the bedroom. Nora was in bed with her makeup still on, eyes closed and already nearly asleep. I went to the bathroom and rinsed my face. I took solace knowing that Nora would wake up the next day with a zit and I would awake with clean skin, incrementally better than her. I used Henry’s old toothbrush. Nora hadn’t thrown it out yet, a sentimental gesture that made me feel like she probably didn’t have the capability to kill him. I looked on the back of the bathroom door and saw the towel with the letter *H* monogrammed onto it that she’d mentioned in her *Teen Vogue* piece. I guess she wasn’t lying about keeping it up. I smelled the towel. It reeked of mildew and aftershave.

When I got into the bedroom, Nora was breathing heavily. I walked over to the bed and stood over her, waiting for her to wake up, but she was passed out. I picked up one of the pillows from the bed and thought about putting it over her face. Maybe I would smother her for a few seconds, just

as a joke. I wouldn't actually kill her, of course, but her reaction to such an act would likely confirm or disprove whether or not she was a killer herself. I pictured her jumping up in a panic and tussling with me, throwing me to the ground and wrapping her hands around my neck. I was too tired and drunk to test it. I put the pillow back down on the bed and crawled under the covers with her.

After a beat, Nora opened her eyes and looked at me.

"I meant you could sleep on the couch," she said.

How was I supposed to know that? She hadn't made the terms of her offer clear. I scooted up to get out of the bed, but she grabbed my arm at the last moment.

"Whatever, it's fine, Lillian," she said. "You can stay."

I lay back in bed and got comfortable.

Nora turned and looked at me. "You're not really scared of me, are you?"

"I don't know," I exhaled tiredly. "I don't think so."

Nora sighed. "I only wanted to kill him after he was already dead," she said tipsily.

For whatever reason, I believed her. After a little while, Nora's heavy breathing resumed. I wrapped one of my arms around her and pretended that I was Henry, scooting the bone of my pelvis against her butt. I closed my eyes and I fell asleep quickly.

I slept better than I had in weeks.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

NORA'S PHONE RANG AT SEVEN in the morning, startling us both awake. The sun was still crawling out, and the light was low enough that the room was a soft bluish gray. Nora sprang up in bed when she saw the caller ID, grabbing her phone from her bedside table and detangling her legs from mine quickly.

"Who is it?" I hissed, but she shushed me.

She spoke to whoever it was in a hushed tone and kept nodding and saying "Okay" with a very somber look on her face. "Wow. That happened at the same bar last night?" she asked.

I wanted to tell Nora to put her phone on speaker so I could hear. It felt rude for her to withhold whatever breaking news was occurring while I sat less than a foot away. I wondered what Hector would say if he could see me in this situation: waking up in bed with Nora in her and Henry's apartment. He was the one who'd suggested I spend more time with people; he didn't get to decide which people I chose.

"So, what will you do about his case?" Nora asked.

She was definitely talking about Henry's murder, then. The police must have uncovered new information and called Nora to fill her in on it. I found it a little rude that they hadn't given me an early-morning courtesy call, too. I guess the mistress was further down on the call sheet. Or were the police leaving me out of the conversation because whatever new intel they had implicated me in some way? I scanned Nora's face for answers, watching her eyes flicker with new information but nothing that I could decipher telepathically. After a couple more somber "okays," she hung up the phone and finally looked at me.

"Last night, some homeless man attacked a guy outside the same bar where Henry was killed," Nora said darkly.

“Oh, shit. Why’d he attack him?” I sat up.

“What do you mean?” Nora said.

“Like why did the homeless person attack this other guy?” I asked.

Nora blinked at me, not understanding that a person without a house could still have impetus for their actions. Maybe someone had provoked the guy. If I was without a home in these frigid temperatures, I would be injecting whatever I could get my hands on into my veins and picking fights with anyone in Hunter rain boots. I wouldn’t say that I was an advocate for homeless people; I just knew I would be much more pissed off if I was in their position.

“I don’t know the context. But the police think this could be the same person who stabbed Henry. They’re booking him,” she said.

“For Henry’s murder?” I asked.

“No. Only for the incident last night: aggravated assault with a weapon.”

“Shit. Did he have a knife or something?”

“They said he threw a rock.”

I bit down on the bottom of my lip so I wouldn’t laugh inappropriately at how deranged it was to put someone in jail for throwing a rock.

“Is Henry’s family going to press charges against this guy?” I asked after successfully suppressing my giggle.

“Well, they can’t totally confirm his involvement in Henry’s case without a murder weapon, so no. Not yet, at least. But the police think this is the best they’re going to get in terms of figuring out who did this,” she said. “The bar manager and some regulars said the same guy was around the night Henry died, making trouble.”

I tried to take in this information. Henry’s murder was solved. Or probably not even remotely solved, but the police were closing the case nonetheless. I wouldn’t need to speak with them again. I could stop seeing Hector. I could put this all behind me.

“How do you feel?” Nora asked.

“It’s weird. I guess I thought there would be some clearer motive,” I said.

Nora nodded. “Yeah, me, too. Sometimes I honestly thought you did it, too.”

I laughed. “And you still asked me to stay over?”

Nora shrugged. “Maybe I have bad survival instincts.”

I realized perhaps there were more similarities between Nora and me than I had originally admitted; at minimum, we had the same demented curiosity to know each other, even if it hurt our own feelings or was potentially dangerous.

Neither of us knew what to do next. The tether between us was disappearing in real time. Nora would move on with her life. She would ride a few more months of internet fame until she started dating another version of Henry after an appropriate amount of time had passed, probably eight months to a year. Nora and Henry 2.0 would date for approximately a year and a half; then they would settle down together. They would have children that came out bright blond, and she would get married in some old Boston institution, like the Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum or Holy Cross Cathedral. Everyone would praise her for overcoming her horrific loss, and Henry’s family would forgive her for outing their son for getting his dick wet with someone else.

Soon all would be right in the world for Nora.

Maybe I would come out of this okay, too. I wouldn’t be convicted of a murder—that was good news. I would eventually get back into Candice’s good graces, and Jamie would forgive me, too. I would swallow my pride and join Bumble BFF, becoming the kind of girl who got invited to watch *The Bachelor* with a group of girlfriends on Monday nights. I would meet a guy who did some vague “business” job and who had his own apartment. I would be his only girlfriend. We would degrade each other in the bedroom but not in front of our friends. We would get married after three years of dating. Right before the wedding, my dead father’s distant relatives would reach out to let me know that I had inherited a large lump sum of money. With this nest egg, my future husband and I would buy a house together. We wouldn’t have kids, and we would keep having sex for fun, not for procreation. When we were in our mid-forties, we would have a threesome

with a younger woman, and afterward, my husband would say to me, “I like you so much more than her, baby.” Yes, maybe everything would be all right for me, too.

Nora crawled out of bed and started getting dressed. I felt a sense of unease burrowing in my stomach. It was like the last week of college before graduation: that period of limbo when you knew that your life was shifting, but you weren’t sure if it would be for better or worse. When I walked out of this apartment, I would never be invited back again—for real this time. I would have to go on Zillow to find the listing and reminisce on the time I had spent here. This chapter of my life was coming to a close, whether I wanted it to or not.

“Do you want breakfast or something before you go?” Nora asked.

I could tell she was ready for me to leave, but she was doing the aftercare that some men I slept with did. She would feed me something quick—coffee and a bagel, probably—and then linger by the doorway until I left. I wondered if she regretted letting an interloper into her home. I wondered if she worried that I was going to set up camp here and never leave. Maybe I would.

“Sure,” I said, “I could eat.”

WE SAT AT the kitchen table, picking at granola and sipping our respective cups of coffee. After I was finished, Nora wordlessly took my bowl and started washing it in the sink. I drank my coffee as slowly as I could, letting it get lukewarm and then a little cold.

“Was Henry nice to you?” I asked.

Nora turned around to face me, drying her hands from the dishes.

“Well, he cheated on me,” she said.

“I mean aside from that.”

Nora gave this question some thought.

“Mostly, yeah. We fought, and he did dumb shit sometimes. But usually, he was good to me,” she answered.

I glanced at the threshold of the bedroom. I saw a flash of Henry carrying me into it. The coffee in my stomach sloshed angrily, a wave of nausea coming with it.

“I think he assaulted me, kind of,” I said, surprising myself.

As the words came out of my mouth, I realized they were true.

Nora froze, still facing the sink.

My heart thumped wildly. A flash of my head being pushed into the mattress played on my mind. But Henry and I were a couple who tested sexual boundaries—who leaned into the push and pull, right? Maybe I was overdramatizing what had happened. And now I had made the mistake of saying it out loud to Nora. I didn’t want her to look at me like a victim—or, worse, like a liar. I was a liar for many things, but I couldn’t bear the thought of not being believed for this. I waited for Nora’s mouth to drop and her to exclaim: “Henry would never!” I waited for her to make quick excuses for her dead boyfriend and call it a misunderstanding, or blame me for being drunk during the interaction.

Instead, she turned around and she sat down next to me at the table.

“He did that to me in college once, too,” she said, matter-of-fact. “He was drunk, and it only happened one time, but...yeah. It wasn’t a nice moment.”

I exhaled, the emotional reverb of her story echoing through my body, confirming my own experience along with it. I didn’t ask Nora any details about what had transpired between them, and she didn’t ask me any, either. We didn’t need to compare notes. We also didn’t apologize or say any of the fake shit people say when you tell them you’ve been assaulted—or maybe assaulted. We didn’t tell each other to girlboss up and retroactively expose him for his actions, or ask if we had spoken to a professional about it. We didn’t need to label it trauma or PTSD, or suggest a good book on how to move on from it. We both just needed to say it out loud and have someone else hear it.

I finished my coffee. Nora took my glass and rinsed it in the sink. When she was finished cleaning the dish, she washed her hands, taking her time to dry them. She sprayed her sink with a cleaning product and gave it a gentle

scrub. When she was done, we slowly made our way to the living room. She handed me my coat. I sat down on the edge of the couch, putting my shoes on and searching for something else to say.

“Are you going to write about this?” I asked.

“Probably not,” she said.

I couldn’t shake the feeling that this was an insult to me in some way.

“Maybe we could do this again,” I said, walking out onto a ledge and willing Nora to meet me there. I saw a glimpse of us again as friends, going to movie matinees and dinners, where we ordered multiple menu items to share. I saw us sitting on a patio in the summer, drinking Aperol spritzes and making appearances in the backgrounds of each other’s Instagram stories. I saw us existing outside in the world together, without Henry being the thing that kept us together.

Nora hesitated. “Work is crazy for me. But yeah...maybe we could grab coffee or something again sometime,” she said noncommittally.

Grabbing a coffee was the least intimate of all of the things she could have suggested. Coffee was for business meetings and dates you didn’t want to last for more than forty minutes. Coffee was for “catching up.” Coffee was for your second cousin’s friend who was in town, not for people you shared a boyfriend and a bed with. Coffee was a fuck-you.

“Should we find a day?” I asked, flinching at the desperation in my own voice.

“Um...let’s play it by ear.”

I squeezed my fist closed to stop myself from screaming, letting my nails dig into my own palm. Nora shifted her weight back and forth on her feet. It was clear she was ready for me to leave. I was reminded of Henry staring at me the same way—with the same look that said *Please just go quietly*. I felt the composure I had falling off of me like clothes that no longer fit. I wanted to grab Nora’s shoulders and tell her that I didn’t want to be alone anymore. I wanted to tell her that the investigation ending scared me. I wanted to tell her that if I couldn’t have Henry, then I needed her. I needed someone. I wanted to show her studies about physical contact, and how important that is to us as human beings. I wanted to tell her that

maybe I had sent too many messages, but we could overcome that—we could pass through the sliding door and come out on the other side as friends. We could be more than coffee. But I didn't say any of that. Instead, I pulled my phone out of my bag and snapped a picture of the space, not making any effort to hide my action from Nora. She remained standing in the middle of the frame with a blank expression on her face. I knew we would never get coffee. I would never be here again.

“Goodbye,” I said finally.

“Goodbye, Lillian,” she said.

I took a step out the door when Nora put her hand on my shoulder. “Wait.”

I turned around, my breath catching. She didn't want me to leave. Maybe we would get that coffee after all. Maybe it wasn't an empty promise.

“Did you pee on our doorstep a while ago?” Nora asked.

I swallowed, a mixture of disappointment and embarrassment churning in the abyss of my body.

“Of course not,” I said, my cheeks flushing.

I turned around and walked down the stairs, out into the cold air.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

AFTER I LEFT NORA'S APARTMENT, Hector called to tell me he had news that he wanted to share with me in person. He asked me to come by his office that afternoon. I didn't bother telling Hector that I already knew what had happened with the case; he would disapprove of my time with Nora. Plus, this might be my last chance to see him.

When I got to his office, Hector didn't look as pleased as I'd anticipated he would be, given the positive outcome. I had half expected us to celebrate when I arrived. I imagined Hector getting me a cake that said "You're free" with a picture of Martha Stewart leaving jail on it. But there was no cake or signs of celebration. Hector told me to take a seat and offered me some water, a gesture he hadn't repeated since our first meeting. Once I was settled, he let out a long breath and gave me the same update that Nora had already relayed to me. He said he wasn't entirely convinced that the man had killed Henry, but the police and Henry's family felt it was enough of a coincidence to close the case. I got the sense that Hector was disappointed, like maybe he wanted us to go to court after all. I wondered if this was because he wanted to spend more time with me, or if this outcome had shaken my lawyer's belief in the judicial system altogether. I decided it was probably a mix of both.

"Do we need to do anything else?" I asked.

Hector said we just needed to talk about the financial responsibility. He laid out all the charges our working relationship had cost Jamie. It was a three-page document with every billable hour listed along with a brief memo, as well as some travel costs incurred from his visits to the police station. The total cost for his services came out to \$4,873.44. I wondered if this would be a lot of money for Jamie. It was certainly a lot of money to me, but I had no clue what Jamie made as a personal trainer. I confirmed

with Hector that he was charging Jamie's card, and though he frowned, he assured me that this was the case.

Hector said that Henry's family would be making a statement to the public soon. I did my best to arrange my face so I looked sympathetic to this idea, but I felt it was crude to make a public declaration about a crime you weren't even positive was connected. I wondered if Henry's family had grown weary of pursuing actual justice and just wanted to move on with their lives. Henry's sister still only exclusively posted about the murder, but I could tell she was starting to get bored of it. Her social engagement was slowly dipping, and I was sure she missed posting pictures of whatever book she was reading and overfiltered selfies.

"Can I ask you something, Lillian?" Hector said. "Now that it's over?"

Was he finally going to ask me on a date? I had assumed he was happy with his wife, but I would still go. Sure, Hector had become less attractive to me since we started working together, but I could turn my opinion around. Maybe we would even get married and I would help him redecorate this hopeless office. My mom would love it if I married a lawyer. She would say she finally felt like I was being taken care of, like we lived in the '50s and I could only exist on the income of a man. I waited for Hector to make his move.

"Did you do it?" Hector asked. "Did you kill Henry?"

My eyes widened with surprise. Was he really asking me this?

"With the hex, you mean?" I asked.

"No...um, did you actually kill him?" Hector paused. "Another way?"

I realized that he wasn't asking me this question in earnest curiosity, but because he wanted confirmation of what he already believed: Hector thought that I had killed Henry.

"Elise told me you took one of her Ambiens that night...she wasn't sure if you went back out. She said the front door was unlocked when she woke up the next morning, which you tend to do when drinking," Hector added.

That cunt. Why was Hector talking to Elise anyway? And why was he taking it upon himself to further investigate this crime? The police hadn't reached out to Elise after the first interview, so why did Hector feel the need

to? I felt betrayed knowing that he had been doing this behind my back. I scanned the document in front of me for the billable hour labeled “backstabbing” but only saw “witness interviews.”

“I wanted to make sure I had all the information, so I spoke to her a few days ago,” Hector explained.

“I didn’t kill Henry, Hector,” I said firmly.

And what did the Ambien have to do with this? Sure, I had changed clothes on Ambien before, maybe sent a social media message or two that I didn’t remember. But I wasn’t capable of venturing across town and killing my boyfriend on the drug. I might have wanted Henry to die that night, I might have even willed it with whatever inner magic I had in me, but I didn’t *actually* carry out the murder. I now wished the police had looked into me further. I wished they had done their due diligence so Hector didn’t feel the need to play Nancy Drew. It would be impossible to go on a date with him after this. I looked at the photos of Hector’s family sitting on his desk. I bet he went home every day and spoke to his wife about me. I bet he told her he was representing this crazy privileged twenty-nine-year-old white girl who he suspected was a secret killer. I bet they laughed about me and his wife remarked how grateful she was that their kids weren’t defective, like me. I bet Hector breached all our attorney-client confidentiality while they traded stories about me at the dinner table as he gobbled up Tuna Helper. I didn’t know what I hated Hector for more: thinking I was guilty, or the life I imagined he had outside of me.

“I just had to ask,” Hector said, as if he was just asking what my star sign was and not if I had committed a heinous crime.

He cleared his throat awkwardly and told me that he would send a copy of his invoice in the mail as well as via email. He said I could text or call him if I had any questions about the billing. He claimed that he didn’t expect anything else to come up from here on out, but the police still had his number if it did. He told me to stay out of trouble, and that he hoped I would be able to go back to work soon. After his little goodbye speech, he handed me his business card and said he would appreciate it if I rated their legal practice five stars on Yelp.

When our business was officially done, he stood up and put out his hand for me to shake. Though I hated him in this moment, I ignored his hand and pulled him into an embrace. He was going to give me a hug after accusing me of homicide. Hector's body stiffened, like a wax figure, but he didn't stop me. I pushed my small boobs into him and whispered into his ear that it had been a pleasure working together. After a beat, he cleared his throat and stepped back. I lingered in his office for as long as I could before Hector leaned over his computer and said he had another appointment arriving.

Outside his office, I didn't know what to do with myself. The day stretched in front of me like an ocean I was meant to cross with no boat. It was barely twelve in the afternoon, and I didn't know what I would do until it was time to sleep. Was this what being depressed felt like? Like your life had stopped propelling you forward? Like you were just waiting for something to happen, either sleep or death, whichever came first?

I pulled out my phone to text Jamie, but I thought better of it. We had just charged her card nearly five thousand dollars. It would probably be best to let her sit with that for a minute before I tried to smooth things over. I navigated to Nora's profile, where she had posted a new photo of Henry's towel on the back of her bathroom door. The caption read:

The police have informed us they're closing Henry's case. I will let Henry's family share more details when the time is right, but I can say that it appears Henry's death was a random, and tragic, act of violence. With the case closing, I find myself wondering how I'll find my own closure. I have been taking it day by day, with all of your love and unwavering support helping me along the way. I may not be ready to throw in the towel, but every day I get closer to it, thanks to all of you.

I wanted to comment on the goblingirlxo account and tell Nora that she had incorrectly used the metaphor of "throwing in the towel," equating it

with moving on rather than what it actually stood for: giving up. It didn't seem like Nora would be giving up her facade of the grieving girlfriend anytime soon. It was glaringly evident that she wasn't even close to done riding this tragedy wave. When Henry had been alive, her brand revolved around their codependency as a couple; now that he was dead, she would make it about his absence. She would go on Kaylor's podcast and cry until the blonde handed her a tissue and she dabbed it under her eye, her makeup still perfectly intact. She would probably talk about me, too. Whatever white flag we had raised this morning would yellow in the wind.

I texted her a link to her own post and said:

The towel smells like shit. You should just wash it.

I opened up my email next, hoping for some busywork from Candice that might give me a temporary purpose. In my email there was a new message with the subject line:

In Regards To Your Employment

The email was from Candice, with HR cc'd. I opened it.

Dear Lillian,

It has come to my attention that you came into contact with Bekah ("The Wellness Witch") this past week and had what she described as an "inappropriate interaction." While I have tried to be understanding, your behavior over the last month has become troubling. This action clearly breaches Fizzle's Employee Code of Conduct (attached to this email for your review), which you signed upon your hiring. The code of conduct clearly states that employees will not endanger,

jeopardize, or lose company business due to behavior that is deemed “unprofessional.” With that said, Fizzle has classified your prementioned behavior as unprofessional and believes it is best for us to part ways with you, effective immediately. Sandra (cc’d) from HR will walk you through next steps for your departure, as well as give you directions on how to turn in your company equipment. Your laptop has been disabled remotely and your work email will be deactivated after you open this message. Your personal email is cc’d for further communication.

Best wishes for the future,
Candice

My hands were shaking. Bekah had ratted me out. I should have anticipated this. I was furious that Candice wouldn’t give me the opportunity to explain my side of the story. I should have emailed her first—beat Bekah to the punch before she could weave her overly dramatic narrative about what happened. I hadn’t really done anything wrong anyway. I’d supported a client’s event and inquired about her process. If anything, I was going above and beyond the call of duty. I began drafting an email back to Candice, explaining my position, when I noticed that there was a business card stuck to the back of my phone. It was the card for one of the psychiatrists Hector had previously recommended I see. I turned it over in my hands. The card felt like a sign from the universe—some sort of lifeline in my string of bad luck. Maybe this shrink could write me a letter stating that I was perfectly sane and able to return to work. Or maybe she could diagnose me with ADHD or autism: something I could use to sue Candice for wrongful termination. If Nora could weaponize therapy speak and claim she was “sharing her truth,” then so could I. Plus, it might not be a bad idea to speak to a professional about all that I had endured.

I called the number.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

THE PSYCHIATRIST SAID SHE COULD meet with me the very next day. It felt like a red flag that her schedule was so open, but I accepted the appointment nonetheless. Her office was located near Faneuil Hall in an older brick building down a cobblestone side street. Before my session, I went to the bar next door, which was full of sad older men who stared at the bottoms of their glasses like they were looking for a time machine in them. I ordered a martini, hoping it would loosen me up, drinking it in less than five minutes.

The psychiatrist's name was Dr. Gina Cohen, and from the photo on her website, she appeared to be in her mid-fifties. She wore all black and looked like a woman who would be cast as a shrink in a low-budget television show. The session would cost \$200 for the hour, and her office was located on the third floor of a walk-up, where she shared the space with a dental practice and a lash technician. I briefly wondered if the lash tech could fit me in as a walk-in after my session.

Dr. Cohen's waiting room was painted seafoam, and she had a bookshelf full of therapy books in case you wanted to try to fix yourself before your appointment. There was a red light on a connecting doorway that said "Occupied" to indicate someone was on the other side, spilling out their insides. I squeezed one of the plants in the waiting room to check if it was real and was surprised when it disintegrated between my fingertips, leaving behind a little plant goo. There were no windows in the room, and I wondered if Dr. Cohen brought the plant outside for a little bit every day to keep it alive; I couldn't decide if that would be certifiable or compassionate.

My session was due to start in three minutes; I decided if Dr. Cohen was even a minute late, I would leave. I was beginning to think this whole endeavor was a bad idea. I had hoped that my session would be like Tony Soprano's; she would know I wasn't perfect but be endeared to me still. But

what if that didn't happen? What if she didn't like me? What if she thought there was something wrong with me—something inherently rotten? I scanned the shelf of therapy books to distract myself from these malignant thoughts and saw titles like *Breaking Cycles* and *Life After Grief*. I imagined some poor woman reading these books as she sat next to her disinterested husband in bed, trying to find any answer to where her life had gone wrong and a step-by-step solution on how to fix it. The truth was that sometimes things in your life sucked past the point of no return. You couldn't fix everything. I wondered if I should write my own book with this advice. I would call it *Just Give Up*. Maybe I would pursue a career in psychology if I couldn't get my marketing job back.

I glanced at the clock on the wall as my appointment time approached, preparing myself to flee. I had never met the woman, so I felt no loyalty to stay and no qualms about leaving. She didn't have my bank information; there would be no way for me to be held accountable if I was a no-show. I stood up to leave, and as I did, the red light turned off. The door swung open.

“Hello,” said Dr. Cohen.

Dr. Cohen looked at least ten years older in person than she had in her online photo. I assumed it had been a while since she had had her headshot updated. I wondered if I should distrust her for being a catfish. Dr. Cohen had big, feathery brown hair that was styled like she'd stepped right out of a JCPenney catalog in the '90s, with large curls bouncing on her shoulder blades. She wore all black and had thick glasses on; I wasn't sure if they were actually prescription, or were just for show.

“Lillian, right? So nice to meet you,” she said, motioning for me to come in.

Dr. Cohen had one of those voices that tickled the inside of your brain like ASMR did. It was calming in the way you might feel around an attractive yoga teacher during shavasana. I followed her inside. Maybe this wouldn't be so bad after all. Inside the room was a big green couch, a red armchair, and a small green love seat. I felt sure that the chair I chose would say something important about me as a person. Picking the couch felt

selfish: like I was going to stretch out and take a nap. The red armchair felt like it was intended to be the doctor's seat, as it was made for one person and the standout color of the room. The love seat seemed like the least offensive option, so I chose that, putting my purse down next to me. On the coffee table there was a box of tissues ready to go. I wondered how many people had cried in this room. I thought about all the secrets that had been shared here. There was a palpable energy in a room like this, where you stepped into it with the intention of being honest. Dr. Cohen flipped on a small box that started playing white noise and hit a light switch, which I assumed lit up the "Occupied" sign on the other side. She then sat down on the couch, throwing my own choice off completely. I had failed my first test.

"So, tell me a little about yourself, Lillian," Dr. Cohen said warmly, opening up a new page of her notebook.

I told Dr. Cohen that my lawyer, Hector, had suggested I come see her and that I was also interested in the process of therapy. I wanted to make it sound like I had an academic approach to the whole thing. I wasn't sure how much I was supposed to open up to her. Did you ease into these things with foreplay or go right to spreading your legs? We only had an hour, and I wanted to get the most out of it. Plus, I was acutely aware that each minute cost me exactly three dollars and thirty-three cents.

"Would you care to share why Hector was representing you?" Dr. Cohen asked.

I explained what had happened with Henry, stumbling over my words like I was ripping the Band-Aid off a hairy leg. I told her that the case was now closed, but I gave her the broad strokes of what had happened. Dr. Cohen started jotting down notes as I talked, raising her eyebrows every now and then, which I found slightly unprofessional. I thought she would ask me more questions, but every time my talking slowed, she just looked at me expectantly, waiting for more information. Eventually, I felt my body cracking open and my true self crawling out.

I told her about the hex, about Nora and the kiss with Jamie. I told her about my mother and Henry's mother. I told her about Elise moving out and

being a bitch about the earplugs. I told her about the goblingirlxo Instagram account and my messages to Nora. I told her about Hector's judgment and what I thought his wife was probably like. I told her about Detective Jennings's biceps. I told her about Candice and her stupid Crocs. I told her about Bekah's scam of a business. I told her about getting fired. I found myself talking without taking breaths in between, allowing so many of the things I had hidden to spill out in front of someone. I told her how mad I was at Henry and how hurt I had been when he ended it with me. I told her that Jamie might be my backup plan if no one else would love me. I told her that I thought about becoming a sugar baby—but I only wanted to fuck hot men, who were typically poor. I told her how sometimes when people cried, I wanted to laugh. I told her that I was relieved the cops stopped looking into things with Henry, and that I felt bad for the homeless guy—but not so bad that I would do anything about it. I told her I only tipped ten percent most of the time and I often told DoorDash that my order never arrived so I could get refunds. I told her that I voted in the last election just to get the sticker but that it didn't make a difference in my life. I told her that I didn't want to end up alone. I told her that I might have been Princess Diana in a past life, despite us overlapping for a year. I told her that if I had wanted to have an affair with Hector, I probably could have. I told her that the next guy I dated would finally be the correct amount of obsessed with me, and that he would never hurt me. I told her about the stalking misunderstanding in college. I told her I didn't really get the point of the Barbie movie because it was still an ad at the end of the day. I told her that I thought I was a good person, but sometimes I felt other people were too stupid to see that. I considered disclosing what Nora and I had spoken about the other morning, but decided against it; something about our shared experience felt like it needed to be protected still.

I spoke for forty-five minutes without interruption while Dr. Cohen listened intently. I could finally understand why people liked therapy. It was nice to have someone sit there and listen to you without you having to feign interest in what was happening in their life, too.

“Am I one of your more interesting clients?” I finally asked her.

I felt a kind of euphoric high from being so honest with someone. Surely this would be her best session of the day, likely the month—maybe even the year. I imagined Dr. Cohen would talk to her therapist friends about the fascinating and misunderstood young woman who she had started working with. She would tell them that the world had been unkind to me, but I was resilient and still managed to find my own way. I wondered if she might encourage me to write a memoir or self-help book. I would be a far better writer than Nora. Maybe Dr. Cohen and I would work together for years, and eventually become close friends. I wouldn't need to do much in terms of my own personal development; she would tell me that I was existing on a higher plane than most people. She would say that this made life difficult for folks like me, and I would have to get better friends and lovers to keep up with my emotional intelligence.

Dr. Cohen shifted in her chair.

“You want to know if I find you interesting?” she asked.

I wondered if this was a tactic all shrinks used, lobbing questions back at the client so they'd be forced to hear them out loud.

“Doesn't everyone care what their therapist thinks about them?” I asked.

“Well, sure. There is a desire for approval for most people. And the doctor-patient relationship does bring that out. But I think you might already assume you are more interesting than the other clients I work with, Lillian,” she said. “In fact, I think you assume you are one of the—if not *the*—most interesting people in the world.”

I did think this, but I didn't see how it was a bad thing, which her tone suggested it might be. Didn't everyone think this about themselves? And in my case, it was actually true.

“May I ask what you're hoping to get out of therapy?” Dr. Cohen asked.

“I just want to talk to someone about all the crazy shit that's been happening to me lately. And maybe get a letter to clear up the whole thing that happened at work.”

“And do you feel any personal responsibility for the ‘crazy shit’ that has been going on in your life?” Dr. Cohen tapped her pencil on her notebook.

The air in the room had shifted from warm and welcoming to cold and sterile. Suddenly, her voice had lost its buttery sound. What was she implying? And what was this line of questioning meant to lead to?

“I feel bad about the hex. But the rest of the stuff just happened,” I explained.

Dr. Cohen took a deep breath. She leaned toward me, looking very somber.

“I think you’re displaying an interesting mix of narcissism and a victim mentality. You have done some destructive things to people you’re very close with: kissing Jamie, wanting to break up Hector’s marriage, sending Nora those cruel messages, harassing your client at work. These decisions aren’t healthy, but you’ve done mental gymnastics to justify your actions. It seems the only thing you do take responsibility for is this hex—which you thought at one point played a role in Henry’s untimely death, though I don’t sense much sadness around his loss in general,” she said.

My head was spinning. Narcissism? Victim mentality? Harassment? What the fuck was this woman implying? Thank God I hadn’t seen her before Henry’s case was closed; she was clearly misunderstanding who I was on a fundamental level. And of course I was sad about Henry’s death. Sure, I had some complicated feelings toward him, but I was still devastated. Just because I couldn’t produce tears on demand didn’t mean I didn’t care.

“It’s interesting that you do feel remorse about this hex. I wonder why you feel so much responsibility around that particular aspect,” she continued, eyeing me. “If we’re going to work together, I want to make sure you can be accountable for your role in situations, Lillian. And not just because you think you might have some untapped supernatural power. It will be very hard to make progress without some sense of grounded responsibility. I’d like to help you get there, though.”

Had Hector spoken to Dr. Cohen about me before I came in? Had he set this up and fed her lies to sabotage me? Were they sleeping together and she

was projecting her own guilt about it onto me? Maybe Candice or Nora had played a part, too. I got the sense that several outside forces were colluding to make this woman dislike me. Maybe Bekah had hexed me in retaliation.

“Why do you hate me?” I asked. “You don’t even know me.”

“I don’t hate you, Lillian. In fact, I would be really interested to see your progress if you invested in therapy. I don’t mean to scare you away from doing that, I just want to make sure we’re both on the same page about what that work will entail,” she said. “And what kind of therapist I am.”

She had spent less than an hour with me, and she was already trying to break down every iota of self-confidence that I had. Why was she punishing me? What had I done to her?

“Is this because I picked the love seat?” I asked.

“What?” Dr. Cohen scanned the room.

“The chair. Is it, like, a test?” I asked, growing frustrated.

“I assure you the chairs in this room are merely chosen for comfort. They are not a litmus test of any kind.”

I didn’t believe her. I bet the love seat was the most selfish option. I needed to get out of this office. I looked at her notebook, which contained all the secrets I had just told her. I wanted to snatch it out of her hands and light it on fire using the small candle on the table. Maybe I would burn the whole building down with it. Maybe she would still be inside. As if sensing my violent thoughts, Dr. Cohen cleared her throat.

“I can tell you’re quite upset. And I apologize for making you feel that way. I know that was a lot of honesty for our first time working together, and scaring you wasn’t my intention. I do think we could do some good work here, Lillian,” she said. “I really do.”

“What do you do with those notes?” I asked.

“They’re for my own records. That’s all.”

“Well, I don’t think this is going to work out,” I said. “Did you even go to school for this? Or was it, like, some online-degree bullshit?” I questioned, not caring what the actual answer was. “Maybe you’re unhappy in your own life so you pick on pretty younger women so you can feel better about yourself. You have that power complex, huh?” I spat.

“I understand you’re frustrated—”

“I’m fine, actually. I’m just worried about your other clients who might actually trust your opinion. Though you managed to get me in quickly, so maybe business is bad?”

Dr. Cohen didn’t argue with me but let me continue talking. I told her that her shoes were ugly and she had overgrown chin hair. I told her that the color of her walls was hideous and all the therapy books on the planet wouldn’t make her good at her job. I told her that she should stop drinking coffee because her teeth were getting yellow. I told her that no self-respecting adult would take advice from someone with her haircut and she needed Botox, but it was also probably too late for it to help her.

“I think that’s our time. If you want to keep working together, we can talk about how you just lashed out at me in our next session,” Dr. Cohen said calmly.

I wanted to punch her in her smug face. I hated her. And I hated Hector for giving me her contact information. I felt traumatized and misunderstood, like I needed a new therapist to recover from this one.

“You should be reported to the board of therapists,” I said, unsure if this was a thing that existed.

“Okay,” she said tiredly.

I stormed out without paying.

In the waiting room, a middle-aged man was sitting in the chair picking lint off his pants, killing time before his session. He looked at me, startled to see me barreling through the sacred waiting space. I must have looked like a wild animal, because he crossed his arms instinctively, as if to protect his internal organs.

“She’s full of shit,” I said. “I would save your money.”

I slammed the door shut.

CHAPTER THIRTY

I TOOK THE TRAIN HOME in a fugue state. I tapped my CharlieCard and waited for the correct train, making my way back to my apartment on pure muscle memory. I knew that if I let myself be present during my commute, I would throw myself—or someone else—onto the train tracks. Was the third rail still a thing? If so, I pictured dangling Dr. Cohen's body above it.

When I got home, I found Dr. Cohen's therapist profile on BetterHelp, Psychology Today, and Zocdoc and left scathing reviews for her on all platforms. I found her practice listed on Yelp and left one there, too. I didn't use my real name, of course, but she would undoubtedly know that it was me:

Posted by PickleGirl20 on February 27, 2025

I went to see Dr. Cohen after my partner's untimely death. I was incredibly raw going into my session, hoping for the help of a professional to find some peace in the wake of my devastation. Dr. Cohen was cruel and verbally abused me to the point that I felt physically threatened by her. I'm not sure why she targeted me in this way—maybe she does it to all her patients, maybe she had a bad day. Regardless, she was one of the most sinister people I have ever come across in my life. Now I have to deal with the deep grief of losing someone I loved, along with the PTSD I have from this terrible session. Please avoid seeing this woman at all costs. She is a spiteful, scary person. STAY FAR AWAY.

I hit send, and my phone rang immediately after. I jumped at the timing: Had Dr. Cohen found my review already? Would she sue me for slander?

Would Hector defend her?

My chest deflated with relief when I realized it was just Jamie.

I answered. “Hey, what’s up?”

“Can we meet?” Jamie asked, anxiety coating her voice.

I considered all the ways in which I was walking into another trap by saying yes. Jamie would want to discuss the kiss and her credit card charges from the lawyer, which she had surely seen by now. It would be a sticky conversation—one that required quite a bit of patience on my end. I wasn’t sure if I had the bandwidth to be even a little generous with my friend after my session with Dr. Cohen. Maybe it would be best to avoid Jamie for a little longer, give her feelings more time to dilute. On the other hand, I didn’t know what I would do with the rest of my day other than drink myself into oblivion. Which would feel nice, but was also a little boring to do alone; I always operated best when I had a captive audience. Perhaps I could be the bigger person and give a vague non-apology like “I’m sorry you felt that way” if Jamie confronted me for leading her on. Or maybe she wanted to apologize to me for her own romantic delusions. They were, after all, inappropriate. The only way to find out her intention would be to go.

I named a bar where we could meet that was exactly one minute and twenty seconds from my house. I waited for Jamie to pitch someplace that was more of a midpoint between us so she could pretend she had a backbone, but she didn’t. She told me she’d see me there in an hour. That gave me just enough time to make myself look more attractive so Jamie would be easily influenced.

I arrived at the bar five minutes after Jamie and I were supposed to meet, hoping she would extend the olive branch of buying me a drink to greet me upon arrival. When I walked in, I spotted her sitting in a wooden booth, exactly zero drinks in front of her. I sighed and walked over to the bar. I wasn’t doing this clearheaded. I ordered myself a glass of wine and a shot of vodka and brought them over to the table. Jamie could get her own.

“Hi,” Jamie said tightly, like we were exes meeting for divorce mediation.

“Are you going to get anything to drink?” I asked.

“Um, no, I’m good,” she said.

Her abstaining from alcohol felt like a nonverbal judgment. I threw back my shot quickly, not liking how the two glasses looked next to each other on the table. The booze stung my throat on the way down, sending a little burst of adrenaline through me. I needed to get the worst part over with and acknowledge the kiss.

“If this is about the other night, I’m sorry if your feelings got hurt. I thought it would be fun to make out and get my mind off things for a little, but I understand that you have deeper feelings for me, which I know is probably really difficult for you,” I said.

Jamie shifted in her seat. I took this as permission to keep going.

“I’ll be honest, I see the way you look at me. And I get that it was probably confusing for me to give some attention back to you, but I think it’s better if we just remain friends. I don’t see you as more than that, sadly...I wish I did,” I said.

I was impressed with myself. I hadn’t planned on being so kind and articulate. I wondered what Dr. Cohen would think if she could see me now. I took responsibility for my actions. I was an emotionally mature, considerate person. She didn’t know jack shit about what I was capable of. Jamie took a deep breath and stood up from the booth.

“Actually, I think I will get a drink.” She walked toward the bar.

I had let Jamie down as easily as I possibly could, but I understood if she needed to drown her troubles a little. It couldn’t be nice to hear that I didn’t love her back. After a few minutes, she returned with a rum and Coke, and sat back down.

“So, the kiss thing is fine. I was hurt at first, but the more I think about it, the more I know that it doesn’t make sense for us to get involved romantically. It was probably a bad idea.” Jamie paused. “I’ve had a crush on you for a while and I’ve clearly done a bad job hiding that, so, yes, it was a little confusing for me. And yeah, I did want to talk about it. I didn’t like that you pretended it didn’t happen. But I agree it shouldn’t happen again.”

I saw now that she was going to do the self-preservation thing where she acted like it was her idea to set the boundary, not mine. That was fine. I could play along with that if she needed me to.

“I obviously think you’re pretty, and it was fun, but I agree that it would be a terrible idea to date. We’re very different people,” she said.

Her suggestion that we were “very different” seemed to imply that she was better than me in some way. Why was Jamie attempting to lasso the power away from me?

“But that’s actually not what I needed to talk to you about,” she followed up. “I just got the credit card charge for the lawyer.”

So that’s what this theatrical meeting was about: She was pissed about the money. Was she going to try and weasel her way out of paying? I didn’t have the bandwidth to deal with this today, nor would I entertain the idea of ever reimbursing her. Plus, I was actually on a budget now that my only source of income had been eliminated. She had offered me this kindness; she couldn’t take it back.

“It actually came out cheaper than I expected,” I said, trying to convince her that a normal amount of money had been charged to her account.

“So, it’s not just that...” Jamie swallowed. “I noticed a few other charges on my card.”

Had Hector overcharged her for something? Was he running a scam? I imagined him and his secret lover, Dr. Cohen, sitting in her office and laughing as they booked tickets for a cruise to the Caribbean with an alcohol package included. I was thankful it wasn’t my money, but I found myself mad at Hector on Jamie’s behalf.

“Do you want me to call Hector?” I asked.

“Um, no. Is my credit card linked to your Uber account?” Jamie asked, her eyes searching mine.

I had forgotten about that.

A few months ago, I had used Jamie’s credit card to call her an Uber after her phone died at my place. I guess I had never removed the payment information and was still using it. Was she seriously annoyed about that? It

was, what...a couple hundred bucks over six months? I tried to remember if I had taken any substantial rides, but couldn't think of anything too damning.

"I didn't realize it was still linked. Sorry," I said, trying to be generous with my apologies today.

"Well, there was a ride that I was charged for that was kind of weird," Jamie said. She took a long sip of her drink.

"Okay. I can pay you back, whatever."

Why was she being so stingy?

"The night Henry died," she continued, "there was a charge for \$43.70."

My stomach flipped. I had sent my credit card charges to Hector to prove my innocence, but I hadn't considered the possibility that Jamie's card, not mine, had been linked to my Uber account.

"Can you check your ride history on the app? See if you went somewhere that night?" Jamie asked. She was tapping her fingers nervously against her glass.

"Of course," I said.

I pulled my phone out of my pocket, glad to be sitting on the opposite side of the booth from her. I pretended to click through my device, doing my best to steady my shaking hands so she wouldn't clock them. I clicked around my phone, opening and closing random apps. I didn't want to actually look at my account while I was in front of her. I worried that if I saw something I wasn't ready to see, my face would give it away.

"Oh...I took a ride the night before for that amount. It must have charged you late," I said with as much confidence as I could muster.

Jamie exhaled, and her shoulders slackened with relief.

"Oh. Okay...That makes sense," she breathed. "Can I see?"

I stiffened. "What?"

"Can I just...see the charge?" Jamie asked, her face coated with sudden anxiety again.

I laughed, trying to lighten the mood. "What are you...a jealous boyfriend?"

“I just want peace of mind, I guess.” She extended her hand, reaching for my phone.

I shoved my phone into my purse. “You’re being insane. I’m not going to have you rummage through my phone like a toxic ex.”

“It would make me feel better,” she pleaded. “Please.”

“I’ll unlink your card. Relax,” I said.

Jamie looked at me, considering how much further she wanted to push this. I could feel sweat pooling in my palms and my blood pressure rising steadily.

“The police closed the case anyway,” I said. “Didn’t you see? It’s over.”

Jamie knitted her eyebrows. “What? No. Who was it?”

“Some homeless guy. I guess he’s on, like, a violent rampage,” I explained, exaggerating the extent of the rock-throwing criminal’s wrongdoings.

“Oh,” Jamie said. “That’s horrible.” She still looked skeptical.

We sat in relative silence, sipping our drinks. Jamie was drinking hers quickly. I wondered if we would order another and she would stick around for a bit. I had no desire to go home and open up the potential bomb that was ticking inside my phone. I waited for Jamie to make casual conversation, but she didn’t.

“I should get going,” she finally said.

I wanted to stop her from leaving. I wanted to tell her to sit back down, maybe even on the same side of the booth as me. I wanted to handcuff us together until she was nice to me again. I wanted to tell her that she wasn’t allowed to bail when things got difficult. I worried that maybe she didn’t believe me. Did she want to get away from me because she thought I was a violent person? I knew at my core I wasn’t remotely vicious, but Jamie’s desire to flee made me want to put her in a jar and keep her in a basement, shining a light on her at all hours so she never slept again. I wanted to shake the jar until she was on the brink of death and then be the one to save her from it at the last moment so she would love me again.

Jamie stood up.

“Wait,” I said, surprising both of us. “Are you sure you don’t want to hang out?”

Jamie looked at me. For the first time, I saw in her face the same expression every child in my class had had at the zoo the day I pushed Melanie Frank into the gorilla pen. There was no benefit of the doubt. There were no residual feelings. Her viewpoint had shifted.

“I’ll see you later, Lillian.”

And then she walked out.

My heart was pounding. I wondered if I could have a heart attack from how fast it was beating. I put my hand over my chest and felt it thumpthumpthump like there was a little creature inside me trying to break free. I attempted to slow my breathing, but every breath I took my body ate up and burned through like oil. Once she was out of my view, I opened my Uber app.

Thumpthumpthump.

I clicked on “Ride History.”

Thumpthumpthump.

I scrolled to the date of Henry’s murder.

Thumpthumpthump.

Thumpthumpthump.

Thumpthumpthump.

There it was.

Thumpthumpthump.

At 2:03 a.m. the night of Henry’s murder, I took an Uber from my apartment to an approximate location in Somerville, near the bar Henry was killed at.

A wave of surprise ran through my body like an electric shock. Every inch of me was pulsing. What did this mean? What had I done there? Did I talk to Henry? Did we fight? Did we fuck? Did he hurt me? Did I hurt him?

With shaking hands, I deleted my account.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

I GOT DRUNK FOR TWO days straight after seeing the Uber charge. I went through everything I had in my house: wine, vodka, peppermint schnapps, and a box of Franzia. When I ran out of alcohol, I went to the corner store and stocked up on more. My hangovers began to bleed into each other, only dulled by more booze and greasy take-out food. I instructed the delivery people to leave my food at the door, like they were dropping off sustenance to a prisoner. When they left, I would scurry out and grab my bounty like a tipsy and less dexterous rat. I knew my drinking had become problematic, maybe even the kind of bingeing that killed a person, but I couldn't stop. When I was drunk, I could exist in a suspended plane in between reality and sleeping. When I was sober, I was forced to reckon with what this cursed Uber trip might mean.

I researched Ambien and its effects on your memory. I learned via Reddit that Ambien blackouts were quite common, especially when mixed with alcohol. A woman on one thread said that she cheated on her husband while on it, and that the drug had destroyed her marriage and thus her life. There were endless stories about disloyalty, fighting, stalking, fucking, forgetting to pick up kids at school, and a variety of other Very Bad Things. No one mentioned they had murdered someone on it, though.

I googled "Ambien murder" in a private browser on my laptop and saw that a decent amount of people had indeed committed homicide on the pill, claiming involuntary intoxication as a defense if they were caught for their crime. One man had driven his car to his boss's house and shot him in cold blood. Camera footage showed the man honoring every single stoplight on his way to take someone's life.

In my core, I knew I wasn't a murderer. Maybe I stepped on spiders when I saw them rather than taking them outside, but I wasn't capable of

harming anything larger than a bug. And I had liked Henry—probably loved him, even. I wouldn't have ended his life under any circumstances. I considered what prison would be like for someone like me. Surely upon my arrival, a gaggle of lesbians would be fighting for possession of me as a lover. I would inevitably have to shack up with one of them for protection, maybe even growing to love her. I would get into really good shape, probably the best of my life. Maybe I would pick up religion again, just to have something to believe in while I was forced to shit in front of my cellmate. I would probably garner the attention of a few admirers on the outside, too. People would send me letters en masse, drawn to me either by their belief in my innocence or by their belief in my guilt, like Gypsy Rose Blanchard. I would be forced to leave behind people from my life “before”: Hector, Jamie, Nora, maybe even my mother. I would have to exist in a new subculture of people who were okay with the kind of criminal I was accused of being. It would be difficult, but eventually, I would be loved and even accepted in my new community. When I got out, maybe they would make a prestige scripted television show about me. I would be played by a beautiful actress who would take me as her date to the Emmys and make a speech about how misunderstood I had been. It would take time, but I would get my public redemption. Nora would call me from her house in the suburbs while two sticky kids screamed in the background and say she was happy to see that I was doing so well. I would realize, even though I had spent a good chunk of my life in prison, I was still doing better than her.

Or maybe jail would be awful. Maybe I would be constantly harassed and the food would taste like Styrofoam with a dash of MSG. I would have to assimilate myself with my fellow whites for protection, rubbing elbows with neo-Nazis and white supremacists. My mother would disown me, and Hector would give an interview on *60 Minutes* about how he had always suspected I was guilty. Elise would write a Twitter thread about sleeping twenty feet away from a killer, and people would praise her for her “bravery,” though she had done nothing but fall asleep with crusty earplugs in. I wouldn't get let out early on probation, and I would waste my hottest years inside a jail cell with little fanfare.

Knowing how badly being honest could go, I couldn't risk telling anyone about the Uber charge. I wasn't a murderer anyway. There was no reason for me to ruin my life over one stupid late-night escapade. Maybe it didn't matter what had actually happened that night. I wondered if Jamie would ever question this charge again. We were growing apart as friends anyway. Maybe our friendship had run its course. Maybe it was time for me to start a new chapter and reinvent myself altogether. I could change apartments and find new friends. I considered leaving Boston and wondered what other cities I might still be rated above a seven in. Maybe Chicago? Definitely Detroit, but I wasn't that desperate yet.

For now, getting out of my apartment felt like the best temporary solution. The space had seemed to possess a toxic energy since the hex. I texted my mother and asked her to make up my bed. Within thirty seconds, she answered:

OF COURSE
U ARE ALWAYS WELCOME

DESPITE LIVING IN Arlington, Massachusetts, a town that was at least ten miles away from a decent beach, my mother's home was inexplicably beach themed. She had the following signs inside her home in various locations:

No shirt, no shoes, still problems.
Life's a beach, bitch!
While Sally sells seashells, I'm trying to relax!
Everything's better with a mai tai.
I'm on Island Time.
It's always 5 o'clock in this house!
Más margaritas, por favor!

I stared at my least favorite painting of a whale while my mother sat across from me with a concerned look on her face. The entire house had the distinct smell of my childhood: a mix of vanilla and probably some mold. My mother was unabashedly concerned after seeing me. I had gained about six pounds during my weeklong bender, and I hadn't been sleeping. Seeing myself through my mother's judgmental eyes was jarring. I realized I looked like someone who had just gotten off of a twenty-three-hour plane ride with a shit ton of turbulence; maybe one of the doors had even come off mid-flight.

"Have you been taking care of yourself, honey?" she asked, her eyes oozing concern.

"Of course," I lied.

I didn't tell her that I thought my blood was still ninety percent Smirnoff and my colon was hanging on by a thread. I didn't tell her that no matter how many times I washed my face, my pores filled back up with grease and sweat just seconds later. I didn't tell her that I felt like I was somewhere between asleep and awake at all times.

"And everything's okay at work?" She pursed her lips.

At some point, I would have to tell my mother that I had lost my job, but today wasn't the day to break that news.

"Yeah. Work's fine. It's work," I said nonchalantly.

"And you've been eating well?" She glanced at my stomach in that way boomer mothers couldn't help but do. I made a useless effort to suck some air in and conceal the fat in my organs. It was this kind of comment that gave me an eating disorder at fourteen. Thankfully, I was too lazy to pick that back up as an adult.

"Yeah. I'm nourishing myself," I said, co-opting language I had heard someone use on a podcast.

"Well, why don't you shower and put your stuff down," my mother suggested. "I'll make us something to eat."

"Okay," I said, relieved to have someone tell me what I needed to do to fix myself.

I put my overnight bag in my childhood bedroom, which my mother hadn't touched since I moved out, per my explicit orders. She once put a walking pad in there in an attempt to make it a workout room and I cried. I was twenty-three at the time. Now she knew better than to make any more changes without my consent. My room was painted dark pink, a decision I had made in high school and have been forced to stand by since. There were framed photos of my graduation and various monumental events. Many photos featured old high school friends who hadn't yet decided to abandon me like I was the runt of the litter.

After my shower, I felt and looked incrementally better. My hair was clean, and my skin was temporarily shine-free after I had scrubbed it with the cheap St. Ives face wash that my mother kept in the shower. When I emerged from the bathroom and met my mother in the living room, she was watching *Yellowstone* and had made us each a chicken Caesar salad.

She gave me a once-over. "You look a little better."

My mother motioned for me to sit down next to her and kept playing her show, explaining to me which character was fucking which, and who was a good cowboy, a bad cowboy, or a mediocre one. I found myself quickly wrapped up in these rugged hot people's dramas, despite having never seen the show before. I learned that murder was a frequent occurrence on this ranch and rethought my mother's position on the subject. When an episode ended, I decided to make myself a drink.

"Make me one, too," my mother said, happy to have an excuse to drink on a weekday.

The next episode started. I sipped my whiskey, letting it warm me. Twenty minutes into the episode, I felt my body start to relax from the alcohol.

I wondered if there was any scenario in which I could be fully honest with my mother. Would she understand about the hex? About the late-night Uber trip? Would she forgive me if I had actually done something more than both of those things? I wanted to think that no matter what had happened, she would still be on my side. But even if I told her and she reacted well, there would still be a small part of her that saw me differently.

Maybe she would tense every time I held a knife when we cooked together, or suggest I go on medication. Even if she still loved me, there would be an inevitable shift, a moving of the earth beneath us that would change the position of the ground we stood on.

“Was I a weird kid?” I asked my mom.

My mother paused the show, irked by the interruption. “Why?”

“I don’t know,” I said, wounded that her answer hadn’t immediately been “no.”

After a pause, she settled on answering with, “You marched to the beat of your own drum.”

“How?”

“Well, I don’t know. You got in trouble sometimes. You did things that people didn’t understand.” She looked at the wall like it was a portal to the past. “I think you got that from your dad.” She squirmed in her seat, clearly antsy to change the subject.

“How can you say that I got it from Dad? You didn’t even really know him.”

My mom took a big sip of her drink. “Well, I knew him a little. You met him one time.”

“What?” She had never shared this with me before. “When did I meet him?”

“Oh, you were just a toddler. He decided he wanted to meet you when he was in the area one time. He wanted to see what you were like. It didn’t go well, though,” she laughed.

“Why? What happened?” I was desperate for more information.

“He was a deadbeat. I think he wanted to check if we had money.” She motioned to the living room. “Which clearly we didn’t.”

“So, he left?” I asked.

She nodded. “He stayed for about twenty minutes.”

I sat with that fact: My father had decided I wasn’t worth knowing after only twenty minutes.

“Did I ever...hurt anyone or anything when I was a kid?” I asked, hugging the pillow in my lap.

“Well, there was that girl Melanie,” my mom sighed. “The whole zoo debacle.”

“But she was fine,” I insisted. “I didn’t really hurt her.”

“You did push her, though. Your teacher wanted me to take you to a shrink after that. Everyone was very upset about the whole thing.”

I remembered my mother had toyed with the idea of bringing me to a therapist a few times as a child: once after the zoo incident, the other time when I was about eight. While playing outside, I had convinced a three-year-old neighbor to walk into the woods and hide from his parents as a joke. The child ended up taking my direction too well and went missing until nightfall. When he was finally found, he pointed to me, rattling me out in broken toddler garble. After that, my mother suggested I see a psychologist. I agreed to go, but after my mother looked up the cost of a session, she decided that I was actually okay.

I thought back to the day after the zoo incident. When we got home, my mother had told me to go to my room and think about what I had done. As a child, I’d found myself thrilled when she pretended that she was a mother who disciplined me and I a kid who listened. It was like we were cosplaying a normal family, except the dad was always out buying milk. I didn’t usually suffer repercussions for my actions back then. My mom didn’t have the energy to follow through on punishment. At five years old, I had carved my name into my mother’s car with a rock and was sent to time-out, only to be released minutes later so we could watch *Friends* together. It was just the two of us in our house—she couldn’t afford to make me her enemy.

“But I never really hurt anyone, right?” I pushed.

“No.” My mother glanced at the television, desperate to get back to it. “Why are you asking me this anyway?”

I swallowed. I’d already told my mother Henry’s case was closed, but this was my opportunity to tell her what I had—or *potentially* had—done. This was my chance to look into the eyes of the person who made me and ask her the question that had been playing in my mind since Jamie had told me about the Uber charge: Was I capable of this?

“So, the Henry thing...It turns out I went out that night after all...” I started. My hands were shaking. “...I took an Ambien that night to sleep, so I didn’t remember.”

My mother’s head swiveled to face me. “Since when do you take Ambien? You don’t do drugs.”

“I just needed help sleeping,” I said. “I don’t ‘do drugs.’ But technically, I wasn’t home when he died, I guess.”

My mother looked at the television again, waiting for one of her cowboys to jump off the screen and save her. “Okay. So, you went out? That’s fine.”

“Well, I went to the neighborhood that he was killed in.”

My heart was beating faster now. My mother took a sip of her drink.

“I’m worried that I might have done something...” I started.

“That’s enough, Lillian,” my mother spat suddenly.

I tensed in my seat. I wasn’t used to my mother raising her voice with me. She rarely did it when I was a child, never mind dared to do it when I was an adult. It was a shock to the system.

“You know, I thought you came home to spend some time with me. I thought you wanted to have quality time with your mother. You barely call, and now you’re here and all you can do is talk about this Henry thing. It’s done. He’s gone. You need to get over it. Move on with your life,” she said. “And for the love of God, stop talking about it.”

I stayed quiet, frozen by her response.

“You should get some sage or something. I think I have some I can give you. And my friend Jennie just got certified in Reiki. Maybe she can help you get over this thing. Though I would spare her the details,” she added.

My mother’s message was clear: She didn’t want to know what might have happened that night. Could I blame her? I didn’t, either. But I was burdened with what might have been, and I would have to remain alone in that burden. I couldn’t tell a lawyer, or a therapist, or Jamie—or even my own mother. I had to keep lying for others. I had to be the version of myself that everyone was most comfortable with, no matter the toll it took on me.

I had to keep playing the part.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

I SAT ON THE TRAIN with a small cluster of sage in my hand on my way back from my mother's house. The train ride from Arlington to Mission Hill usually took a little over an hour. As I sat with my belongings, my eyelids began to feel impossibly heavy. I had been awake all of the previous night, tossing and turning—riddled with the kind of unshakable adrenaline an Olympic athlete might have before leaving their starting blocks. I had debated crawling into my mother's bed and sleeping at her feet like a dog, a habit I had as a child up until the age of twelve, when she told me I was too old to act that way anymore. Ultimately, I opted to stay in my own bed, not sure where I stood with even my own mother anymore.

As the train lurched forward, I drifted in and out of consciousness, my head bobbing up and down. I hoped I wouldn't see anyone I knew. I probably looked like a Southie addict on their way to the methadone clinic for their daily fix.

"Central," the train conductor said in a thick accent through the speaker. Eventually, I couldn't fight any longer. I was pulled under by sleep.

I'M SWAYING IN the back of an Uber. My body feels unsteady, a little underwater. I stare out the window and wish that Vanessa Carlton's "A Thousand Miles" were playing. I ask the Uber driver if I can plug my phone in to play it, but he pretends that he can't hear me. I ask again.

I can't make out the language this song is in. Maybe it's Russian?

"Can I plug my iPhone in?" I ask again.

"Fine," a gruff voice says.

I realize I left my phone at home anyway. Oh well.

* * *

Rosary beads dangle from his rearview mirror. I make eye contact with the driver. I wonder if he thinks I'm the devil. I wonder if I am the devil. What am I doing? What is my plan?

* * *

The back window is opened. The driver is trying to keep me awake. I realize that he could rape me, but I push the thought out of my head, fearing my own power of manifestation. I might throw up.

"Don't throw up," the driver begs.

* * *

I'm wearing thin pajama pants and a long-sleeve shirt with UGG slippers outside of the bar. It's not my best going-out outfit. A homeless woman walks by me and nods like, *Welcome to the neighborhood, comrade.*

* * *

I lean against a wall and fall asleep for a minute.

* * *

I wake up and remember I have a reason for being here.

* * *

I'm glad I remembered to bring my ID. The bouncer looks at my picture for a long time. Maybe he wants to fuck me.

"I have a boyfriend," I say. "He's inside."

* * *

I go to the bathroom without looking at anyone.

* * *

In the bathroom mirror, I see a stranger staring back at me. I think she's ugly until I realize we share the same face. Maybe it's just bad lighting. I raise my eyebrows up and down to make sure I'm still alive. I think I am.

* * *

I have brought a big handbag. I don't look at what's inside of it, but I know it has everything I need.

* * *

I sit down on the toilet and fall asleep for a minute. Maybe a few minutes.

* * *

I stand up too quickly and pee on my leg a little.

* * *

"How long are you going to be?" a bitchy girl's voice asks me. "Someone's in here," I say. Why is it so embarrassing to use the bathroom?

* * *

"You're a fucking stalker," he says. I guess we're in a fight.

* * *

Henry stops yelling at me when a group of men walk by. I give the men a forlorn expression that says, *My boyfriend hits me*, but they keep walking. I guess chivalry really is dead.

* * *

I'm following Henry home. I need to talk to him. I can't let him go home before we speak.

* * *

Henry's drunk, too. He wobbles down the street, trying to get away from me. Maybe I am stalking him. He looks like a helpless little creature from behind. I run after him.

"I want to talk," I say in a slurred voice that doesn't sound like my own.

* * *

"You're crazy," Henry says. He's facing me now. Finally, we're speaking. But he doesn't want to listen. I need to make him listen.

* * *

I remember why I brought my bag. I pull out the Important Thing that I packed. I don't want to use it. I just want to scare him, teach him a lesson. I want him to feel how I felt. I want him to understand that it's actually very scary when you're not in control of your own body.

* * *

I don't really want to hurt him. But he's not listening again. Maybe he doesn't care what I have to say. Maybe he never did. Maybe I was always just a body. Maybe I was never a person inside.

* * *

Flesh is actually kind of soft until you hit the bone.

* * *

There's a lot of blood in the body. There is way more than they show in the movies.

* * *

I tell Henry that he's going to be okay.

* * *

I didn't bring my phone to call anyone. I don't use his.

* * *

"Shhh." I hold his face as he falls asleep. He looks harmless when he's sleeping. But I know what he's capable of.

* * *

It actually feels very good to have the last word.

* * *

Adrenaline blocks out the cold.

* * *

I am a fast walker.

* * *

No one preys on you if you are the monster.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

MY BLOOD PRESSURE WAS ELEVATED the moment I got off the train. When I arrived home, I took my mother's advice and frantically saged my apartment. I'd read online that dark energy could come from all sorts of sources. Some people picked it up at work, bringing home the bad karma like a nasty case of head lice in preschool. Other times, a traumatic event occurred in a space that caused bad energy to linger there, seeping into the walls and finding its way into the cracks of your floorboards. Sometimes humans carried darkness inside them, like a drug mule. I assumed that was the case for me, that I had become an unknown host—a magnet that attracted bad luck. That darkness was haunting me, seeping into my brain and convincing me I might be a person who I was not. I needed to get rid of it.

I lit the sage and walked every inch of my apartment, a defined cloud of gray smoke following me. People online said that as you burned the herb, it was helpful to think about the bad energy as baggage you could pack up and send away. I imagined Henry kissing me and put it in a toiletry bag. I imagined waking up next to Nora and put it in a weekend carry-on. I remembered the breakup conversation and put that in a roller backpack. I thought of Hector asking if I had killed Henry, and I put it in the side compartments of my suitcase, where I normally kept my underwear. The kiss with Jamie went into small shampoo bottles. The therapy session was packed and wrapped tightly into an overnight parcel. Pushing Melanie Frank went into a shoebox.

Then I thought of what Henry had done to me.

I thought of my face pressing into the mattress. I thought about how I had wondered what the thread count of his sheets was. I thought of staring at a painting on his wall of three fishes, art that I now knew Nora had likely

picked out for them. I thought about how the third fish looked like it couldn't breathe. I thought about inhaling and exhaling. I thought about how, in that moment, I had gone to every crevice and corner in my brain except the one that was in that room in my own body.

I put that memory into a Pelican case and locked it shut.

Another recollection then bubbled to the surface, also begging me to get rid of it. I inhaled the sage, imagining it entering my lungs, taking root in my body, and cleansing every crevice it touched.

I saw myself putting a knife into Henry's body. My stomach turned as I pictured the life leaving his eyes and the strength it took for my arm to break through his skin, and then his muscle, until I finally hit bone. I thought of the Uber ride there and the brisk walk back.

I put that memory into a coffin.

I lowered that coffin deep down into the earth.

I watched the sage smoke twirl, dancing in the air like it was finally free. I allowed my thoughts to dance freely with it.

Maybe I had done it.

Maybe I had killed Henry.

Maybe I wasn't a bad person because I did one bad thing. Maybe Henry deserved it. Maybe I was protecting others, ridding the world of a man who didn't always hear you when you said the word "no." Maybe I had saved Nora from a life of infidelity, too. Maybe I had saved us both. And I had spared women from a man who pretended to be docile, who read books in bars and talked about climate change and postured as caring and thoughtful; a man who gave you just enough, but never close to enough. A man who only saw certain women as full human beings, and who saw others as bodies to fill. A man who made you feel like you could be robbed of something even when you carried nothing. Maybe I had found Henry out, seen him for what he truly was. And maybe I had been forced to eradicate him like the invasive species he was because of it. Perhaps what I had done was actually quite brave, when you thought about it.

I let my apartment fill with smoke. Soon I could barely see my hand in front of me. When I started to grow dizzy, I finally opened a window. After

a little while, the smoke cleared. The apartment smelled pungent and heavy, like wet moss and earth. I lit palo santo next, this time thinking of the good memories I wanted to fill the space with. I thought of getting a new job where I was appreciated. I thought of starting fresh and making the right first impression on my new coworkers. I thought of being asked out to drinks and invited to people's weddings. I thought of making friends who I saw more than once a month. I thought of Jamie forgetting about the Uber charge. I thought of becoming acquaintances with Nora and commenting on each other's Instagrams: "Stunning!" I thought of meeting someone who really liked me. Of having great sex with this person and then our relationship turning into something boring and kind, where we mostly just watched television. I thought of lying in bed and talking and not having to wax every hair off my asshole to be loved. I thought of being myself in front of someone and not being worried that it was a bad thing.

I thought of never having met Henry.

I kept burning the small stick of wood, enjoying the fragrance that slowly started to mask the sage smell, then walked into my bedroom, where I was abruptly hit with a deep sense of déjà vu. I felt like I had looked at my room from exactly this angle before, in exactly this way.

A chill vibrated down my body from the top of my head to the base of my spine.

Then I remembered where I had put it.

Slowly, I walked over to my bed. I hadn't changed the sheets in well over a month. I knew that you were supposed to wash them at least every two weeks, but I only did it when something visibly stained the linens. I made a mental note to clean them soon. My bed was pressed up against the wall. I stared at the mattress, like Henry's ghost might rise out of it.

Gently, I nudged the bed away from my window.

Thud.

Something hit the floor.

I climbed on top of my mattress and peered over to the other side of the bed.

A bloody knife looked back at me.

Fuck.

I was afraid to touch it. Maybe what that blade had done was totally separate from me as a person, a one-off event carried out by a forced hand. I worried that if I touched it, we would fully merge—blurring the line between me and the murderer. I swallowed, trying to summon some saliva into my mouth and courage into my body.

With two fingers, I picked it up.

I hurried into the bathroom and dropped the knife into the sink, running water over it, as if I could melt the metal if I just got the temperature hot enough. I watched a speck of dried blood turn from burnt brown to bright red while it drained down the sink. My heart was pumping with such force that I could feel the vibration of it against my breastbone.

I looked at the toilet.

A wave of recognition washed over me.

Right.

That was where I put that.

I opened the lid of the tank and found a T-shirt inside, stained orange red in certain spots. I took a deep breath and placed the lid back onto the tank.

So, that was why my toilet had been acting up.

There was a knock at my door.

My heart thumped angrily, pulsing in my throat.

I looked at myself in the mirror. I didn't look my best. My eyes were a little droopy, and my complexion hyperpigmented. I stared into my pupils, searching for the person I knew.

I was still her, right?

Another knock.

Perhaps it was my landlord. Had I forgotten to pay rent? Elise was always so good at that stuff.

I walked out into the living room and peered through the peephole of the front door. Jamie stood on the other side. Elation and relief washed over me. I knew she would come around. I knew she would miss me eventually.

Without thinking, I opened up the door. “Hi,” I said, like Harry when he sees Sally after all that time has passed.

“Hi.” She looked tired. “Can I come in?”

I hesitated, which Jamie took as permission to enter.

Once inside, she began pacing back and forth in the living room, looking around the apartment like a bat that had accidentally flown inside. I quickly walked over to my bathroom door, which adjoined to my bedroom, and closed it.

“What’s up?” I crossed my arms protectively.

“Can I please see the Uber trip?”

So, this was why she had come. She didn’t want to rekindle our friendship. She wanted proof.

“I deleted the app,” I said.

Jamie stiffened. “Why?”

“I don’t know. I wasn’t using it.”

Jamie swallowed.

“I feel anxious about everything. I know that the police connected that other person to it, but—I don’t know. I’m having trouble sleeping. I’m having panic attacks and stuff...” She trailed off, clearly hoping I would swoop in and show her my phone, erasing all her fears with one glance at my screen. “Can I please just see it?” She was almost begging.

“I couldn’t show you even if I wanted to,” I reiterated. “I’m sorry.”

Jamie bit her fingernails until one of her cuticles started bleeding.

“Did you do it, Lil?” she asked. “Did you kill him?”

There it was. Everything was out in the open now. I wondered what my face looked like. I tried to arrange it in a way that conveyed my innocence.

“Oh, come on,” I laughed.

“Lillian. I’m serious,” Jamie said with more strength than I had ever heard in her voice.

I considered whether or not I should be honest with her. I considered if I should explain that maybe I had killed Henry. Maybe it was an accident, or maybe it wasn’t. Maybe it was the best thing I had ever done. I considered if Jamie was a person who would be able to hold this knowledge

and still understand that this didn't mean I was a bad person. If she did understand, maybe we would have our happily-ever-after. Maybe I would see her in a new light. Maybe we would fall in love. Maybe I would give her what she'd always wanted, and she would give me what I'd needed all along: to be seen by someone and to still be loved.

Or maybe she would disappoint me, just like everyone else.

"Of course I didn't kill him," I said, looking at her squarely.

I took a step between Jamie and the door. I could see in her face that she was scared of me, that she knew what I had done. I thought of the knife in my bathroom sink.

"Can I make you a drink?" I asked, straightening my shoulders.

I couldn't take the risk.

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Photograph of the author by Jessica Castro

Kirsten King is a novelist and screenwriter. Kirsten lived in Boston before relocating to Los Angeles, where she currently resides with her husband and two perfect cats. She has been published in *Teen Vogue*, *BuzzFeed*, *Cosmopolitan*, *The Huffington Post*, *The New Yorker*, and more. Her feature film, *Crush*, debuted on Hulu in 2022, and she has also written for television shows like *The Second Best Hospital in the Galaxy* on Amazon Prime. *A Good Person* is her debut novel.

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